Learn Being Forward

COURSES · CAMPUS PARTNERSHIPS · PLACEMENTS

STUDY NOTES · BASIC TO ADVANCED

Verbal Reasoning
Read Well, Write Right, Reason Clearly

Complete notes for the Learn Being Forward Verbal Reasoning syllabus: grammar, vocabulary, reading, verbal reasoning and written and spoken English, explained with rules, examples and shortcut tricks, followed by basic, intermediate and advanced questions with fully worked solutions.

26	3	37	650
modules	levels	minimum days	solved questions

How to use these notes

These notes follow the **Learn Being Forward Verbal Reasoning syllabus** exactly: the same 26 modules, in the same order, with every topic and subtopic explained step by step. Each subtopic number (for example **10.2.1**) matches the syllabus, so you can always find where you are.

Level	Modules	Minimum	Outcome
1. Beginner	1 to 9	12 days	Master sentence structure, parts of speech, tenses and agreement, and build vocabulary with synonyms, antonyms, idioms and one-word substitutions
2. Intermediate	10 to 18	13 days	Spot errors, correct and complete sentences, solve cloze tests and para jumbles, read passages accurately, and handle verbal analogies, voice and narration
3. Advanced	19 to 26	12 days	Solve advanced reading comprehension and verbal critical reasoning, summarise text, master confusing words, write timed emails and essays, and clear spoken-English assessments
Total	1 to 26	37 days	About 7 weeks at 6 study days per week

1 · Understand
Learn each rule and write it in your notebook with two sentences of your own.

2 · Study the examples
Read every example sentence and note exactly why the wrong version is wrong.

3 · Solve with a timer
Attempt the basic, intermediate and advanced questions before looking at any solution.

4 · Check and log
Compare with the solutions, log every mistake by rule, and read for 20 minutes every day.

Every topic follows the same pattern: the rule in plain words, clear example sentences (correct and incorrect), tables and diagrams, and **shortcut tricks** for exam speed. Each module then gives about 25 practice questions in three levels, **basic**, **intermediate** and **advanced**, in the styles used by campus tests (TCS, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, Cognizant, Capgemini, AMCAT, eLitmus) and bank and government exams. Every question is fully solved, and every solution names the rule that decides the answer, so each mistake teaches something.

HOW TO READ THE BOXES

Gold-bordered boxes hold **shortcut tricks**, worked examples and notes, red boxes warn about common traps, and navy boxes hold the key rule to remember. In example sentences, × marks an incorrect sentence and ✓ the corrected one.

Course plan at a glance

Module	Topic	Level	Min days
01	Introduction to verbal reasoning and verbal ability	Beginner	1
02	Parts of speech and sentence structure	Beginner	1
03	Nouns, pronouns and articles	Beginner	1

Module	Topic	Level	Min days
04	Verbs and tenses	Beginner	2
05	Subject–verb agreement	Beginner	1
06	Adjectives, adverbs, prepositions and conjunctions	Beginner	1
07	Vocabulary-building strategies	Beginner	1
08	Synonyms and antonyms	Beginner	2
09	One-word substitution, idioms, phrases and phrasal verbs	Beginner	2
10	Spotting errors	Intermediate	2
11	Sentence correction and sentence improvement	Intermediate	2
12	Fill in the blanks	Intermediate	1
13	Cloze test	Intermediate	1
14	Para jumbles (sentence rearrangement)	Intermediate	2
15	Odd sentence out and paragraph completion	Intermediate	1
16	Reading comprehension basics	Intermediate	2
17	Verbal analogies, word relationships and classification	Intermediate	1
18	Voice and narration	Intermediate	1
19	Advanced reading comprehension	Advanced	2
20	Verbal critical reasoning	Advanced	1
21	Para summary and main idea	Advanced	1
22	Text completion and sentence equivalence	Advanced	1
23	Confusing words, spelling and word usage	Advanced	1
24	Written English tests: email and essay writing	Advanced	2
25	Spoken English assessments: Versant and SVAR	Advanced	2
26	Exam strategy, mock tests and company-specific preparation	Advanced	2

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LEVEL 1

Beginner level

Master sentence structure, parts of speech, tenses and agreement, and build vocabulary with synonyms, antonyms, idioms and one-word substitutions

9 MODULES · 12 DAYS MINIMUM

Module 01 · Introduction to verbal reasoning and verbal ability	1 day
Module 02 · Parts of speech and sentence structure	1 day
Module 03 · Nouns, pronouns and articles	1 day
Module 04 · Verbs and tenses	2 days
Module 05 · Subject–verb agreement	1 day
Module 06 · Adjectives, adverbs, prepositions and conjunctions	1 day
Module 07 · Vocabulary-building strategies	1 day
Module 08 · Synonyms and antonyms	2 days
Module 09 · One-word substitution, idioms, phrases and phrasal verbs	2 days

MODULE 01 · BEGINNER

Introduction to verbal reasoning and verbal ability

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

This module explains what verbal reasoning and verbal ability tests measure, why companies use them, where they are tested, the common question types and how to improve steadily. It ends with a 25-question diagnostic test covering grammar, vocabulary and reading, fully solved, so you can see where you stand before starting.

IN THIS MODULE

1.1 What is verbal reasoning?
1.2 Why do we need it?
1.3 Where is it tested?
1.4 Common question types
1.5 How to improve
1.6 Diagnostic test

1.1 What is verbal reasoning?

1.1.1 Definition: understanding, analysing and reasoning with written language

Verbal reasoning is the ability to understand written language precisely, analyse what it says and does not say, and reason correctly with it. A verbal test checks whether you can read a sentence and notice that it is grammatically wrong, choose the exact word a context needs, follow the argument of a passage, and decide what does or does not follow from it.



THE VERBAL REASONING CYCLE

1.1.2 Verbal ability vs verbal reasoning

	Verbal ability	Verbal reasoning
Tests	grammar, vocabulary, reading	logic expressed in words
Typical questions	error spotting, synonyms, fill in the blanks, cloze tests	critical reasoning, inferences, assumptions, analogies
Skill used	knowledge of English rules and words	careful thinking about meaning
Improves with	rules notebook and vocabulary practice	reading arguments and practising inference

1.1.3 How it differs from logical and non-verbal reasoning

Logical reasoning works with arrangements, codes and relations; non-verbal reasoning works with figures. Verbal reasoning works with **language**: the information is in sentences and passages, and the challenge is to read them exactly as written.

1.2 Why do we need it?

1.2.1 Clear English is essential at work

Client emails, documentation, status reports, meetings and code reviews all depend on clear, correct English. Companies test it because a single unclear sentence can cost a project time and money.

1.2.2 Verbal sections often decide shortlisting

In many campus tests, the verbal section has its own cut-off. Strong candidates in aptitude can be rejected for a weak verbal score.

1.2.3 Builds reading speed and comprehension

Every subject, every exam and every job involves reading. Faster, more accurate reading pays back in all of them.

1.3 Where is it tested?

Test	Verbal content
TCS NQT, Infosys, Wipro, Accenture, Cognizant, Capgemini, HCLTech	grammar, vocabulary, reading comprehension, sentence arrangement
AMCAT English, eLitmus verbal, CoCubes	grammar, vocabulary, comprehension, verbal reasoning
Versant, SVAR	spoken English: reading aloud, repeating, sentence building, conversation
Bank, SSC and other government exams	error spotting, cloze tests, para jumbles, comprehension
CAT VARC, GMAT, GRE, IELTS, TOEFL	advanced reading, critical reasoning, text completion, writing

1.4 Common question types

Area	Question types	Module
Grammar and error spotting	spot the error, sentence correction, fill in the blanks	2–6, 10–12
Vocabulary	synonyms, antonyms, one-word substitution, idioms	7–9, 23
Reading comprehension	passages with factual, inference and vocabulary questions	16, 19

Area	Question types	Module
Sentence arrangement and completion	para jumbles, cloze tests, odd sentence out, paragraph completion	13–15, 22
Verbal reasoning	analogies, critical reasoning, summaries	17, 20, 21
Writing and speaking	email and essay writing, Versant and SVAR	24, 25

1.5 How to improve

1.5.1 Daily reading habit

Read for 20 minutes every day: a newspaper editorial, a long-form article or a good non-fiction book. Read actively: after each paragraph, say in one sentence what it said.

1.5.2 Vocabulary notebook and spaced repetition

Write every new word with its meaning, a sentence of your own, and one synonym and antonym. Review the notebook (or a flashcard app) on a spaced schedule: after one day, three days, one week and one month.

1.5.3 Grammar rules notebook with examples

For every rule in this book, write the rule, one wrong sentence and its correction. Most error-spotting questions test the same 40 or 50 rules again and again.

> **SHORTCUT TRICK**
> Ten new words a day for seven weeks is about 500 words: enough to transform a vocabulary score.

1.6 Diagnostic test

Attempt all 25 questions in 25 minutes without help. Record your score for grammar (Q1–10), vocabulary (Q11–18) and reading and reasoning (Q19–25).

Read the passage and answer Q19 to Q22.
Remote work was once considered a perk offered by a handful of technology firms. Today many companies treat it as normal, and some have closed offices altogether. Supporters argue that employees save hours of travel each week and can work when they concentrate best. Critics reply that new employees learn more slowly when they cannot watch experienced colleagues, and that casual conversations, which often spark new ideas, become rare. Many firms have therefore settled on a hybrid model, asking staff to come in on two or three fixed days.

1.6.1 Diagnostic questions

1.6.1.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct option: She _____ to the office every day.

(a) go **(b)** going **(c)** goes **(d)** gone

Q2 Choose the correct option: Neither of the answers _____ correct.

(a) is **(b)** are **(c)** were **(d)** have been

Q3 Choose the correct article: He is _____ honest man.

(a) a **(b)** the **(c)** no article **(d)** an

Q4 Choose the correct option: I _____ here since 2020.

(a) live **(b)** have lived **(c)** am living **(d)** lived

Q5 Choose the correct pronoun: Between you and _____, the plan will fail.

(a) I **(b)** me **(c)** myself **(d)** mine

Q6 Which part of the sentence has an error? *Each of the students have submitted the assignment on time.*

(a) Each of the students **(b)** have submitted
(c) the assignment **(d)** on time

Q7 Choose the correct preposition: She is good _____ mathematics.

(a) in **(b)** on **(c)** for **(d)** at

Q8 Choose the correct option: If I _____ you, I would accept the offer.

(a) were **(b)** was **(c)** am **(d)** will be

1.6.1.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the correctly punctuated sentence.

(a) It is late, we should leave now. **(b)** It is late we should leave now.
(c) It is late; we should leave now. **(d)** It is late: and we should leave now.

Q10 Choose the correct option: The news _____ very encouraging.

(a) are **(b)** were **(c)** have been **(d)** is

Q11 Choose the synonym of ABUNDANT.

(a) scarce **(b)** plentiful **(c)** abandoned **(d)** tiny

Q12 Choose the antonym of TRANSPARENT.

(a) opaque **(b)** clear **(c)** obvious **(d)** bright

Q13 Choose the word for: a person who can speak many languages.

(a) linguist **(b)** bilingual **(c)** polyglot **(d)** orator

Q14 What does the idiom "to break the ice" mean?

(a) to start a conversation in an awkward situation
(b) to damage something valuable

(c) to win easily
(d) to reveal a secret

Q15 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) accomodate (b) accommodate (c) acommodate (d) acomodate

Q16 Choose the synonym of CANDID.

(a) secretive (b) sweet (c) careful (d) frank

1.6.1.3 Advanced level

Q17 Choose the meaning of the phrasal verb "put off".

(a) wear (b) extinguish (c) postpone (d) accept

Q18 Choose the word that best fills the blank: The manager was _____ about the delay and demanded an explanation.

(a) delighted (b) indifferent (c) furious (d) grateful

Q19 According to the passage, why did many firms adopt a hybrid model?

(a) because remote work became illegal
(b) because employees disliked travel
(c) to close all their offices
(d) to balance the benefits of remote work against its drawbacks

Q20 Which of the following is mentioned as a disadvantage of remote work?

(a) employees save travel time (b) new employees learn more slowly
(c) offices become more expensive (d) technology firms dislike it

Q21 The word "spark" in the passage is closest in meaning to

(a) trigger (b) burn (c) shine (d) stop

Q22 Which statement can be inferred from the passage?

(a) All companies have closed their offices.
(b) Remote work is more common now than it once was.
(c) Hybrid work has no disadvantages.
(d) Critics want remote work banned.

Q23 Choose the odd one out.

(a) chair (b) apple (c) mango (d) banana

Q24 Rearrange to form a sentence: P: the meeting Q: was postponed R: due to S: heavy rain

(a) QPRS (b) PRQS (c) PQRS (d) SRPQ

Q25 Book is to Library as Painting is to

(a) Artist (b) Canvas (c) Museum guide (d) Gallery

1.6.2 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) goes**

With a singular third-person subject (she) in the simple present, the verb takes -s/-es: **goes**.

Q2 **Answer: (a) is**

"Neither of" + plural noun takes a **singular** verb in formal English: neither is correct.

Q3 **Answer: (d) an**

"Honest" begins with a vowel **sound** (the h is silent), so the article is **an**.

Q4 **Answer: (b) have lived**

"Since 2020" marks an action that began in the past and continues now: present perfect, **have lived**.

Q5 **Answer: (b) me**

After a preposition (between) the object form is needed: between you and **me**.

Q6 **Answer: (b) have submitted**

"Each of" takes a singular verb: each of the students **has** submitted.

Q7 **Answer: (d) at**

The fixed expression is "good **at**" a subject or activity.

Q8 **Answer: (a) were**

In an imaginary (second) conditional, formal English uses **were** for all persons: if I were you.

Q9 **Answer: (c) It is late; we should leave now.**

Two independent clauses can be joined by a **semicolon**; a comma alone makes a comma splice.

Q10 **Answer: (d) is**

"News" is an uncountable noun and always takes a **singular** verb.

Q11 **Answer: (b) plentiful**

Abundant means existing in large quantities: plentiful. "Scarce" is its antonym.

Q12 **Answer: (a) opaque**

Transparent means letting light through; its opposite is **opaque**.

Q13 **Answer: (c) polyglot**

A **polyglot** speaks several languages. A linguist studies language; bilingual means two languages; an orator is a public speaker.

Q14 **Answer: (a) to start a conversation in an awkward situation**

"Break the ice" means to ease tension and **start a conversation**.

Q15 **Answer: (b) accommodate**

Accommodate has double c and double m.

Q16 **Answer: (d) frank**

Candid means honest and direct: frank.

Q17 **Answer: (c) postpone**

"Put off" a meeting means to **postpone** it.

Q18 **Answer: (c) furious**

Demanding an explanation shows anger: **furious**.

Q19 **Answer: (d) to balance the benefits of remote work against its drawbacks**

The passage lists advantages and disadvantages and then says firms "therefore" chose hybrid: a **compromise** between them.

Q20 **Answer: (b) new employees learn more slowly**

Critics say new employees **learn more slowly** without watching colleagues.

Q21 **Answer: (a) trigger**

Conversations that "spark new ideas" **trigger** or start them.

Q22 **Answer: (b) Remote work is more common now than it once was.**

Once a perk of "a handful" of firms, it is now "normal" for many: it is **more common**. The other options go beyond the passage.

Q23 **Answer: (a) chair**

Apple, mango and banana are fruits; **chair** is furniture.

Q24 **Answer: (c) PQRS**

"The meeting was postponed due to heavy rain": **PQRS**.

Q25 **Answer: (d) Gallery**

Books are kept and displayed in a library; paintings in a **gallery**.

Verbal tests check grammar, vocabulary, reading and reasoning with words. Read daily, keep a vocabulary notebook and a grammar rules notebook, and log every mistake by rule.

MODULE 02 · BEGINNER

Parts of speech and sentence structure

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

Grammar starts with understanding how each word works in a sentence. This module covers the eight parts of speech, words that change their part of speech, subject and predicate, objects and complements, phrases and clauses, the four functional and four structural sentence types, and the two commonest sentence errors (fragments and run-ons), followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

2.1 The eight parts of speech
2.2 Sentence structure
2.3 Types of sentences
2.4 Common sentence errors
2.5 Practice questions
2.6 Solutions

2.1 The eight parts of speech

2.1.1 Noun, pronoun, verb, adjective, adverb, preposition, conjunction, interjection

Part of speech	Job in the sentence	Examples
Noun	names a person, place, thing or idea	Riya, Delhi, laptop, honesty
Pronoun	replaces a noun	she, they, it, someone, which
Verb	shows an action or a state	write, run, is, seem
Adjective	describes a noun or pronoun	tall, three, careful, blue
Adverb	describes a verb, adjective or another adverb	quickly, very, often, here
Preposition	links a noun or pronoun to the rest of the sentence	in, on, at, under, between
Conjunction	joins words, phrases or clauses	and, but, because, although
Interjection	expresses sudden feeling	Oh!, Wow!, Alas!



EVERY WORD HAS A JOB

2.1.2 One word, different parts of speech

A word's part of speech depends on its **job in the sentence**, not on the word itself.

Word	Sentence	Part of speech
run	I **run** every morning.	verb

Word	Sentence	Part of speech
run	She went for a **run**.	noun
light	Switch on the **light**.	noun
light	This bag is **light**.	adjective
light	Please **light** the lamp.	verb
fast	He drives **fast**.	adverb
fast	It is a **fast** car.	adjective
round	He walked **round** the park.	preposition

SHORTCUT TRICK
Ask what the word is doing: naming (noun), acting (verb), describing a noun (adjective), describing an action or a quality (adverb), linking (preposition or conjunction).

2.2 Sentence structure

2.2.1 Subject and predicate

Every complete sentence has a **subject** (who or what the sentence is about) and a **predicate** (what is said about the subject; it always contains the main verb).



SUBJECT AND PREDICATE

2.2.2 Objects and complements

Element	What it does	Example
Direct object	receives the action (answers "what?" or "whom?")	She wrote **a report**.
Indirect object	the person to or for whom the action is done	She gave **her manager** the report.
Subject complement	follows a linking verb (be, seem, become) and describes the subject	He is **a developer**. She seems **tired**.
Object complement	describes the object	They elected him **captain**.

2.2.3 Phrases and clauses

A **phrase** is a group of words without its own subject–verb pair: *in the morning, a very old laptop, to finish the work*. A **clause** has a subject and a verb: *because the server crashed*.

2.2.4 Independent and dependent clauses

An **independent clause** can stand alone as a sentence. A **dependent clause** begins with a word such as *because, although, when, if, which, that, who* and cannot stand alone.



A DEPENDENT CLAUSE LEANS ON AN INDEPENDENT CLAUSE

2.3 Types of sentences

2.3.1 By function

Type	Purpose	Ends with	Example
Declarative	makes a statement	.	The meeting starts at ten.
Interrogative	asks a question	?	Has the client replied?
Imperative	gives a command or request	. or !	Please send the file.
Exclamatory	shows strong feeling	!	What a brilliant idea!

2.3.2 By structure

Type	Structure	Example
Simple	one independent clause	The server restarted.
Compound	two or more independent clauses joined by and, but, or, so, yet, or a semicolon	The server restarted, but the error remained.
Complex	one independent clause + at least one dependent clause	The error remained because the cache was full.
Compound-complex	two or more independent clauses + at least one dependent clause	When the cache filled, the server slowed, and users complained.

Simple = one independent clause. Compound = two independent clauses. Complex = independent + dependent. Compound-complex = two independent + dependent.

2.4 Common sentence errors

2.4.1 Fragments

A **fragment** is a group of words punctuated as a sentence but lacking a subject, a main verb, or an independent clause.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Because the train was late.	We missed the meeting because the train was late.	dependent clause alone
Working late every night.	She was working late every night.	no subject or main verb
The report that I sent yesterday.	The report that I sent yesterday has errors.	no main verb

2.4.2 Run-on sentences and comma splices

A **run-on** joins two independent clauses with no punctuation; a **comma splice** joins them with only a comma. Fix either with a full stop, a semicolon, or a comma plus a conjunction.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
It is raining we will stay inside.	It is raining, so we will stay inside.	run-on
The code compiled, it did not run.	The code compiled; it did not run.	comma splice
I called him, he did not answer.	I called him, but he did not answer.	comma splice

WATCH OUT
"However", "therefore" and "moreover" are not conjunctions. "It rained, however we played" is a comma splice; write "It rained; however, we played."

2.5 Practice questions

2.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Identify the part of speech of the underlined word: She sings beautifully.

(a) adjective (b) noun (c) verb (d) adverb

Q2 Identify the part of speech of the underlined word: Honesty is the best policy.

(a) adjective (b) adverb (c) noun (d) verb

Q3 Identify the part of speech of the underlined word: The cat hid under the table.

(a) preposition (b) adverb (c) conjunction (d) adjective

Q4 Identify the part of speech of the underlined word: I was tired, but I finished the work.

(a) preposition (b) adverb (c) pronoun (d) conjunction

Q5 What is the subject of the sentence: "The list of new features was long."?

(a) new features
(b) The list of new features
(c) features was long
(d) was long

Q6 Which of these is a complete sentence?

(a) When the results were announced.
(b) The results were announced.
(c) Announcing the results.
(d) The results that were announced.

Q7 Identify the sentence type by function: "Please close the door."

(a) declarative (b) interrogative (c) exclamatory (d) imperative

Q8 Identify the part of speech of the underlined word: Alas! We lost the match.

(a) interjection (b) adverb (c) noun (d) conjunction

2.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Identify the part of speech of "fast" in: "He ran fast to catch the bus."

(a) adjective (b) noun (c) adverb (d) verb

Q10 Identify the part of speech of "light" in: "Light the candles before the guests arrive."

(a) noun (b) adjective (c) adverb (d) verb

Q11 Identify the structure: "The server crashed, and the team worked all night."

(a) simple
(b) compound
(c) complex
(d) compound-complex

Q12 Identify the structure: "Although it was late, she finished the report."

(a) complex
(b) simple
(c) compound
(d) compound-complex

Q13 In "She gave the client a discount", what is "the client"?

(a) direct object
(b) subject complement
(c) indirect object
(d) subject

Q14 In "He became the team leader", what is "the team leader"?

(a) subject complement **(b)** direct object
(c) indirect object **(d)** object complement

Q15 Which of the following is a phrase (not a clause)?

(a) after the meeting ended **(b)** after the long meeting
(c) because she left **(d)** when they arrived

Q16 Which sentence is a comma splice?

(a) The file is large, so it takes time to upload.
(b) The file is large; it takes time to upload.
(c) Because the file is large, it takes time to upload.
(d) The file is large, it takes time to upload.

2.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Identify the structure: "When the alarm rang, Ravi woke up, but his brother kept sleeping."

(a) compound **(b)** complex
(c) compound-complex **(d)** simple

Q18 Which is the best correction of: "I finished the project, however, the client wanted changes."?

(a) I finished the project, however the client wanted changes.
(b) I finished the project however, the client wanted changes.
(c) I finished the project; however, the client wanted changes.
(d) I finished, the project, however the client wanted changes.

Q19 In "The committee declared the plan a failure", what is "a failure"?

(a) direct object **(b)** subject complement
(c) indirect object **(d)** object complement

Q20 Identify the part of speech of "round" in: "The earth is round."

(a) preposition **(b)** adjective **(c)** adverb **(d)** noun

Q21 Which word in the sentence is a pronoun? "Whoever finishes first can leave early."

(a) Whoever **(b)** finishes **(c)** first **(d)** early

Q22 Which of the following is a fragment?

(a) She hoped to get the job.
(b) Hoping to get the job after the interview.
(c) Hope helps.
(d) Get the job!

Q23 Choose the sentence that is correctly joined.

(a) The test was difficult, yet most students passed.
(b) The test was difficult most students passed.
(c) The test was difficult, most students passed.
(d) The test was difficult, therefore most students passed.

Q24 In "That he lied surprised everyone", what is the subject?

(a) he **(b)** everyone **(c)** That he lied **(d)** surprised

Q25 Identify the part of speech of "but" in: "Everyone came but Ravi."

(a) conjunction **(b)** adverb **(c)** pronoun **(d)** preposition

2.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (d) adverb**

"Beautifully" describes how she sings (a verb): **adverb**.

Q2 **Answer: (c) noun**

"Honesty" names an idea: an abstract **noun**.

Q3 **Answer: (a) preposition**

"Under" links "the table" to the verb, showing position: **preposition**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) conjunction**

"But" joins two clauses: **conjunction**.

Q5 **Answer: (b) The list of new features**

The sentence is about **the list** (of new features); "was" agrees with "list".

Q6 **Answer: (b) The results were announced.**

Only **"The results were announced."** has a subject, a main verb and no subordinating word.

Q7 **Answer: (d) imperative**

It gives a request: **imperative**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) interjection**

"Alas" expresses sudden feeling: **interjection**.

Q9 **Answer: (c) adverb**

It describes how he ran: **adverb**. (In "a fast car" it would be an adjective.)

Q10 **Answer: (d) verb**

It is a command to do something: **verb**.

Q11 **Answer: (b) compound**

Two independent clauses joined by "and": **compound**.

Q12 **Answer: (a) complex**

One dependent clause (although …) + one independent clause: **complex**.

Q13 **Answer: (c) indirect object**

The discount is given **to** the client: indirect object; "a discount" is the direct object.

Q14 **Answer: (a) subject complement**

"Became" is a linking verb; "the team leader" renames the subject: **subject complement**.

Q15 **Answer: (b) after the long meeting**

Only **"after the long meeting"** has no subject–verb pair.

Q16 **Answer: (d) The file is large, it takes time to upload.**

Two independent clauses joined by a comma alone: **The file is large, it takes time to upload.**

Q17 **Answer: (c) compound-complex**

Two independent clauses (Ravi woke up / his brother kept sleeping) + a dependent clause (when …): **compound-complex**.

Q18 **Answer: (c) I finished the project; however, the client wanted changes.**

"However" is an adverb, not a conjunction, so the clauses need a **semicolon** before it and a comma after it.

Q19 **Answer: (d) object complement**

It describes the object "the plan": **object complement**.

Q20 **Answer: (b) adjective**

It describes the noun "earth" after a linking verb: **adjective**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) Whoever**

Whoever is a pronoun standing for the unknown person.

Q22 **Answer: (b) Hoping to get the job after the interview.**

It has no subject and no main verb (hoping is a participle): **fragment**. "Get the job!" is a complete imperative.

Q23 **Answer: (a) The test was difficult, yet most students passed.**

A comma plus a coordinating conjunction (**yet**) correctly joins two independent clauses; "therefore" needs a semicolon.

Q24 **Answer: (c) That he lied**

The whole clause **"That he lied"** is the subject (a noun clause) of "surprised".

Q25 **Answer: (d) preposition**

Here "but" means "except" and is followed by a noun: **preposition**.

A word's part of speech is decided by its job. Every sentence needs a subject and a predicate with a main verb. Join independent clauses with a full stop, a semicolon, or a comma plus and/but/or/so/yet; never with a comma alone.

MODULE 03 · BEGINNER

Nouns, pronouns and articles

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

Nouns, pronouns and articles are the most frequently tested areas in error-spotting questions. This module covers kinds of nouns, countable and uncountable nouns, plurals, nouns that are always singular or always plural, possessives, the kinds of pronouns, subject and object case, pronoun–antecedent agreement, each other and one another, the rules for a, an and the, and determiners such as few, a few, less and fewer, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

3.1	Nouns	3.2	Pronouns
3.3	Articles	3.4	Determiners and quantifiers
3.5	Practice questions	3.6	Solutions

3.1 Nouns

3.1.1 Common, proper, collective, abstract, material

Kind	Meaning	Examples
Common	general name of a class	city, engineer, phone
Proper	name of a particular one (capital letter)	Mumbai, Infosys, Monday
Collective	a group seen as one unit	team, committee, jury, flock
Abstract	an idea, quality or state	honesty, freedom, anger
Material	a substance	gold, water, cotton

3.1.2 Countable and uncountable nouns

Countable nouns have plurals and take *a/an* and *many/few*. Uncountable nouns have no plural and take *much/little*; to count them use a unit word: *a piece of advice, an item of news, a piece of furniture*.

Always uncountable (no -s, no a/an)	Correct use
information, advice, furniture, equipment, luggage, baggage	some information, a piece of advice
news, knowledge, scenery, machinery, poetry, traffic	the news is good; heavy traffic
feedback, homework, research, software, evidence	useful feedback; a lot of research

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
She gave me many advices.	She gave me a lot of advice.	advice is uncountable

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
The sceneries of Kashmir are beautiful.	The scenery of Kashmir is beautiful.	scenery is uncountable
He bought new furnitures.	He bought new furniture.	furniture is uncountable

3.1.3 Plural forms and irregular plurals

Pattern	Examples
add -s / -es	book → books, box → boxes, bus → buses
consonant + y → -ies	city → cities (but day → days)
-f / -fe → -ves	knife → knives, leaf → leaves (but roof → roofs, chief → chiefs)
irregular	man → men, child → children, tooth → teeth, mouse → mice
same in both	sheep, deer, aircraft, series, species
Latin / Greek	criterion → criteria, phenomenon → phenomena, datum → data, analysis → analyses
compound nouns	mother-in-law → mothers-in-law, passer-by → passers-by

3.1.4 Nouns always singular or always plural

Always singular verb	Always plural verb
news, mathematics, physics, economics (subject)	scissors, trousers, jeans, spectacles, pliers
measles, mumps, billiards, athletics	cattle, police, people, clergy
information, advice (uncountable)	thanks, goods, riches, premises, surroundings

WATCH OUT
Pair nouns take plural verbs unless "pair" is the subject: "My trousers **are** torn" but "This pair of trousers **is** torn".

3.1.5 Possessive forms and apostrophes

Rule	Example
singular noun: add 's	the manager's office, James's car
plural ending in s: add '	the students' results
plural not ending in s: add 's	the children's toys, women's rights
joint ownership: 's on the last name only	Ram and Shyam's shop (one shop)
separate ownership: 's on each	Ram's and Shyam's shops
its (possessive) vs it's (it is)	The company changed its logo. It's raining.

3.2 Pronouns

3.2.1 Kinds of pronouns

Kind	Examples
Personal	I, me, you, he, him, she, her, it, we, us, they, them
Possessive	mine, yours, his, hers, ours, theirs
Reflexive / emphatic	myself, yourself, himself, ourselves, themselves
Relative	who, whom, whose, which, that
Demonstrative	this, that, these, those
Indefinite	someone, anybody, everyone, nobody, each, either, neither, one
Interrogative	who, whom, whose, what, which

3.2.2 Subject vs object case

Use the subject form (I, he, she, we, they, who) as the subject of a verb and after *than/as* when a verb is understood; use the object form (me, him, her, us, them, whom) after verbs and prepositions.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Between you and I, he is wrong.	Between you and me, he is wrong.	object after preposition
He is taller than me.	He is taller than I (am).	subject before understood verb (formal)
Who did you meet?	Whom did you meet?	object of "meet" (formal)
Me and Ravi went home.	Ravi and I went home.	subject form; others first

> **SHORTCUT TRICK**
> For who/whom, answer the question with he/him: "You met **him**" → whom. "**He** called" → who called.

3.2.3 Pronoun–antecedent agreement

A pronoun must agree in number and gender with the noun it replaces. Indefinite pronouns such as *each, everyone, anybody, neither* are singular in formal tests.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Each of the boys brought their book.	Each of the boys brought his book.	each is singular
Everyone must do their duty.	Everyone must do his or her duty.	formal test rule
The committee gave their decision.	The committee gave its decision.	committee acting as one

3.2.4 Each other, one another, either, neither, one

Word	Rule	Example
each other	between two	The two brothers love each other.
one another	among more than two	The five friends helped one another.
either / neither	one of two (singular verb)	Either of the two roads leads there.
any / none	one of more than two	Any of the five roads … / None of them
one	continue with one's	One should do one's duty.

3.3 Articles

3.3.1 "A" vs "an": the sound rule

Use **an** before a vowel **sound**, **a** before a consonant **sound**, whatever the spelling: an hour, an honest man, an MBA, an X-ray; a university, a European, a one-day match, a useful tip.

3.3.2 Uses of "the"

Use "the" with	Example
something already mentioned or known	I bought a phone. The phone is fast.
unique things	the sun, the earth, the internet
superlatives and ordinals	the best, the first, the only
rivers, oceans, mountain ranges, deserts	the Ganga, the Pacific, the Himalayas, the Thar
newspapers, famous buildings, plural country names	the Hindu, the Taj Mahal, the USA, the Netherlands
adjective used as a group	the rich, the poor, the elderly
musical instruments	She plays the guitar.

3.3.3 Omission of articles

No article with	Example
names of people, cities, most countries	Ravi lives in Pune, India.
languages and subjects	She speaks French. He studies physics.
meals, games, diseases (most)	We had lunch. They play cricket. He has diabetes.
places used for their purpose	go to school / church / bed / hospital (as a patient)
uncountable and plural nouns in general	Water is essential. Dogs are loyal.

WATCH OUT
"Go to **the** school" means visiting the building (for example, a parent going to a meeting); "go to school" means going as a student.

3.4 Determiners and quantifiers

3.4.1 Some, any, much, many, few, a few, little, a little, less, fewer

Word	Used with	Meaning / example
many / few / fewer	countable plural	many books; fewer mistakes
much / little / less	uncountable	much water; less time
few	countable	almost none (negative): Few people came.
a few	countable	some, a small number (positive): A few people came.
the few	countable	all of the small number: I spent the few rupees I had.
little / a little / the little	uncountable	same pattern: little hope (almost none), a little hope (some)
some	positive sentences, offers	Would you like some tea?
any	negatives and questions	I do not have any money.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
There were less people than expected.	There were fewer people than expected.	fewer with countables
He has a few money.	He has a little money.	money is uncountable
I have much friends.	I have many friends.	many with countables

3.5 Practice questions

3.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct option: She gave me some useful _____.

(a) informations **(b)** an information
(c) informations pieces **(d)** information

Q2 Choose the correct article: She is _____ university professor.

(a) an **(b)** the **(c)** a **(d)** no article

Q3 Choose the correct article: I will be back in _____ hour.

(a) an **(b)** a **(c)** the **(d)** no article

Q4 Choose the correct plural of "criterion".

(a) criterions **(b)** criterias **(c)** criterion **(d)** criteria

Q5 Choose the correct option: Mathematics _____ my favourite subject.

(a) are **(b)** is **(c)** were **(d)** have been

Q6 Choose the correct pronoun: The manager asked Priya and _____ to stay late.

(a) I **(b)** me **(c)** myself **(d)** mine

Q7 Choose the correct option: The two sisters helped _____.

(a) one another **(b)** themselves each
(c) each another **(d)** each other

Q8 Choose the correctly punctuated phrase.

(a) the children's toys **(b)** the childrens' toys
(c) the childrens toys **(d)** the children toys'

3.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the correct option: There were _____ mistakes in this report than in the last one.

(a) less **(b)** lesser **(c)** fewer **(d)** little

Q10 Choose the correct option: _____ people understand this theory; it is very difficult.

(a) A few **(b)** The few **(c)** Little **(d)** Few

Q11 Which part has an error? *The police has arrested / the thief who / broke into / the bank.*

(a) The police has arrested **(b)** the thief who
(c) broke into **(d)** the bank

Q12 Which part has an error? *Each of the players / must bring / their own kit / to the ground.*

(a) Each of the players **(b)** must bring
(c) their own kit **(d)** to the ground

Q13 Choose the correct option: He is senior to _____ in the department.

(a) I **(b)** me **(c)** myself **(d)** mine

Q14 Choose the correct option: Who / Whom do you think will win?

(a) Who **(b)** Whom **(c)** Whose **(d)** Which

Q15 Choose the correct article: _____ Ganga is a sacred river.

(a) A **(b)** An **(c)** The **(d)** no article

Q16 Choose the correct option: My spectacles _____ broken.

(a) are **(b)** is **(c)** was **(d)** has been

3.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which part has an error? *He gave me / many valuable advices / which helped me / in my career.*

(a) He gave me **(b)** many valuable advices
(c) which helped me **(d)** in my career

Q18 Which part has an error? *One should keep / his promises if / he wants to be / trusted by others.*

(a) One should keep **(b)** his promises if
(c) he wants to be **(d)** trusted by others

Q19 Choose the correct option: He is _____ MBA from a reputed institute.

(a) a **(b)** an **(c)** the **(d)** no article

Q20 Which part has an error? *The sceneries / of the hill station / attract tourists / every summer.*

(a) The sceneries **(b)** of the hill station
(c) attract tourists **(d)** every summer

Q21 Choose the correct option: Neither of the two candidates _____ suitable.

(a) are **(b)** were **(c)** have been **(d)** is

Q22 Choose the correct option: This is the girl _____ father is a doctor.

(a) who's **(b)** whom **(c)** whose **(d)** which

Q23 Which part has an error? *It is me / who am responsible / for the delay / in the project.*

(a) It is me **(b)** who am responsible
(c) for the delay **(d)** in the project

Q24 Choose the correct option: I spent _____ money I had on books.

(a) little **(b)** a little **(c)** the little **(d)** the few

Q25 Which part has an error? *Ram and Shyam's shops / are on the / same street, but they / never compete.*

(a) Ram and Shyam's shops **(b)** are on the
(c) same street, but they **(d)** never compete

3.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (d) information**

"Information" is uncountable: no -s and no "an": some useful **information**.

Q2 **Answer: (c) a**

"University" begins with a "yoo" (consonant) sound: **a** university.

Q3 **Answer: (a) an**

The h in "hour" is silent, giving a vowel sound: **an** hour.

Q4 **Answer: (d) criteria**

Criteria is the Greek plural of criterion.

Q5 **Answer: (b) is**

Names of subjects ending in -ics take a **singular** verb.

Q6 **Answer: (b) me**

"Asked … me": object of the verb. Test by removing "Priya and": asked **me**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) each other**

For two people use **each other**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) the children's toys**

"Children" is a plural not ending in s, so add **'s**: the children's toys.

Q9 **Answer: (c) fewer**

"Mistakes" is countable: **fewer**.

Q10 **Answer: (d) Few**

The sense is negative (almost no one): **Few**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) The police has arrested**

"Police" is always plural: the police **have** arrested.

Q12 **Answer: (c) their own kit**

"Each" is singular, so the pronoun must be singular: **his own kit** (formal test rule).

Q13 **Answer: (b) me**

"To" is a preposition and needs the object form: senior to **me**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) Who**

Test: "You think **he** will win", so the subject form **who** is correct; "do you think" is a parenthetical clause.

Q15 **Answer: (c) The**

Names of rivers take **the**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) are**

"Spectacles" is a pair noun, always plural: **are**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) many valuable advices**

"Advice" is uncountable: **much valuable advice** (or a lot of valuable advice).

Q18 **Answer: (b) his promises if**

After "one", continue with **one's** and "one": one should keep one's promises if one wants to be trusted.

Q19 **Answer: (b) an**

"MBA" is read "em-bee-ay", starting with a vowel sound: **an** MBA.

Q20 **Answer: (a) The sceneries**

"Scenery" is uncountable: **The scenery … attracts** tourists (the verb also changes).

Q21 **Answer: (d) is**

"Neither" means not one of two: singular **is**.

Q22 **Answer: (c) whose**

The possessive relative pronoun is **whose**; "who's" means "who is".

Q23 **Answer: (a) It is me**

After "It is" formal English uses the subject form: **It is I** who am responsible (the verb agrees with "I").

Q24 **Answer: (c) the little**

"The little" means all of the small amount: I spent **the little** money I had.

Q25 **Answer: (a) Ram and Shyam's shops**

Separate ownership needs 's on each name: **Ram's and Shyam's shops**.

Uncountables (information, advice, furniture, news, scenery) take no -s and no a/an. Pair nouns and police/cattle/people are plural. Use object pronouns after verbs and prepositions. Each/every/either/neither are singular. A/an follow the sound. Few/fewer for countables; little/less for uncountables.

MODULE 04 · BEGINNER

Verbs and tenses

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Beginner**

Verb forms and tenses are the core of correct English and a major source of test questions. This module covers main and auxiliary verbs, transitive and intransitive verbs, irregular verb forms, modals, all twelve tenses with timelines, sequence of tenses, stative verbs, since and for, the four conditionals, infinitives, gerunds and participles, and the subjunctive, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

4.1 Verbs
4.2 The twelve tenses
4.3 Tense rules and common errors
4.4 Non-finite verbs
4.5 Subjunctive mood
4.6 Practice questions
4.7 Solutions

4.1 Verbs

4.1.1 Main and auxiliary verbs

The **main verb** carries the meaning; **auxiliary (helping) verbs** (be, have, do and the modals) help form tenses, questions, negatives and the passive: *She has been **working**. Did you **call**?*

4.1.2 Transitive and intransitive verbs

A **transitive** verb needs an object (*She **wrote** a letter*); an **intransitive** verb does not (*He **slept***). Only transitive verbs can be made passive.

Pair	Transitive (takes an object)	Intransitive (no object)
raise / rise	They raised the price.	Prices rose.
lay / lie	Lay the book on the table. (laid, laid)	Lie down. (lay, lain)
set / sit	Set the cup down.	Sit here.

4.1.3 Regular and irregular verbs

Base	Past	Past participle	Base	Past	Past participle
begin	began	begun	lie (rest)	lay	lain
break	broke	broken	ride	rode	ridden
choose	chose	chosen	rise	rose	risen
drink	drank	drunk	seek	sought	sought

Base	Past	Past participle	Base	Past	Past participle
fly	flew	flown	shake	shook	shaken
forbid	forbade	forbidden	spring	sprang	sprung
hang (object)	hung	hung	swim	swam	swum
hang (execute)	hanged	hanged	tear	tore	torn
lay (put)	laid	laid	write	wrote	written

4.1.4 Modal verbs

Modal	Main uses	Example
can / could	ability, permission, polite request	Can you help? Could you help? (more polite)
may / might	permission, possibility (might = less likely)	It may rain. It might rain.
shall / will	future, offers (shall I…?), promises	Shall I open the window?
should / ought to	advice, duty	You should rest. You ought to rest.
must / have to	necessity, strong deduction	You must wear a helmet. He must be tired.
would	polite request, past habit, conditional	Would you mind…? He would walk daily.

WATCH OUT
A modal is always followed by the base verb: "He can **swim**", never "He can swims" or "He can to swim" ("ought to" is the exception).

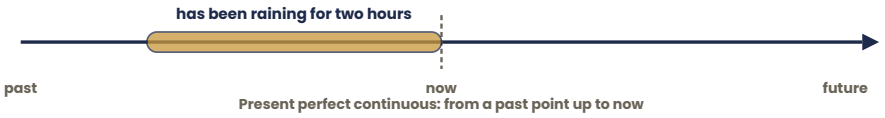
4.2 The twelve tenses

	Simple	Continuous	Perfect	Perfect continuous
Present	I work	I am working	I have worked	I have been working
Past	I worked	I was working	I had worked	I had been working
Future	I will work	I will be working	I will have worked	I will have been working

4.2.1 Present: simple, continuous, perfect, perfect continuous

Tense	Use	Example
Simple present	habits, facts, timetables	Water boils at 100 °C. The train leaves at six.
Present continuous	action happening now or around now; fixed future plans	She is writing code. I am meeting him tomorrow.

Tense	Use	Example
Present perfect	past action with present result; unfinished period	I have lost my keys. She has worked here since 2021.
Present perfect continuous	action begun in the past and still continuing (stresses duration)	It has been raining for two hours.



WATCH OUT

Never use the present perfect with a finished past time: "I have seen him **yesterday**" is wrong; write "I saw him yesterday".

4.2.2 Past: simple, continuous, perfect, perfect continuous

Tense	Use	Example
Simple past	completed action at a known past time	I met her last week.
Past continuous	action in progress at a past moment, often interrupted	I was cooking when he called.
Past perfect	the earlier of two past actions	The train had left before we reached the station.
Past perfect continuous	duration up to a past point	She had been waiting for an hour when the bus came.



4.2.3 Future: simple, continuous, perfect, perfect continuous

Tense	Use	Example
Simple future	prediction, decision, promise	I will call you tonight.
Future continuous	action in progress at a future moment	This time tomorrow I will be flying to Delhi.
Future perfect	completed before a future point	By March, we will have finished the project.
Future perfect continuous	duration up to a future point	By June, she will have been working here for five years.

4.3 Tense rules and common errors

4.3.1 Sequence of tenses

If the main clause is in the past tense, the subordinate clause is usually in a past tense too: *He **said** that he **was** busy.* Universal truths stay in the present: *The teacher said that the earth **revolves** round the sun.*

In clauses of time and condition (when, if, before, after, as soon as, until, unless), use the present for a future meaning: *I will call you when I **reach** (not "will reach") home.*

4.3.2 Stative verbs are not used in continuous form

Verbs of knowing, feeling, possessing and perceiving describe states, not actions: *know, understand, believe, like, love, hate, want, own, belong, seem, contain, consist, hear, see, smell.*

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
I am knowing the answer.	I know the answer.	stative verb
This box is containing books.	This box contains books.	stative verb
She is having a car.	She has a car.	"have" = possess (but "having lunch" is fine)

4.3.3 "Since" and "for"

Since + a point of time (since Monday, since 2019, since morning); **for** + a period (for three days, for ten years). Both normally go with a perfect tense.

4.3.4 Conditional sentences

Type	If-clause	Main clause	Meaning	Example
Zero	present	present	general truth	If you heat ice, it melts.
First	present	will + base	real future possibility	If it rains, we will stay in.
Second	past (were)	would + base	imaginary present/future	If I were rich, I would travel.
Third	past perfect	would have + past participle	imaginary past	If you had studied, you would have passed.

WATCH OUT
Never put "will" or "would" in the if-clause: "If he **will come**…" and "If I **would have known**…" are both wrong.

4.4 Non-finite verbs

4.4.1 Infinitives, gerunds and participles

Form	Shape	Example
Infinitive	to + base	She wants **to learn** Python.
Bare infinitive	base (after modals, let, make, see, hear)	Let him **go**. I saw her **leave**.
Gerund	verb + -ing used as a noun	**Swimming** is good exercise.
Present participle	verb + -ing used as adjective or in continuous tenses	a **running** tap
Past participle	third form	a **broken** chair

WATCH OUT
Dangling participle: "**Walking** to the station, the rain started" says the rain was walking. Write "**While I was walking** to the station, the rain started".

4.4.2 Verbs followed by gerund vs infinitive

+ gerund (-ing)	+ infinitive (to …)	Change in meaning
avoid, enjoy, finish, mind, deny, suggest, consider, admit, practise, risk, keep, look forward to, be used to, object to	agree, decide, hope, plan, promise, refuse, want, afford, expect, manage, offer, learn	stop, remember, forget, try, regret: "stopped smoking" (quit) vs "stopped to smoke" (paused in order to)

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.	"to" here is a preposition
He avoided to answer.	He avoided answering.	avoid + gerund
She is used to wake up early.	She is used to waking up early.	be used to + gerund

4.5 Subjunctive mood

The subjunctive expresses wishes, imaginary situations and demands. Use **were** for all persons in wishes and unreal conditions, and the **base verb** after verbs of demand, suggestion and necessity.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
I wish I was taller.	I wish I were taller.	wish → were
If he was here, he would help.	If he were here, he would help.	unreal condition
I suggest that he goes now.	I suggest that he go now.	suggest that + base verb
It is essential that she attends.	It is essential that she attend.	essential that + base verb

Also: *It is high time we **left*** (past form after "it is time"), and *I would rather you **stayed***.

4.6 Practice questions

4.6.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct option: She _____ in this company since 2019.

(a) is working (b) works
(c) was working (d) has been working

Q2 Choose the correct option: I _____ him yesterday at the station.

(a) have seen (b) saw (c) had seen (d) see

Q3 Choose the correct option: Water _____ at 100 °C.

(a) boils (b) boil (c) is boiling (d) boiled

Q4 Choose the correct option: When I reached the station, the train _____.

(a) already left (b) had already left
(c) has already left (d) was already leaving

Q5 Choose the correct option: I will call you as soon as I _____ home.

(a) reach (b) will reach (c) reached (d) would reach

Q6 Choose the correct option: He has been ill _____ three days.

(a) since (b) from (c) for (d) by

Q7 Choose the correct option: If it rains, we _____ the match.

(a) would cancel (b) cancelled
(c) would have cancelled (d) will cancel

Q8 Choose the correct past participle: The window was _____ by the storm.

(a) broke (b) breaked (c) break (d) broken

4.6.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the correct option: I _____ the answer to this question.

(a) am knowing (b) have been knowing
(c) know (d) was knowing

Q10 Choose the correct option: If I _____ you, I would apologise.

(a) were (b) was (c) am (d) had been

Q11 Choose the correct option: If she had left earlier, she _____ the flight.

(a) would catch (b) will catch
(c) had caught (d) would have caught

Q12 Choose the correct option: I look forward to _____ from you.

(a) hear (b) hearing (c) heard (d) be hearing

Q13 Choose the correct option: By next March, we _____ the new office.

(a) will complete (b) will have completed

(c) complete (d) have completed

Q14 Which part has an error? *He told me that / he will join / the company / next month.*

(a) He told me that (b) he will join
(c) the company (d) next month

Q15 Choose the correct option: She avoided _____ the question.

(a) to answer (b) answer (c) answered (d) answering

Q16 Choose the correct option: The prices of vegetables have _____ sharply.

(a) risen (b) raised (c) rose (d) arisen

4.6.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which part has an error? *I have finished / the report / last night / before dinner.*

(a) I have finished (b) the report
(c) last night (d) before dinner

Q18 Which part has an error? *The doctor suggested that / he takes / complete rest / for a week.*

(a) The doctor suggested that (b) he takes
(c) complete rest (d) for a week

Q19 Choose the correct option: It is high time we _____ the problem seriously.

(a) take (b) have taken (c) took (d) will take

Q20 Which part has an error? *If he would have asked / me, I would / have helped / him gladly.*

(a) If he would have asked (b) me, I would
(c) have helped (d) him gladly

Q21 Choose the correct option: The criminal was _____ at dawn.

(a) hung (b) hang (c) hunged (d) hanged

Q22 Which part has an error? *Walking along the beach, / a big wave / suddenly knocked / me down.*

(a) Walking along the beach, (b) a big wave
(c) suddenly knocked (d) me down

Q23 Choose the correct option: He stopped _____ to his friend when he saw him on the road.

(a) talking (b) to talk (c) talk (d) talked

Q24 Choose the correct option: She _____ for two hours when the power finally came back.

(a) had been studying (b) has been studying
(c) was studied (d) is studying

Q25 Choose the correct option: I would rather you _____ here tonight.

(a) stay (b) will stay (c) stayed (d) have stayed

4.7 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (d) has been working**

"Since 2019" + continuing action: present perfect continuous, **has been working**.

Q2 **Answer: (b) saw**

A finished past time (yesterday) needs the simple past: **saw**.

Q3 **Answer: (a) boils**

A scientific fact: simple present, **boils**.

Q4 **Answer: (b) had already left**

The train left before I reached: earlier past action, past perfect **had already left**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) reach**

After "as soon as" (time clause) use the present for the future: **reach**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) for**

"Three days" is a period: **for**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) will cancel**

First conditional: present in the if-clause, **will** + base in the main clause.

Q8 **Answer: (d) broken**

Break – broke – **broken**.

Q9 **Answer: (c) know**

"Know" is a stative verb and is not used in the continuous: **know**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) were**

Second conditional (imaginary): **were** for all persons.

Q11 **Answer: (d) would have caught**

Third conditional: had + past participle → **would have** + past participle.

Q12 **Answer: (b) hearing**

In "look forward to", "to" is a preposition, so a gerund follows: **hearing**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) will have completed**

"By next March" = completed before a future point: future perfect, **will have completed**.

Q14 **Answer: (b) he will join**

Sequence of tenses: after past "told", use **would join**.

Q15 **Answer: (d) answering**

"Avoid" is followed by a gerund: **answering**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) risen**

"Rise" is intransitive (no object): rise – rose – **risen**.

Q17 **Answer: (a) I have finished**

A finished past time (last night) needs the simple past: **I finished**.

Q18 **Answer: (b) he takes**

After "suggest that", use the subjunctive base verb: he **take** (or "he should take").

Q19 **Answer: (c) took**

"It is high time" is followed by the past form: **took**.

Q20 **Answer: (a) If he would have asked**

Never "would" in the if-clause: **If he had asked**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) hanged**

For execution, the forms are hang – hanged – **hanged**; "hung" is for objects.

Q22 **Answer: (b) a big wave**

Dangling participle: the wave was not walking. Rewrite: "Walking along the beach, **I was knocked down** by a big wave."

Q23 **Answer: (b) to talk**

He paused (stopped walking) in order to talk: **stopped to talk**. "Stopped talking" would mean he ended a conversation.

Q24 **Answer: (a) had been studying**

Duration up to a past point: past perfect continuous, **had been studying**.

Q25 **Answer: (c) stayed**

"Would rather" + another subject takes the past form: you **stayed**.

Simple past for finished times; present perfect for unfinished periods (since + point, for + period). Past perfect for the earlier of two past actions. Present tense after when/if/as soon as for the future. No will/would in if-clauses. Stative verbs are not continuous. "Were" for unreal conditions; base verb after suggest/insist that.

MODULE 05 · BEGINNER

Subject–verb agreement

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

Subject–verb agreement errors are the single most common error type in placement tests. This module covers the basic rule and every tricky case: subjects joined by and, or, nor, either…or and neither…nor; as well as and along with; each, every and everyone; collective nouns; the number of and a number of; one of the; amounts and periods; titles; inverted sentences with there and here; and relative clauses such as one of those who, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

5.1 Basic rule
5.2 Tricky subjects
5.3 Inverted sentences
5.4 Relative clauses
5.5 Practice questions
5.6 Solutions

5.1 Basic rule

5.1.1 Singular subject → singular verb; plural subject → plural verb

In the present tense a singular third-person subject takes a verb ending in -s (*she works, it seems, he has, it is*); a plural subject takes the plain form (*they work, they have, they are*).



FIND THE REAL SUBJECT; SKIP THE WORDS BETWEEN

SHORTCUT TRICK

Cross out every prepositional phrase (of …, in …, with …) between the subject and the verb. The noun left is the true subject.

5.2 Tricky subjects

5.2.1 Subjects joined by and, or, nor, either…or, neither…nor

Subject	Verb	Example
A and B (two things)	plural	Ravi and Priya **are** here.
A and B (one person/idea)	singular	Bread and butter **is** my breakfast. The secretary and treasurer **has** arrived. (one person)
each/every + A and B	singular	Every boy and girl **was** present.

Subject	Verb	Example
A or B, either A or B, neither A nor B	agrees with the nearer subject (B)	Neither the manager nor the employees **were** aware. Either the employees or the manager **is** responsible.



PROXIMITY RULE FOR OR / NOR

WATCH OUT
"The secretary and **the** treasurer have arrived" (two people, article repeated) but "The secretary and treasurer has arrived" (one person holding both posts).

5.2.2 "As well as", "along with", "together with"

These phrases add information but do not join subjects; the verb agrees with the **first** subject. Same for *with, in addition to, besides, accompanied by, including, rather than*.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
The captain, as well as the players, were praised.	The captain, as well as the players, was praised.	agrees with "captain"
The teacher along with her students are coming.	The teacher along with her students is coming.	agrees with "teacher"

5.2.3 "Each", "every", "everyone", "anybody"

Each, every, either, neither, everyone, everybody, someone, anybody, nobody, no one, nothing, everything are singular: *Everyone **has** a role. Each of the reports **is** ready.*

5.2.4 Collective nouns

A collective noun (team, committee, jury, family, staff, audience, government) takes a singular verb when the group acts as one unit, and a plural verb when its members act separately.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
The jury have given its verdict.	The jury has given its verdict.	acting as one
The committee is divided in their opinions.	The committee are divided in their opinions.	members act separately

5.2.5 "The number of" vs "a number of"

The number of + plural noun → singular verb (the number itself): The number of applicants **is** large. **A number of** (= many) + plural noun → plural verb: A number of applicants **were** rejected.

5.2.6 "One of the ..."

"One of the + plural noun" takes a singular verb because the subject is "one": *One of my friends **lives** in Chennai.* The noun after "one of the" must be plural: *one of the best **players***, not "player".

5.2.7 Amounts, distances and periods of time

A sum of money, a distance, a weight or a period treated as one amount takes a singular verb: *Ten thousand rupees **is** a lot. Five kilometres **is** too far to walk. Two years **has** passed quickly.*

5.2.8 Titles and names of books

Titles of books, films and organisations are singular, even if they look plural: *"Great Expectations" **is** a classic. The United Nations **has** issued a statement.*

Also singular	Also plural
news, mathematics, physics, measles	police, cattle, people, scissors, trousers
many a + singular noun: Many a student **has** failed.	the rich, the poor (= people): The rich **are** not always happy.
more than one + singular noun: More than one person **was** hurt.	both, few, many, several: Both **are** correct.

5.3 Inverted sentences

In sentences beginning with *there, here* or a phrase of place, the subject comes after the verb. Find it and make the verb agree: *There **are** three errors in this code. Here **comes** the bus. On the table **were** two files.*

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
There is many reasons for the delay.	There are many reasons for the delay.	subject "reasons" is plural
Here comes the guests.	Here come the guests.	subject "guests" is plural

5.4 Relative clauses

The verb in a relative clause (who/which/that ...) agrees with the noun the pronoun refers to.

One of those who + plural verb: He is one of those people who **work** hard ("who" refers to "people"). But **the only one of those who** + singular verb: He is the only one of those people who **works** hard ("who" refers to "the only one").

5.5 Practice questions

5.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct option: The list of names _____ on the notice board.

(a) is (b) are (c) were (d) have been

Q2 Choose the correct option: Ravi and his sister _____ engineers.

(a) is (b) are (c) was (d) has been

Q3 Choose the correct option: Everyone in the office _____ about the merger.

(a) know (b) are knowing (c) have known (d) knows

Q4 Choose the correct option: Neither the teacher nor the students _____ present.

(a) was (b) is (c) were (d) has been

Q5 Choose the correct option: The number of cars on the roads _____ increasing.

(a) are (b) were (c) is (d) have been

Q6 Choose the correct option: A number of students _____ absent today.

(a) is (b) was (c) has been (d) are

Q7 Choose the correct option: There _____ several mistakes in your essay.

(a) is (b) are (c) was (d) has been

Q8 Choose the correct option: Each of the boys _____ a prize.

(a) gets (b) get (c) are getting (d) have got

5.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the correct option: The manager, along with his team, _____ attending the conference.

(a) are (b) is (c) were (d) have been

Q10 Choose the correct option: Bread and butter _____ my usual breakfast.

(a) is (b) are (c) were (d) have been

Q11 Choose the correct option: Fifty thousand rupees _____ too much for this phone.

(a) are (b) were (c) is (d) have been

Q12 Choose the correct option: One of my colleagues _____ in Hyderabad.

(a) live (b) are living (c) have lived (d) lives

Q13 Choose the correct option: The jury _____ divided in their opinions.

(a) was (b) is (c) has been (d) were

Q14 Which part has an error? *The quality of the mangoes / were not good, / so we returned / the whole box.*

(a) The quality of the mangoes (b) were not good,

(c) so we returned (d) the whole box.

Q15 Which part has an error? *Either the students / or the teacher / are responsible / for the damage.*

(a) Either the students **(b)** or the teacher
(c) are responsible **(d)** for the damage.

Q16 Choose the correct option: Mathematics _____ not as difficult as people think.

(a) are **(b)** were **(c)** is **(d)** have been

5.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which part has an error? *He is one of those / leaders who / has always / served the people.*

(a) He is one of those **(b)** leaders who
(c) has always **(d)** served the people.

Q18 Which part has an error? *Many a student / have failed / to understand / this chapter.*

(a) Many a student **(b)** have failed **(c)** to understand **(d)** this chapter.

Q19 Choose the correct option: He is the only one of the applicants who _____ the required experience.

(a) has **(b)** have **(c)** are having **(d)** were having

Q20 Which part has an error? *The secretary and treasurer / of the club / were present / at the meeting.*

(a) The secretary and treasurer **(b)** of the club
(c) were present **(d)** at the meeting.

Q21 Choose the correct option: Every man, woman and child _____ given a ration card.

(a) were **(b)** are **(c)** have been **(d)** was

Q22 Which part has an error? *Here comes / the members / of the committee / for the inspection.*

(a) Here comes **(b)** the members
(c) of the committee **(d)** for the inspection.

Q23 Choose the correct option: The rich _____ not always generous.

(a) is **(b)** are **(c)** was **(d)** has been

Q24 Which part has an error? *The United Nations / have passed / a resolution / on climate change.*

(a) The United Nations **(b)** have passed
(c) a resolution **(d)** on climate change.

Q25 Choose the correct option: More than one employee _____ complained about the new policy.

(a) have **(b)** has **(c)** are **(d)** were

5.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (a) is**

The subject is "list" (singular); "of names" is a phrase: **is**.

Q2 **Answer: (b) are**

Two people joined by "and": plural **are**.

Q3 **Answer: (d) knows**

"Everyone" is singular: **knows**.

Q4 **Answer: (c) were**

With "neither … nor" the verb agrees with the nearer subject, "students": **were**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) is**

"The number of" takes a singular verb: **is**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) are**

"A number of" means "many": plural **are**.

Q7 **Answer: (b) are**

Inverted sentence; the subject "mistakes" is plural: **are**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) gets**

"Each" is singular: **gets**.

Q9 **Answer: (b) is**

"Along with" does not join subjects; the verb agrees with "manager": **is**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) is**

"Bread and butter" is one dish: singular **is**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) is**

A sum of money as one amount: singular **is**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) lives**

The subject is "one": **lives**.

Q13 **Answer: (d) were**

"Their opinions" shows the members acting separately: plural **were**.

Q14 **Answer: (b) were not good,**

The subject is "quality" (singular): **was** not good.

Q15 **Answer: (c) are responsible**

The nearer subject is "teacher" (singular): **is** responsible.

Q16 **Answer: (c) is**

Subject names in -ics are singular: **is**.

Q17 **Answer: (c) has always**

"Who" refers to "leaders" (plural): who **have** always served.

Q18 **Answer: (b) have failed**

"Many a" + singular noun takes a singular verb: **has** failed.

Q19 **Answer: (a) has**

"Who" refers to "the only one" (singular): **has**.

Q20 **Answer: (c) were present**

With one article, "secretary and treasurer" is one person: **was** present.

Q21 **Answer: (d) was**

"Every" before nouns joined by "and" makes the subject singular: **was**.

Q22 **Answer: (a) Here comes**

The subject "members" is plural: **Here come**.

Q23 **Answer: (b) are**

"The rich" means rich people: plural **are**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) have passed**

The name of one organisation is singular: **has** passed.

Q25 **Answer: (b) has**

"More than one" + singular noun takes a singular verb: **has**.

Find the real subject by ignoring phrases between it and the verb. And = plural (unless one idea); or/nor = nearer subject; as well as/along with = first subject. Each, every, everyone, many a, more than one, the number of, amounts and titles are singular. A number of, the rich and police are plural. In "one of those who", the verb is plural.

MODULE 06 · BEGINNER

Adjectives, adverbs, prepositions and conjunctions

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

These words modify and connect ideas, and each has its own common errors. This module covers degrees of comparison, double comparatives, the order of adjectives, Latin comparatives, kinds and positions of adverbs, adjective versus adverb, hardly and no sooner, prepositions of time, place and direction, fixed prepositions, unnecessary prepositions, kinds of conjunctions, correlative pairs and parallel structure, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

6.1 Adjectives
6.2 Adverbs
6.3 Prepositions
6.4 Conjunctions
6.5 Practice questions
6.6 Solutions

6.1 Adjectives

6.1.1 Degrees of comparison

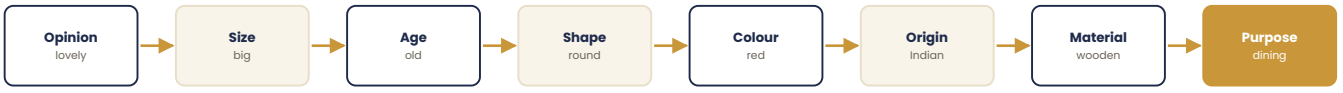
Adjective	Comparative	Superlative	Rule
tall	taller	tallest	one syllable: -er, -est
big	bigger	biggest	double the final consonant
happy	happier	happiest	-y → -ier, -iest
beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful	long words: more, most
good / bad	better / worse	best / worst	irregular
many / much	more	most	irregular
little	less	least	irregular
far	farther / further	farthest / furthest	farther = distance; further = more, additional

Use the comparative for two things (*the taller of the two*) and the superlative for three or more (*the tallest in the class*). Compare like with like: *The climate of Shimla is cooler than* ***that of*** *Delhi* (not "than Delhi").

6.1.2 Double comparatives

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
This plan is more better.	This plan is better.	double comparative
She is the most cleverest.	She is the cleverest.	double superlative
This is the most unique design.	This design is unique.	absolute adjective: unique, perfect, complete, ideal

6.1.3 Order of adjectives



OSASCOMP: A LOVELY BIG OLD ROUND RED INDIAN WOODEN DINING TABLE

6.1.4 Latin comparatives

Adjectives ending in -ior (*superior, inferior, senior, junior, prior, anterior, posterior*) and *prefer* take **to**, not "than": *He is senior **to** me. I prefer tea **to** coffee.*

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
He is senior than me.	He is senior to me.	Latin comparative + to
This model is more superior to that.	This model is superior to that.	no "more" with -ior
I prefer walking than running.	I prefer walking to running.	prefer … to

6.2 Adverbs

6.2.1 Types and position of adverbs

Type	Answers	Examples	Usual position
Manner	how?	quickly, carefully, well	after the verb or object
Place	where?	here, outside, everywhere	after the verb or object
Time	when?	now, yesterday, soon	end (or start) of the clause
Frequency	how often?	always, often, never, usually	before the main verb, after "be"
Degree	how much?	very, quite, too, almost	before the word it modifies

Frequency adverbs: *She **always** arrives early. She is **always** early. She has **never** been late.* Order at the end of a clause: manner, place, time: *He worked **hard at the office yesterday**.*

6.2.2 Adjective vs adverb

Adjectives describe nouns; adverbs describe verbs, adjectives and other adverbs. After linking verbs (be, seem, look, feel, taste, smell, sound, become) use an adjective.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
He did good in the test.	He did well in the test.	well describes "did"
She speaks English fluent.	She speaks English fluently.	adverb for verb
The soup tastes deliciously.	The soup tastes delicious.	linking verb + adjective
I feel badly about it.	I feel bad about it.	linking verb + adjective

Word	Meaning	Example
hard / hardly	with effort / almost not	He works hard. He hardly works.
late / lately	not on time / recently	She came late. I have not seen her lately.
near / nearly	close / almost	Sit near me. It is nearly ten.

6.2.3 "Hardly", "scarcely", "no sooner … than"

Hardly / scarcely … when (not "than"); **no sooner … than** (not "when"). At the start of a sentence they invert the verb: *No sooner **had he** left than it rained. Hardly **had I** sat down when the phone rang.* Do not add another negative: "I can't hardly" is wrong.

6.3 Prepositions

6.3.1 Prepositions of time, place and direction

Preposition	Time	Place
at	exact times: at 6 pm, at night, at noon	a point: at the door, at the station
on	days and dates: on Monday, on 5 May	a surface: on the table, on the wall
in	months, years, parts of day: in May, in 2025, in the morning	inside an area: in the room, in Delhi
since / for	point / period (with perfect tenses)	—
by / until	by = not later than; until = up to that time	—

Direction pair	Meaning
into / in	into = movement inside (He jumped into the pool); in = position (He is in the pool)
onto / on	movement onto a surface / position on it
between / among	between two; among more than two
beside / besides	beside = next to; besides = in addition to

6.3.2 Fixed prepositions

Word + preposition	Word + preposition	Word + preposition
interested in	good at	afraid of
agree with (a person)	agree to (a proposal)	agree on (a point)
angry with (person) / at (thing)	depend on	consist of
congratulate on	accuse of	charge with
different from	similar to	married to
aware of	capable of	responsible for
insist on	prevent from	refrain from
comply with	superior to	abide by

6.3.3 Unnecessary prepositions

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Let us discuss about the plan.	Let us discuss the plan.	discuss takes no preposition
He entered into the room.	He entered the room.	enter (a place) takes no preposition
She married with a doctor.	She married a doctor.	marry takes no preposition
Please reply the email.	Please reply to the email.	reply needs "to"

Other verbs that take no preposition: *attack, reach, resemble, request, order, approach, accompany, emphasise, describe*. Verbs that need one: *reply to, listen to, wait for, explain to (someone), object to*.

6.4 Conjunctions

6.4.1 Coordinating, subordinating and correlative conjunctions

Kind	Words	Example
Coordinating (FANBOYS)	for, and, nor, but, or, yet, so	It was late, so we left.
Subordinating	because, although, though, if, unless, when, while, since, until, as, whereas	Although it rained, we played.
Correlative (pairs)	not only … but also, both … and, either … or, neither … nor, whether … or	Both Ravi and Asha passed.

WATCH OUT
Do not double up: "Although … **but**" and "Because … **so**" are wrong. Use one conjunction: "Although he was ill, he came" or "He was ill, but he came". "Though … yet" is an accepted pair in Indian test papers.

6.4.2 Correlative pairs

Correct pair	Common error
not only … but also	not only … as well as
both … and	both … as well as
neither … nor	neither … or
either … or	either … nor
no sooner … than	no sooner … when
hardly … when	hardly … than
so … that	such … that (with a noun)
lest … should	lest … not

6.4.3 Parallel structure with correlatives

The words after each part of a correlative pair must be the same grammatical form.

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
She not only sings but also is dancing.	She not only sings but also dances.	verb + verb
He is either in the office or he is at home.	He is either in the office or at home.	phrase + phrase
Not only he plays cricket but also football.	He plays not only cricket but also football.	noun + noun

6.5 Practice questions

6.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct option: Ravi is the _____ of the two brothers.

(a) tallest **(b)** more tall **(c)** most tall **(d)** taller

Q2 Choose the correct option: She sings _____.

(a) beautifully **(b)** beautiful **(c)** beauty **(d)** more beautiful

Q3 Choose the correct preposition: The meeting is _____ Monday.

(a) in **(b)** at **(c)** on **(d)** by

Q4 Choose the correct preposition: He is interested _____ music.

(a) on **(b)** at **(c)** for **(d)** in

Q5 Choose the correct option: The flowers smell _____.

(a) sweetly **(b)** sweet **(c)** sweetness **(d)** more sweetly

Q6 Choose the correct option: He is senior _____ me by two years.

(a) to **(b)** than **(c)** from **(d)** over

Q7 Choose the correct option: Divide the sweets _____ the three children.

(a) between **(b)** with **(c)** among **(d)** within

Q8 Choose the correct option: She plays both the piano _____ the guitar.

(a) and **(b)** or **(c)** as well as **(d)** nor

6.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Which part has an error? *This is the / most unique painting / I have ever / seen.*

(a) This is the **(b)** most unique painting
(c) I have ever **(d)** seen.

Q10 Which part has an error? *Let us / discuss about / the problem / tomorrow.*

(a) Let us **(b)** discuss about **(c)** the problem **(d)** tomorrow.

Q11 Choose the correct option: No sooner had he reached the station _____ the train left.

(a) when **(b)** than **(c)** then **(d)** that

Q12 Choose the correct option: Hardly had I entered the room _____ the lights went out.

(a) than **(b)** then **(c)** that **(d)** when

Q13 Which part has an error? *The climate of Ooty / is cooler / than Chennai / in summer.*

(a) The climate of Ooty **(b)** is cooler
(c) than Chennai **(d)** in summer.

Q14 Choose the correct order: She bought a _____ table.

(a) small beautiful wooden round **(b)** wooden round small beautiful
(c) beautiful small round wooden **(d)** round beautiful small wooden

Q15 Choose the correct option: I prefer reading _____ watching television.

(a) than **(b)** over than **(c)** to **(d)** rather

Q16 Which part has an error? *Although he worked hard, / but he could not / clear the / examination.*

(a) Although he worked hard, **(b)** but he could not
(c) clear the **(d)** examination.

6.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which part has an error? *She not only / completed the report / but also she presented / it to the board.*

(a) She not only **(b)** completed the report
(c) but also she presented **(d)** it to the board.

Q18 Which part has an error? *He entered into / the room quietly / so that no one / would notice him.*

(a) He entered into **(b)** the room quietly
(c) so that no one **(d)** would notice him.

Q19 Choose the correct option: I have not seen him _____.

(a) late **(b)** later **(c)** latest **(d)** lately

Q20 Choose the correct option: He hardly _____ any mistakes in his work.

(a) doesn't make **(b)** makes **(c)** never makes **(d)** not makes

Q21 Which part has an error? *Neither the manager / or his assistant / was able to / answer the question.*

(a) Neither the manager **(b)** or his assistant
(c) was able to **(d)** answer the question.

Q22 Choose the correct option: She is angry _____ her brother for breaking her phone.

(a) with **(b)** on **(c)** at **(d)** to

Q23 Which part has an error? *Walk carefully / lest you / should not / fall.*

(a) Walk carefully **(b)** lest you **(c)** should not **(d)** fall.

Q24 Choose the correct option: The committee agreed _____ the proposal after a long debate.

(a) with **(b)** to **(c)** on **(d)** for

Q25 Choose the correct option: For _____ details, contact the help desk.

(a) further **(b)** farther **(c)** farthest **(d)** far

6.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (d) taller**

For two people use the comparative: **taller**.

Q2 **Answer: (a) beautifully**

An adverb is needed to describe the verb "sings": **beautifully**.

Q3 **Answer: (c) on**

Days take **on**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) in**

Fixed preposition: interested **in**.

Q5 **Answer: (b) sweet**

"Smell" is a linking verb here, so an adjective follows: **sweet**.

Q6 **Answer: (a) to**

Latin comparatives take **to**.

Q7 **Answer: (c) among**

More than two: **among**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) and**

"Both" pairs with **and**.

Q9 **Answer: (b) most unique painting**

"Unique" is absolute and cannot be compared: **a unique painting** / the only one of its kind.

Q10 **Answer: (b) discuss about**

"Discuss" takes no preposition: **discuss the problem**.

Q11 **Answer: (b) than**

"No sooner" pairs with **than**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) when**

"Hardly" pairs with **when**.

Q13 **Answer: (c) than Chennai**

Compare like with like (climate with climate): than **that of** Chennai.

Q14 **Answer: (c) beautiful small round wooden**

OSASCOMP: opinion (beautiful), size (small), shape (round), material (wooden).

Q15 **Answer: (c) to**

"Prefer … to": I prefer reading **to** watching television.

Q16 **Answer: (b) but he could not**

"Although" and "but" cannot both be used: remove **but**.

Q17 **Answer: (c) but also she presented**

Parallel structure: not only completed … but also **presented** (remove "she").

Q18 **Answer: (a) He entered into**

"Enter" a place takes no preposition: **He entered the room**.

Q19 **Answer: (d) lately**

"Lately" means recently.

Q20 **Answer: (b) makes**

"Hardly" is already negative; adding another negative is wrong: he hardly **makes**.

Q21 **Answer: (b) or his assistant**

"Neither" pairs with **nor**.

Q22 **Answer: (a) with**

Angry **with** a person; angry at or about a thing.

Q23 **Answer: (c) should not**

"Lest" is already negative; it is followed by **should** (not "should not").

Q24 **Answer: (b) to**

Agree **to** a proposal; agree with a person.

Q25 **Answer: (a) further**

"Further" means additional; "farther" refers to physical distance.

No double comparatives; unique/perfect cannot be compared; senior/superior/prefer take "to"; compare like with like. Use adjectives after linking verbs and adverbs for verbs. No sooner … than; hardly … when. Learn fixed prepositions and drop unnecessary ones (discuss, enter, marry). Use one conjunction, correct correlative pairs and parallel forms.

MODULE 07 · BEGINNER

Vocabulary-building strategies

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Beginner**

A strong vocabulary improves every verbal question type. This module teaches how to learn words efficiently: common Latin and Greek roots, negative prefixes and meaning-changing suffixes, learning words in context, mnemonics, word families, spaced repetition, using new words, guessing meaning from context, and using dictionaries and thesauruses well, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

7.1 Word roots
7.2 Prefixes and suffixes
7.3 Learning techniques
7.4 Guessing meaning from context
7.5 Using dictionaries and thesauruses well
7.6 Practice questions
7.7 Solutions

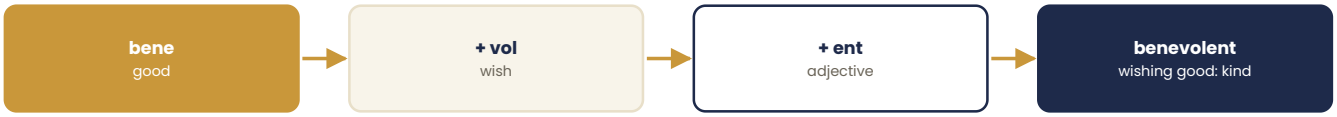
7.1 Word roots

7.1.1 Common Latin and Greek roots

Most long English words are built from a small set of Latin and Greek parts. Knowing one root unlocks a whole family of words.

Root	Meaning	Examples
bene	good, well	benefit, benevolent, benefactor
mal	bad	malfunction, malicious, malnutrition
chron	time	chronology, chronic, synchronise
graph / gram	write, draw	autograph, biography, telegram
dict	say	predict, dictate, contradict, verdict
spect	look	inspect, spectator, retrospect, perspective
port	carry	transport, portable, export, import
scrib / script	write	describe, manuscript, prescription
ver	true	verify, verdict, veracity
vid / vis	see	video, visible, evident, vision
aud	hear	audible, audience, audit
cred	believe	credible, incredible, credentials
mort	death	mortal, immortal, mortgage

Root	Meaning	Examples
phil	love	philosophy, philanthropist, bibliophile
phob	fear	claustrophobia, xenophobia
loqu / log	speak, word, study	eloquent, dialogue, biology
omni	all	omnipotent, omniscient, omnivore
ambi / amphi	both	ambiguous, ambivalent, amphibian



BREAKING A WORD INTO PARTS

7.2 Prefixes and suffixes

7.2.1 Negative prefixes

Prefix	Examples	Note
un-	unhappy, unusual, unaware	most common
in- / im- / il- / ir-	inactive, impossible, illegal, irregular	im- before b, m, p; il- before l; ir- before r
dis-	dishonest, disagree, disappear	often with verbs
mis-	misunderstand, misuse, mislead	wrongly
non-	non-violent, nonsense, non-stop	simply "not"
a- / an-	atypical, amoral, anarchy	without

WATCH OUT
Not every "in-" is negative: *inflammable* means easily set on fire (the same as flammable), and *invaluable* means extremely valuable.

7.2.2 Common suffixes and how they change parts of speech

Suffix	Makes a	Examples
-tion, -sion, -ment, -ness, -ity, -ance, -ence	noun	creation, decision, development, kindness, ability, tolerance
-er, -or, -ist, -ian	noun (person)	teacher, actor, scientist, musician
-ize / -ise, -ify, -ate, -en	verb	modernise, simplify, activate, strengthen
-able, -ible, -ful, -less, -ous, -ive, -al, -ic	adjective	readable, visible, careful, careless, famous, active, natural, poetic

Suffix	Makes a	Examples
-ly	adverb	quickly, happily

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
decision	decide	decisive	decisively
strength	strengthen	strong	strongly
simplicity	simplify	simple	simply
success	succeed	successful	successfully

7.3 Learning techniques

7.3.1 Learning words in context from reading

Words learnt from a sentence you have read stick far better than words learnt from a list. When you meet a new word, copy the whole sentence into your notebook.

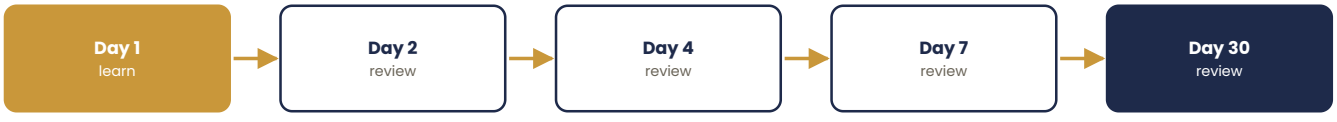
7.3.2 Mnemonics and word stories

Word	Meaning	Memory hook
gregarious	fond of company	"Greg is never alone at parties"
lethargic	sluggish, lacking energy	sounds like "lazy-thargic"
ostracise	exclude from a group	like an ostrich hiding: pushed out of sight
candid	frank, honest	a candid camera shows the truth
meticulous	very careful about details	"Me tick (every) lous(e)"

7.3.3 Word families and thematic groups

Learn related words together: **talking** (verbose, laconic, loquacious, taciturn, eloquent); **money** (frugal, thrifty, extravagant, miserly, lavish); **courage** (intrepid, valiant, timid, cowardly, audacious).

7.3.4 Spaced repetition with flashcards



REVIEW JUST BEFORE YOU WOULD FORGET

Apps such as Anki schedule each card automatically: easy words come back rarely, hard words often. Ten minutes a day is enough.

7.3.5 Using new words in sentences

A word is truly learnt only when you can use it. Write two sentences of your own for every new word, and try to use one new word in conversation or writing each day.

7.4 Guessing meaning from context

Clue type	Signal words	Example
Definition	is, means, that is, or	He was a **philatelist**, that is, a collector of stamps.
Synonym	also, likewise, similarly	She was **affable**; her brother was similarly friendly.
Contrast	but, however, unlike, although	Unlike his **garrulous** sister, he spoke little. (garrulous = talkative)
Example	such as, for example, including	**Nocturnal** animals, such as owls and bats, hunt at night.
Cause and effect	because, so, therefore	He was **destitute**, so he could not even buy food. (destitute = very poor)

SHORTCUT TRICK
Replace the unknown word with a blank and decide what kind of word fits: positive or negative, strong or mild. That alone often removes two options.

7.5 Using dictionaries and thesauruses well

A good learner's dictionary gives the pronunciation, part of speech, all the meanings in order of frequency, example sentences, and usage labels (formal, informal, old-fashioned). A thesaurus lists words of similar meaning, but they are rarely exact substitutes: check each one in a dictionary before using it.

WATCH OUT
Do not pick the longest word from a thesaurus. "He was very *pertinacious* about tea" is not better English than "He was very fond of tea".

7.6 Practice questions

7.6.1 Basic level

Q1 The root "chron" means

(a) colour (b) chain (c) time (d) growth

Q2 The root "spect" in "spectator" means

(a) speak (b) carry (c) believe (d) look

Q3 Choose the correct negative form of "legal".

(a) unlegal (b) inlegal (c) dislegal (d) illegal

Q4 Choose the correct negative form of "responsible".

(a) unresponsible (b) inresponsible (c) irresponsible (d) disresponsible

Q5 Which suffix turns "modern" into a verb?

(a) -ise (b) -ness (c) -ly (d) -ful

Q6 "Benefactor" most nearly means

(a) a person who causes harm (b) a factory owner
(c) a judge (d) a person who gives help or money

Q7 Choose the adjective form of "decide".

(a) decision (b) decisive (c) decisively (d) decided upon

Q8 "Audible" means

(a) easy to see (b) loud enough to be heard
(c) able to be believed (d) easy to carry

7.6.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: Unlike his **taciturn** brother, Ravi talks to everyone.

(a) talkative (b) angry
(c) intelligent (d) reserved, saying little

Q10 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: The medicine **alleviated** the pain, and she could finally sleep.

(a) reduced (b) increased (c) caused (d) ignored

Q11 "Inflammable" means

(a) not able to burn (b) swollen
(c) easily set on fire (d) fireproof

Q12 "Omniscient" means

(a) present everywhere (b) all-powerful
(c) eating everything (d) knowing everything

Q13 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: Nocturnal animals, such as owls and bats, are active at

night; **diurnal** animals are active during the day.

(a) active at night **(b)** active in the daytime
(c) living in water **(d)** sleeping all the time

Q14 "Malevolent" is the opposite of

(a) benevolent **(b)** malicious **(c)** violent **(d)** malignant

Q15 Choose the noun form of "simple".

(a) simplify **(b)** simply **(c)** simplicity **(d)** simplistic

Q16 "Incredible" literally means

(a) not able to be believed **(b)** not able to be heard
(c) without credit **(d)** very expensive

7.6.3 Advanced level

Q17 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: The company's profits were **meagre**, so it could not pay a bonus this year.

(a) very large **(b)** very small **(c)** growing **(d)** secret

Q18 Which word belongs to the same family as "loquacious"?

(a) location **(b)** lucid **(c)** logo **(d)** eloquent

Q19 "Ambivalent" means

(a) walking on both sides **(b)** very ambitious
(c) having mixed feelings **(d)** completely certain

Q20 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: Although the speech was long, it was so **lucid** that everyone understood it.

(a) boring **(b)** confusing **(c)** clear **(d)** loud

Q21 "Invaluable" means

(a) worthless **(b)** cheap
(c) not yet valued **(d)** extremely useful

Q22 "Retrospect" means

(a) a look into the future **(b)** a look back at the past
(c) a careful inspection **(d)** a respectful bow

Q23 Guess the meaning of the word in bold: The new manager was **affable**; within a week everyone felt comfortable approaching her.

(a) friendly and easy to talk to **(b)** strict
(c) shy **(d)** lazy

Q24 Choose the word whose prefix does NOT mean "not".

(a) inactive **(b)** intensify **(c)** incorrect **(d)** invisible

Q25 "Philanthropist" means

(a) a person who helps others, especially with money

(b) a person who hates people
(c) a stamp collector
(d) a lover of books

7.7 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) time**

Chron means time: chronology, chronic, synchronise.

Q2 **Answer: (d) look**

Spect means look: inspect, spectacle, perspective.

Q3 **Answer: (d) illegal**

Before l, "in-" becomes **il-**: illegal.

Q4 **Answer: (c) irresponsible**

Before r, "in-" becomes **ir-**: irresponsible.

Q5 **Answer: (a) -ise**

Modern + **ise** = modernise (a verb).

Q6 **Answer: (d) a person who gives help or money**

"Bene" (good) + "factor" (doer): someone who **does good**, giving help or money.

Q7 **Answer: (b) decisive**

Decisive is the adjective; decision is the noun and decisively the adverb.

Q8 **Answer: (b) loud enough to be heard**

"Aud" means hear: **able to be heard**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) reserved, saying little**

"Unlike" signals contrast with someone who "talks to everyone": **saying little**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) reduced**

She could sleep afterwards, so the pain was **reduced**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) easily set on fire**

"In-" here is not negative; **inflammable** means the same as flammable.

Q12 **Answer: (d) knowing everything**

"Omni" (all) + "scient" (knowing): **knowing everything**. All-powerful is omnipotent.

Q13 **Answer: (b) active in the daytime**

The definition clue follows the word: active **during the day**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) benevolent**

"Mal" (bad) vs "bene" (good): malevolent (wishing harm) is the opposite of **benevolent** (wishing good).

Q15 **Answer: (c) simplicity**

Simplicity is the noun; simplify is the verb.

Q16 **Answer: (a) not able to be believed**

"In" (not) + "cred" (believe) + "ible" (able): **not believable**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) very small**

No bonus could be paid, so profits were **very small**.

Q18 **Answer: (d) eloquent**

"Loqu" means speak: loquacious (talkative) and **eloquent** (fluent in speech).

Q19 **Answer: (c) having mixed feelings**

"Ambi" (both) + "valent" (strength): **pulled both ways**, having mixed feelings.

Q20 **Answer: (c) clear**

"So … that everyone understood" shows it was **clear**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) extremely useful**

Despite the prefix, **invaluable** means so valuable that its worth cannot be measured.

Q22 **Answer: (b) a look back at the past**

"Retro" (back) + "spect" (look): **looking back**.

Q23 **Answer: (a) friendly and easy to talk to**

People felt comfortable approaching her: **friendly**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) intensify**

In **intensify**, "in" is part of the root "intense"; in the others "in-" means not.

Q25 **Answer: (a) a person who helps others, especially with money**

"Phil" (love) + "anthrop" (human): a lover of humanity who **helps others**. A hater of people is a misanthrope.

Learn roots (bene, mal, chron, graph, dict, spect, port, cred, aud, vid) and prefixes (un-, in-/im-/il-/ir-, dis-, mis-, non-); suffixes tell you the part of speech. Learn words in context, in families, with mnemonics and spaced repetition, and use each new word in two sentences. Guess meanings from definition, contrast, example and cause clues.

MODULE 08 · BEGINNER

Synonyms and antonyms

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Beginner**

Synonym and antonym questions directly test the range and precision of your vocabulary. This module covers exact and near synonyms, choosing by context, connotation, antonyms formed by prefixes and by different words, degrees of opposition, a list of high-frequency placement-test words, contextual synonyms and antonyms in passages, and the elimination strategy, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

8.1 Synonyms
8.2 Antonyms
8.3 High-frequency test words
8.4 Contextual synonyms and antonyms in passages
8.5 Elimination strategy
8.6 Practice questions
8.7 Solutions

8.1 Synonyms

8.1.1 Exact vs near synonyms

Few words are exact synonyms. *Big* and *large* are close, but we say "a big mistake", not "a large mistake". Tests usually ask for the **closest** meaning among the options.

8.1.2 Choosing by context

Word	Sentence	Best synonym here
grave	The patient is in a **grave** condition.	serious
grave	He visited his grandfather's **grave**.	tomb
fair	The judge was **fair** to both sides.	just
fair	We went to the village **fair**.	carnival
sound	She gave **sound** advice.	sensible

8.1.3 Connotation

Positive	Neutral	Negative
slim	thin	skinny
thrifty	economical	stingy
confident	self-assured	arrogant

Positive	Neutral	Negative
curious	inquisitive	nosy
determined	firm	stubborn

SHORTCUT TRICK
If the passage praises someone, the right synonym will be positive too. Connotation alone often removes two options.

8.2 Antonyms

8.2.1 Opposites by prefix and by different words

Some antonyms are formed with a prefix (*honest – dishonest, possible – impossible, legal – illegal*); others are different words (*generous – miserly, ancient – modern, expand – contract*).

8.2.2 Degrees of opposition



A SCALE OF MEANING: THE ANTONYM OF "FREEZING" IS "SCORCHING", NOT "WARM"

Choose the antonym of the same strength: the opposite of *ecstatic* (extremely happy) is *miserable*, not merely *sad*.

8.3 High-frequency test words

8.3.1 Common placement-test vocabulary

Word	Synonym	Antonym	Word	Synonym	Antonym
abate	lessen	intensify	frugal	thrifty	extravagant
abundant	plentiful	scarce	gregarious	sociable	reserved
adversity	hardship	prosperity	hostile	unfriendly	friendly
affluent	wealthy	poor	impartial	unbiased	biased
alleviate	relieve	aggravate	inevitable	unavoidable	avoidable
ambiguous	unclear	explicit	lucid	clear	obscure
amiable	friendly	hostile	meticulous	careful	careless
arrogant	haughty	humble	novice	beginner	expert
benevolent	kind	malevolent	obstinate	stubborn	flexible

Word	Synonym	Antonym	Word	Synonym	Antonym
brevity	conciseness	verbosity	optimistic	hopeful	pessimistic
candid	frank	evasive	prudent	wise	reckless
cordial	warm	unfriendly	reluctant	unwilling	eager
cynical	distrustful	trusting	scrutinise	examine	overlook
diligent	hard-working	lazy	tranquil	calm	turbulent
eminent	distinguished	obscure	vague	unclear	precise
ephemeral	short-lived	permanent	zeal	enthusiasm	apathy

8.4 Contextual synonyms and antonyms in passages

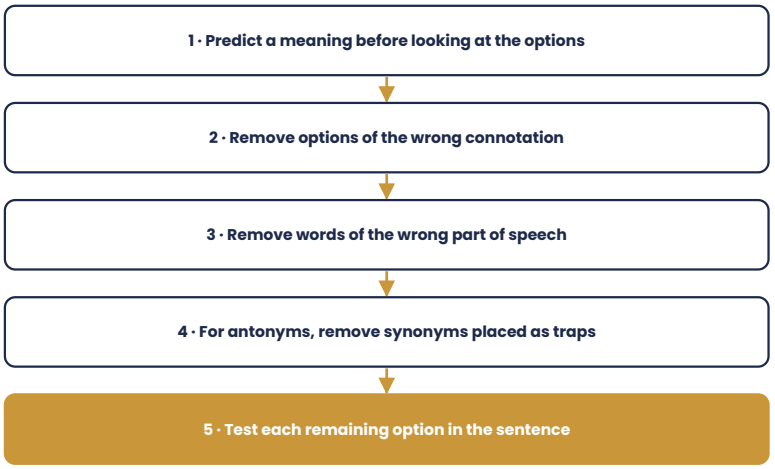
In passage-based questions, the word may be used in a less common sense. Always reread the sentence and replace the word with each option: the right one keeps the meaning of the sentence exactly.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Contextual meaning

Passage: "The committee will **table** the proposal at its next meeting." Here *table* means **present for discussion** (in British usage), not a piece of furniture.

8.5 Elimination strategy



ELIMINATION STEPS

WATCH OUT

Antonym questions almost always include a synonym among the options as a trap. Read the question word carefully: synonym or antonym?

8.6 Practice questions

8.6.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the synonym of DILIGENT.

(a) lazy (b) intelligent (c) hard-working (d) careless

Q2 Choose the antonym of ABUNDANT.

(a) plentiful (b) large (c) rich (d) scarce

Q3 Choose the synonym of CANDID.

(a) sweet (b) secretive (c) clever (d) frank

Q4 Choose the antonym of OPTIMISTIC.

(a) hopeful (b) realistic (c) pessimistic (d) cheerful

Q5 Choose the synonym of TRANQUIL.

(a) calm (b) noisy (c) busy (d) cold

Q6 Choose the antonym of HOSTILE.

(a) aggressive (b) unfriendly (c) angry (d) friendly

Q7 Choose the synonym of NOVICE.

(a) expert (b) beginner (c) author (d) nurse

Q8 Choose the antonym of PERMANENT.

(a) lasting (b) temporary (c) durable (d) fixed

8.6.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the synonym of FRUGAL.

(a) generous (b) wasteful (c) rich (d) thrifty

Q10 Choose the antonym of ALLEVIATE.

(a) aggravate (b) relieve (c) reduce (d) soothe

Q11 Choose the synonym of AMBIGUOUS.

(a) definite (b) ambitious (c) unclear (d) double

Q12 Choose the antonym of OBSTINATE.

(a) stubborn (b) determined (c) firm (d) flexible

Q13 Choose the word closest in meaning to the word in bold: The report contained a **meticulous** analysis of the data.

(a) quick (b) thorough (c) rough (d) confusing

Q14 Choose the word closest in meaning to the word in bold: The patient's condition is **grave**.

(a) serious (b) buried (c) improving (d) quiet

Q15 Choose the antonym of EPHEMERAL.

(a) brief (b) fleeting (c) everlasting (d) momentary

Q16 Choose the synonym of EMINENT.

(a) distinguished (b) dangerous
(c) about to happen (d) ordinary

8.6.3 Advanced level

Q17 Choose the antonym of VERBOSE.

(a) wordy (b) concise (c) talkative (d) loud

Q18 Choose the word that best replaces the word in bold without changing the meaning: The new law will **curb** pollution in the city.

(a) increase (b) measure (c) ignore (d) restrain

Q19 Choose the antonym of the word in bold: The minister's reply was **evasive**.

(a) vague (b) polite (c) direct (d) lengthy

Q20 Choose the synonym of PRUDENT.

(a) rash (b) proud (c) sensible (d) shy

Q21 Choose the word with a negative connotation that is closest in meaning to "economical".

(a) thrifty (b) prudent (c) frugal (d) stingy

Q22 Choose the antonym of ZEAL.

(a) passion (b) apathy (c) eagerness (d) energy

Q23 Choose the word closest in meaning to the word in bold: The committee will **scrutinise** every application.

(a) examine closely (b) reject
(c) collect (d) approve quickly

Q24 Choose the antonym of AFFLUENT.

(a) wealthy (b) impoverished (c) fluent (d) prosperous

Q25 Choose the antonym of the word in bold: Her **ecstatic** response surprised everyone.

(a) miserable (b) sad (c) joyful (d) calm

8.7 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) hard-working**

Diligent means showing care and effort: hard-working.

Q2 **Answer: (d) scarce**

Abundant = plentiful; its opposite is **scarce**. "Plentiful" is the synonym trap.

Q3 **Answer: (d) frank**

Candid = honest and direct: frank.

Q4 **Answer: (c) pessimistic**

The opposite of expecting good outcomes is **pessimistic**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) calm**

Tranquil = peaceful, calm.

Q6 **Answer: (d) friendly**

Hostile = unfriendly; opposite: **friendly**.

Q7 **Answer: (b) beginner**

Novice = a person new to an activity: beginner.

Q8 **Answer: (b) temporary**

Opposite of lasting for ever: **temporary**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) thrifty**

Frugal = careful with money: thrifty.

Q10 **Answer: (a) aggravate**

Alleviate = make less severe; opposite: **aggravate** (make worse).

Q11 **Answer: (c) unclear**

Ambiguous = open to more than one meaning: unclear.

Q12 **Answer: (d) flexible**

Obstinate = stubborn; opposite: **flexible**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) thorough**

A meticulous analysis pays great attention to detail: **thorough**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) serious**

In this context "grave" means **serious**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) everlasting**

Ephemeral = short-lived; opposite: **everlasting**. The other three are synonyms.

Q16 **Answer: (a) distinguished**

Eminent = famous and respected. "About to happen" is "imminent", a common confusion.

Q17 **Answer: (b) concise**

Verbose = using too many words; opposite: **concise**.

Q18 **Answer: (d) restrain**

To curb is to keep in check: **restrain**.

Q19 **Answer: (c) direct**

Evasive = avoiding a clear answer; opposite: **direct**.

Q20 **Answer: (c) sensible**

Prudent = acting with care and thought for the future: sensible.

Q21 **Answer: (d) stingy**

All four relate to saving money, but only **stingy** is negative.

Q22 **Answer: (b) apathy**

Zeal = great enthusiasm; opposite: **apathy** (lack of interest).

Q23 **Answer: (a) examine closely**

To scrutinise is to **examine closely**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) impoverished**

Affluent = wealthy; opposite: **impoverished**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) miserable**

Ecstatic means extremely happy; the antonym of the same strength is **miserable**. "Sad" is weaker.

Choose the closest meaning in context, matching connotation and strength. In antonym questions watch for synonym traps. Learn high-frequency words with one synonym and one antonym each, and test every option back in the sentence.

MODULE 09 · BEGINNER

One-word substitution, idioms, phrases and phrasal verbs

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Beginner**

These questions test knowledge of fixed expressions and precise words. This module covers one-word substitutes for people, fields of study, governments, fears and manias, killings, places and collections; common idioms, using idioms correctly and business idioms; common phrasal verbs and verbs with many meanings; and natural collocations, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

9.1 One-word substitution
9.2 Idioms and phrases
9.3 Phrasal verbs
9.4 Collocations
9.5 Practice questions
9.6 Solutions

9.1 One-word substitution

9.1.1 People

Word	Meaning	Word	Meaning
philanthropist	one who loves and helps mankind	misanthrope	one who hates mankind
misogynist	one who hates women	polyglot	one who speaks many languages
optimist	one who expects the best	pessimist	one who expects the worst
atheist	one who does not believe in God	agnostic	one who believes God's existence cannot be known
egoist	one who thinks only of himself	altruist	one who lives for the good of others
novice	a beginner	veteran	one with long experience
amateur	one who does something for pleasure, not pay	connoisseur	an expert judge of art, food or wine
extrovert	an outgoing person	introvert	a person focused inward
insolvent / bankrupt	unable to pay debts	plagiarist	one who copies another's work as his own
hypocrite	one who pretends to be what he is not	cynic	one who doubts the goodness of others

9.1.2 Fields of study

Word	Study of	Word	Study of
anthropology	mankind	archaeology	ancient remains
entomology	insects	etymology	origin of words
ornithology	birds	seismology	earthquakes
numismatics	coins	philately	stamps (collecting)
pathology	diseases	zoology / botany	animals / plants
cardiology	the heart	dermatology	the skin

9.1.3 Governments and systems

Word	Rule by	Word	Rule by
democracy	the people	autocracy	one person with absolute power
monarchy	a king or queen	oligarchy	a small group
plutocracy	the wealthy	theocracy	religious leaders
bureaucracy	officials	anarchy	no government (disorder)

9.1.4 Fears and manias

Fear (-phobia)	of	Mania	Uncontrollable urge to
acrophobia	heights	kleptomania	steal
claustrophobia	closed spaces	pyromania	set things on fire
hydrophobia	water	megalomania	have power and greatness
xenophobia	foreigners	bibliomania	collect books
agoraphobia	open or crowded places	monomania	be obsessed with one thing

9.1.5 Killings, places and collections

Killing of	Word	Place / collection	Word
oneself	suicide	place for bees	apiary
one's father / mother	patricide / matricide	place for birds	aviary
a king	regicide	place for fish	aquarium
a whole race	genocide	place for orphans	orphanage
insects / germs	insecticide / germicide	collection of poems	anthology
a brother	fratricide	list of books	bibliography

Killing of	Word	Place / collection	Word
infants	infanticide	collection of words with meanings	dictionary / glossary

9.2 Idioms and phrases

9.2.1 Common idioms and their meanings

Idiom	Meaning	Idiom	Meaning
a piece of cake	very easy	once in a blue moon	very rarely
beat around the bush	avoid the main point	bite the bullet	face something difficult bravely
break the ice	start a conversation	burn the midnight oil	work late at night
cry over spilt milk	regret what cannot be changed	hit the nail on the head	say exactly the right thing
let the cat out of the bag	reveal a secret	a blessing in disguise	something good that seemed bad at first
cost an arm and a leg	be very expensive	under the weather	slightly ill
spill the beans	reveal a secret	at the eleventh hour	at the last moment
call it a day	stop working	in hot water	in trouble
a bolt from the blue	a complete surprise	bury the hatchet	make peace
turn a blind eye	ignore deliberately	red-letter day	a memorable day

9.2.2 Using idioms correctly in context

Idioms are fixed: you cannot change their words. "Break the ice", not "break the snow"; "the last straw", not "the final straw" (in tests). Also match the tone: idioms are informal and should be used sparingly in formal writing.

9.2.3 Business idioms used at work

Idiom	Meaning
touch base	make brief contact
on the same page	in agreement, sharing understanding
ballpark figure	rough estimate
back to the drawing board	start again after a failure
think outside the box	think creatively
the bottom line	the final result; the most important point

Idiom	Meaning
get the ball rolling	start something
in the loop	kept informed

9.3 Phrasal verbs

9.3.1 Common phrasal verbs

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Phrasal verb	Meaning
look into	investigate	put off	postpone
carry out	perform, execute	give up	stop, quit
bring up	raise (a child / a topic)	call off	cancel
come across	find by chance	figure out	understand, solve
look after	take care of	look up to	respect
run out of	have no more	put up with	tolerate
turn down	reject	set up	establish
break down	stop working / lose control of emotions	make up for	compensate for

9.3.2 One verb, many meanings

Phrasal verb	Meaning	Example
take off	leave the ground; remove; become successful	The plane took off. Her career took off.
take after	resemble a parent	She takes after her mother.
take over	gain control of	The firm was taken over by a rival.
take up	start a hobby; occupy (space or time)	He took up painting.
take in	deceive; understand; give shelter	Do not be taken in by the offer.
take back	withdraw a statement	I take back what I said.

9.4 Collocations

9.4.1 Natural word pairs

Correct	Not natural	Correct	Not natural
make a decision	do a decision	heavy rain	strong rain

Correct	Not natural	Correct	Not natural
do homework	make homework	strong coffee	powerful coffee
make a mistake	do a mistake	fast food	quick food
take a photo	make a photo	pay attention	give attention
catch a cold	get a cold (informal)	commit a crime	do a crime
meet a deadline	reach a deadline	deeply regret	strongly regret

SHORTCUT TRICK

MAKE is for creating or producing (make a plan, a noise, money); DO is for tasks and work (do the dishes, your best, business).

9.5 Practice questions

9.5.1 Basic level

Q1 One who can speak many languages

(a) linguist (b) orator (c) polyglot (d) bilingual

Q2 The study of insects

(a) etymology (b) ornithology (c) zoology (d) entomology

Q3 Government by the people

(a) autocracy (b) monarchy (c) oligarchy (d) democracy

Q4 Fear of heights

(a) claustrophobia (b) hydrophobia (c) acrophobia (d) xenophobia

Q5 What does "a piece of cake" mean?

(a) something very easy (b) a small reward
(c) a sweet dish (d) a share of profits

Q6 What does "put off" mean in: "The meeting has been put off till Monday"?

(a) cancelled (b) started (c) insulted (d) postponed

Q7 Choose the correct collocation: She _____ a decision after much thought.

(a) did (b) made (c) took up (d) gave

Q8 A place where bees are kept

(a) aviary (b) apiary (c) aquarium (d) granary

9.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 One who does not believe in God

(a) agnostic (b) theist (c) pagan (d) atheist

Q10 What does "burn the midnight oil" mean?

(a) work late into the night (b) waste resources
(c) start a fire (d) celebrate

Q11 What does "let the cat out of the bag" mean?

(a) create confusion (b) free someone
(c) reveal a secret (d) make a mistake

Q12 Choose the meaning of "look up to": Students look up to their teacher.

(a) search for (b) visit (c) complain about (d) respect

Q13 An irresistible urge to steal

(a) pyromania (b) kleptomania (c) megalomania (d) monomania

Q14 Choose the meaning of "take after": Riya takes after her father.

(a) resembles (b) follows (c) looks after (d) dislikes

Q15 Choose the correct collocation: It was raining _____ all night.

(a) strongly (b) powerfully (c) heavily (d) hardly

Q16 Government by a small group of powerful people

(a) oligarchy (b) plutocracy (c) bureaucracy (d) anarchy

9.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 What does "a blessing in disguise" mean?

(a) a hidden danger
(b) something good that at first seemed bad
(c) a secret gift
(d) a religious ceremony

Q18 Choose the meaning of "put up with": I cannot put up with this noise any longer.

(a) increase (b) record (c) stop (d) tolerate

Q19 One who copies another person's writing and passes it off as his own

(a) forger (b) imitator (c) plagiarist (d) editor

Q20 Choose the meaning of the idiom in bold: The project was cancelled **at the eleventh hour**.

(a) at night (b) after a long delay
(c) at the last possible moment (d) at the beginning

Q21 Choose the meaning of "call off": The strike was called off after talks.

(a) announced (b) started (c) extended (d) cancelled

Q22 A collection of poems

(a) bibliography (b) anthology (c) glossary (d) biography

Q23 Choose the meaning of the business idiom: "Can you give me a **ballpark figure** for the cost?"

(a) a rough estimate (b) an exact amount
(c) a sports score (d) a final bill

Q24 The killing of a king

(a) patricide (b) regicide (c) genocide (d) homicide

Q25 Choose the meaning of "take in": The old man was taken in by the fake bank call.

(a) deceived (b) admitted to hospital
(c) given shelter (d) arrested

9.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) polyglot**

A **polyglot** speaks many languages; a linguist studies language.

Q2 **Answer: (d) entomology**

Entomology is the study of insects; etymology is the origin of words.

Q3 **Answer: (d) democracy**

Democracy: rule by the people.

Q4 **Answer: (c) acrophobia**

Acrophobia: fear of heights.

Q5 **Answer: (a) something very easy**

A piece of cake = **very easy**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) postponed**

"Put off" = **postpone**.

Q7 **Answer: (b) made**

We **make** a decision (also "take a decision" in Indian and British usage, but "made" is the option given).

Q8 **Answer: (b) apiary**

Apiary: bees; aviary: birds; granary: grain.

Q9 **Answer: (d) atheist**

Atheist denies God's existence; an agnostic says it cannot be known.

Q10 **Answer: (a) work late into the night**

To burn the midnight oil is to **work late at night**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) reveal a secret**

It means to **reveal a secret** by accident.

Q12 **Answer: (d) respect**

"Look up to" = **respect, admire**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) kleptomania**

Kleptomania: urge to steal; pyromania: to set fires.

Q14 **Answer: (a) resembles**

"Take after" = **resemble** a parent.

Q15 **Answer: (c) heavily**

The natural collocation is **heavy rain / raining heavily**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) oligarchy**

Oligarchy: rule by a few. Plutocracy is rule by the wealthy.

Q17 **Answer: (b) something good that at first seemed bad**

Losing that job was a **blessing in disguise**: it led to something better.

Q18 **Answer: (d) tolerate**

"Put up with" = **tolerate**.

Q19 **Answer: (c) plagiarist**

A **plagiarist** steals another's writing or ideas.

Q20 **Answer: (c) at the last possible moment**

At the eleventh hour = **at the last moment**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) cancelled**

"Call off" = **cancel**.

Q22 **Answer: (b) anthology**

An **anthology** is a collection of poems or other writings.

Q23 **Answer: (a) a rough estimate**

A ballpark figure is a **rough estimate**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) regicide**

Regicide: killing of a king (Latin rex, regis = king).

Q25 **Answer: (a) deceived**

In this context "taken in" means **deceived**.

Learn one-word substitutes by roots (-cracy rule, -cide killing, -logy study, -phobia fear, -mania urge). Idioms are fixed; never change their words. Phrasal verbs change meaning with the particle (take after, take over, take in). Learn natural collocations: make a decision, do homework, heavy rain, strong coffee.

LEVEL 2

Intermediate level

Spot errors, correct and complete sentences, solve cloze tests and para jumbles, read passages accurately, and handle verbal analogies, voice and narration

9 MODULES · 13 DAYS MINIMUM

Module 10 · Spotting errors	**2 days**
Module 11 · Sentence correction and sentence improvement	**2 days**
Module 12 · Fill in the blanks	**1 day**
Module 13 · Cloze test	**1 day**
Module 14 · Para jumbles (sentence rearrangement)	**2 days**
Module 15 · Odd sentence out and paragraph completion	**1 day**
Module 16 · Reading comprehension basics	**2 days**
Module 17 · Verbal analogies, word relationships and classification	**1 day**
Module 18 · Voice and narration	**1 day**

MODULE 10 · INTERMEDIATE

Spotting errors

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Intermediate**

Error-spotting questions split a sentence into parts and ask which part contains a grammatical error, or whether there is no error. This module covers a reliable checking order, the nine error categories that account for nearly all questions (agreement, tense, pronoun, article, preposition, comparison, parallelism, modifiers and redundancy) and how to handle "no error" options, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

10.1 Approach
10.2 Common error categories
10.3 "No error" options
10.4 Practice questions
10.5 Solutions

10.1 Approach

10.1.1 Read the whole sentence first

Many errors are visible only when you see the whole sentence: a verb in part (c) may disagree with a subject in part (a). Read the sentence once for meaning before examining the parts.

10.1.2 Check in a fixed order



THE ERROR-CHECKING ORDER

10.1.3 Identify the rule broken

Do not choose a part because it "sounds odd". Name the rule it breaks; if you cannot, look again. Naming the rule also builds your error log.

SHORTCUT TRICK

Start with the verb. Find the main verb, find its true subject, and check number and tense. About a third of all error-spotting questions are settled here.

10.2 Common error categories

10.2.1 Agreement errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
The quality of these products are poor.	The quality of these products is poor.	subject = quality
Neither he nor his friends was invited.	Neither he nor his friends were invited.	nearer subject
One of the students have won.	One of the students has won.	one of + singular verb

10.2.2 Tense and verb-form errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
I have met him last week.	I met him last week.	finished time → simple past
He did not came.	He did not come.	did + base verb
If I will see him, I will tell him.	If I see him, I will tell him.	no will in if-clause

10.2.3 Pronoun case and reference errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Let you and I finish it.	Let you and me finish it.	object after let
Each student must bring their ID.	Each student must bring his or her ID.	agreement with each
When Ravi met Arjun, he was angry.	When Ravi met Arjun, Ravi was angry.	unclear reference

10.2.4 Article and determiner errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
He is an university student.	He is a university student.	consonant sound
The honesty is the best policy.	Honesty is the best policy.	abstract noun in general
I have less friends now.	I have fewer friends now.	fewer with countables

10.2.5 Preposition errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
She is married with a lawyer.	She is married to a lawyer.	married to
We discussed about the budget.	We discussed the budget.	no preposition
He has been absent since three days.	He has been absent for three days.	for + period

10.2.6 Comparison errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
He is more smarter than me.	He is smarter than I.	double comparative; case
The population of Mumbai is larger than Pune.	The population of Mumbai is larger than that of Pune.	compare like with like
She is the best of the two.	She is the better of the two.	comparative for two

10.2.7 Parallelism errors

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
She likes reading, writing and to paint.	She likes reading, writing and painting.	same form in a list
He is not only clever but also works hard.	He is not only clever but also hard-working.	adjective + adjective

10.2.8 Misplaced and dangling modifiers

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
Running to the bus, my bag fell.	Running to the bus, I dropped my bag.	dangling: who was running?
He only eats fruit in the morning.	He eats fruit only in the morning.	misplaced "only"
I saw a dog on the way to the office with a long tail.	On the way to the office, I saw a dog with a long tail.	misplaced phrase

10.2.9 Redundancy

Redundant	Correct	Redundant	Correct
return back	return	repeat again	repeat
revert back	revert	final outcome	outcome
each and every	each / every	free gift	gift
cooperate together	cooperate	future plans	plans
the reason is because	the reason is that	past history	history
more superior	superior	and etc.	etc.

10.3 "No error" options and how to handle them

About one question in five or six is genuinely error-free. Choose "No error" only after checking every category in the list and finding nothing you can name. Do not pick it just because you are unsure, and do not avoid it just because it feels like a trap.

WATCH OUT

Informal English that is common in speech may still be wrong in a test: "I am having a car", "Myself Ravi", "Revert back", "Discuss about". Judge by the rules, not by what you often hear.

10.4 Practice questions

10.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The list of / items are / on the table.*

(a) The list of **(b)** items are **(c)** on the table. **(d)** No error

Q2 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *She has been / working here / since five years.*

(a) She has been **(b)** working here
(c) since five years. **(d)** No error

Q3 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *He is / an honest / man.*

(a) He is **(b)** an honest **(c)** man. **(d)** No error

Q4 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *I have seen / that film / yesterday.*

(a) I have seen **(b)** that film **(c)** yesterday. **(d)** No error

Q5 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Please return / back the book / by Friday.*

(a) Please return **(b)** back the book **(c)** by Friday. **(d)** No error

Q6 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Neither of the / answers are / correct.*

(a) Neither of the **(b)** answers are **(c)** correct. **(d)** No error

Q7 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *We discussed / about the project / in the meeting.*

(a) We discussed **(b)** about the project
(c) in the meeting. **(d)** No error

Q8 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Between you and I, / the plan / will not work.*

(a) Between you and I, **(b)** the plan
(c) will not work. **(d)** No error

10.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The population of Delhi / is larger than / Kolkata.*

(a) The population of Delhi **(b)** is larger than
(c) Kolkata. **(d)** No error

Q10 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *He did not / knew the answer / to the question.*

(a) He did not **(b)** knew the answer
(c) to the question. **(d)** No error

Q11 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Each of the employees / has been given / a new laptop.*

(a) Each of the employees **(b)** has been given

(c) a new laptop. (d) No error

Q12 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *She enjoys / singing, dancing / and to paint.*

(a) She enjoys (b) singing, dancing
(c) and to paint. (d) No error

Q13 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *If I will get / the job, / I will buy a car.*

(a) If I will get (b) the job,
(c) I will buy a car. (d) No error

Q14 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The furnitures / in this room / are expensive.*

(a) The furnitures (b) in this room (c) are expensive. (d) No error

Q15 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Running to / catch the train, / my phone fell down.*

(a) Running to (b) catch the train,
(c) my phone fell down. (d) No error

Q16 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *He is / more cleverer / than his brother.*

(a) He is (b) more cleverer
(c) than his brother. (d) No error

10.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Hardly had / he arrived / than it started raining.*

(a) Hardly had (b) he arrived
(c) than it started raining. (d) No error

Q18 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Virat is one of / the best batsman / in the world.*

(a) Virat is one of (b) the best batsman
(c) in the world. (d) No error

Q19 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The reason for his absence / is because / he was ill.*

(a) The reason for his absence (b) is because
(c) he was ill. (d) No error

Q20 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Not only he / completed the work / but also helped others.*

(a) Not only he (b) completed the work
(c) but also helped others. (d) No error

Q21 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *No sooner did / the bell ring / than the students rushed out.*

(a) No sooner did (b) the bell ring
(c) than the students rushed out. (d) No error

Q22 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The committee / have submitted / its report.*

(a) The committee **(b)** have submitted **(c)** its report. **(d)** No error

Q23 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *I am looking forward / to meet you / next week.*

(a) I am looking forward **(b)** to meet you
(c) next week. **(d)** No error

Q24 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Scarcely had I / reached the office / when the power failed.*

(a) Scarcely had I **(b)** reached the office
(c) when the power failed. **(d)** No error

Q25 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The manager as well as / his assistants / were present at the meeting.*

(a) The manager as well as **(b)** his assistants
(c) were present at the meeting. **(d)** No error

10.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (b) items are**
Subject "list" is singular: **items is** → the list … **is** on the table.

Q2 **Answer: (c) since five years.**
"Five years" is a period: **for five years**.

Q3 **Answer: (d) No error**
Correct: "honest" starts with a vowel sound, so "an" is right. **No error**.

Q4 **Answer: (a) I have seen**
A finished past time needs the simple past: **I saw** that film yesterday.

Q5 **Answer: (b) back the book**
"Return back" is redundant: **return the book**.

Q6 **Answer: (b) answers are**
"Neither of" takes a singular verb: **answers is** → neither … **is** correct.

Q7 **Answer: (b) about the project**
"Discuss" takes no preposition: **discussed the project**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) Between you and I,**
After the preposition "between" use the object form: **between you and me**.

Q9 **Answer: (c) Kolkata.**

Compare population with population: than **that of Kolkata**.

Q10 **Answer: (b) knew the answer**

"Did not" is followed by the base verb: **did not know**.

Q11 **Answer: (d) No error**

"Each of" takes a singular verb, and "has been given" is singular. **No error**.

Q12 **Answer: (c) and to paint.**

Parallelism: singing, dancing and **painting**.

Q13 **Answer: (a) If I will get**

No "will" in the if-clause: **If I get** the job.

Q14 **Answer: (a) The furnitures**

"Furniture" is uncountable: **The furniture** in this room **is** expensive.

Q15 **Answer: (c) my phone fell down.**

Dangling modifier: the phone was not running. **I dropped my phone**.

Q16 **Answer: (b) more cleverer**

Double comparative: **cleverer**.

Q17 **Answer: (c) than it started raining.**

"Hardly" pairs with **when**: when it started raining.

Q18 **Answer: (b) the best batsman**

"One of the" is followed by a plural noun: **the best batsmen**.

Q19 **Answer: (b) is because**

"The reason … is because" is redundant: the reason … **is that** he was ill.

Q20 **Answer: (a) Not only he**

Parallel placement: he **not only completed** the work but also helped others.

Q21 **Answer: (d) No error**

"No sooner … than" with "did … ring" is correct. **No error**.

Q22 **Answer: (b) have submitted**

"Its report" shows the committee acting as one unit: **has submitted**.

Q23 **Answer: (b) to meet you**

"Look forward to" + gerund: **to meeting you**.

Q24 **Answer: (d) No error**

"Scarcely … when" with inversion "had I" is correct. **No error**.

Q25 **Answer: (c) were present at the meeting.**

"As well as" does not join subjects; the verb agrees with "manager": **was present**.

Read the whole sentence, then check in order: subject–verb agreement, tense and verb form, pronoun, article, preposition, comparison and parallelism, modifiers, redundancy. Name the rule before choosing. Pick "No error" only after every check passes.

MODULE 11 · INTERMEDIATE

Sentence correction and sentence improvement

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Intermediate**

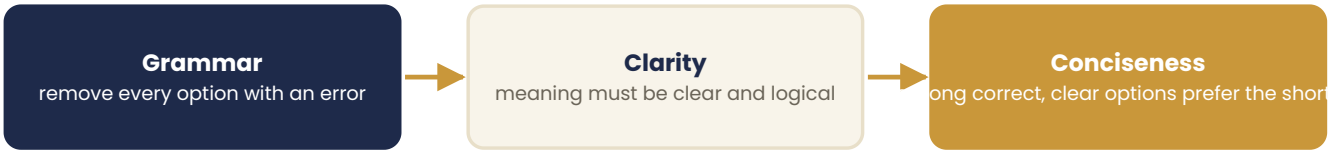
These questions ask you to choose the best version of a sentence or of an underlined part. This module covers the grammar-clarity-conciseness order, eliminating options that share an error, replacing an underlined phrase, "no improvement" options, wordiness, active and passive voice, idiomatic usage, parallel structure, modifier placement and an overview of GMAT-style sentence correction, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

11.1	Sentence correction	11.2	Sentence improvement
11.3	Style issues	11.4	GMAT-style sentence correction (overview)
11.5	Practice questions	11.6	Solutions

11.1 Sentence correction

11.1.1 Grammar first, then clarity, then conciseness



THE ORDER OF TESTS

The best answer is grammatically correct, says exactly what the original meant, and says it without extra words. A shorter option that changes the meaning is wrong.

11.1.2 Eliminating options with the same error

Compare the options side by side: they often differ in one or two places (is/are, who/whom, a comma). Decide each difference once and cross out every option on the wrong side of it.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Split the options

Options: (a) The team are playing their best. (b) The team is playing its best. (c) The team is playing their best. (d) The team are playing its best.

Decide verb–pronoun consistency: the team acting as one unit → "is … its". Only **(b)** survives.

11.2 Sentence improvement

11.2.1 Replacing an underlined phrase

Only the underlined part may change. Read the sentence with each option in place; the rest of the sentence must stay correct.

11.2.2 "No improvement" options

If the underlined part is already correct and as clear as any option, choose "No improvement". It is the right answer in a good share of questions, so do not avoid it, but check every option first.

11.3 Style issues

11.3.1 Wordiness and redundancy

Wordy	Concise
due to the fact that	because
in spite of the fact that	although
at this point in time	now
in order to	to
has the ability to	can
make a decision	decide
a large number of	many
in the event that	if

11.3.2 Passive vs active voice for clarity

Prefer the active voice when the doer matters: "The team **fixed** the bug" is clearer than "The bug **was fixed** by the team". Use the passive when the doer is unknown or unimportant: "The bridge **was built** in 1950."

11.3.3 Idiomatic usage

Idiomatic	Unidiomatic
capable of doing	capable to do
prohibit someone from doing	prohibit someone to do
consider him a leader	consider him as a leader
regard him as a leader	regard him a leader
as … as	as … than

Idiomatic	Unidiomatic
so … that	so … as
not so much X as Y	not so much X but Y

11.3.4 Parallel structure

Items in a list, items joined by *and/or/but*, and the two halves of a correlative pair must have the same grammatical form: *to plan, to build and to test*; *planning, building and testing*.

11.3.5 Modifier placement

Place a modifier next to the word it describes. Put *only, just, almost, even, nearly* immediately before the word they limit: "I **only** have two" vs "I have **only** two".

11.4 GMAT-style sentence correction (overview)

GMAT and CAT-style questions underline a long part of the sentence and offer five versions. They test meaning as much as grammar: logical comparisons, clear pronoun reference, correct verb tense sequence and idioms. Use the same split-the-options method, and remember that the shortest correct option is preferred only if it keeps the full meaning.

11.5 Practice questions

11.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
She don't like spicy food.

(a) didn't liked **(b)** not like **(c)** doesn't like **(d)** No improvement

Q2 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
He has gone to Mumbai last week.

(a) has been **(b)** had gone **(c)** No improvement **(d)** went

Q3 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
I am looking forward to meet you.

(a) for meeting **(b)** meeting with **(c)** No improvement **(d)** to meeting

Q4 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The children were playing in the park when it started to rain.

(a) played **(b)** have been playing
(c) No improvement

Q5 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
He is senior than me.

(a) senior to **(b)** more senior than
(c) senior from **(d)** No improvement

Q6 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Please revert back by Monday.

(a) revert back to me **(b)** revert again
(c) No improvement **(d)** reply

Q7 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Due to the fact that it rained, the match was cancelled.

(a) Due to that **(b)** Because
(c) Owing to the fact of **(d)** No improvement

Q8 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Each of the girls have done her homework.

(a) were doing **(b)** has done
(c) have been doing **(d)** No improvement

11.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
She is good in painting and dancing.

(a) on **(b)** with **(c)** No improvement **(d)** at

Q10 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The manager asked that who had broken the printer.

(a) who had broken the printer **(b)** who has broken the printer?
(c) that who has broken the printer **(d)** No improvement

Q11 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
He prefers coffee than tea.
(a) over than tea **(b)** more than tea **(c)** to tea **(d)** No improvement

Q12 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
If he would have left early, he would have caught the train.
(a) would leave **(b)** left **(c)** No improvement **(d)** had left

Q13 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
She not only sings but also is dancing at the event.
(a) sings but also she dances **(b)** sings but also dances
(c) is singing but also dances **(d)** No improvement

Q14 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The climate of Bengaluru is better than Chennai.
(a) that of Chennai **(b)** of Chennai
(c) Chennai's climate is **(d)** No improvement

Q15 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Being a holiday, the office was closed.
(a) As holiday **(b)** Since being a holiday
(c) It being a holiday **(d)** No improvement

Q16 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
He has been working here since 2018.
(a) No improvement **(b)** is working **(c)** works

11.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The new policy aims to reduce costs, improving quality and to increase sales.
(a) improving quality and increasing **(b)** improve quality and increase
(c) to improve quality and increasing **(d)** No improvement

Q18 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
No sooner had the meeting started when the fire alarm rang.
(a) then **(b)** that **(c)** No improvement **(d)** than

Q19 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Walking along the road, a car almost hit me.
(a) Walking along the road, it was a car that
(b) A car, walking along the road,
(c) While I was walking along the road, a car
(d) No improvement

Q20 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):

The number of applicants have increased this year.

(a) are increasing **(b)** were increased **(c)** has increased **(d)** No improvement

Q21 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
He was so tired that he could not walk.

(a) No improvement **(b)** too tired that
(c) very tired that

Q22 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The CEO, along with the directors, are expected to attend.

(a) were expected **(b)** is expected
(c) have been expected **(d)** No improvement

Q23 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
I only spent ten minutes on the test.

(a) spent only **(b)** spent ten minutes only on
(c) only had spent **(d)** No improvement

Q24 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
The committee considered him as the best candidate.

(a) to be as the best **(b)** the best
(c) like the best **(d)** No improvement

Q25 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"):
Hardly I had reached home when it began to pour.

(a) had I reached **(b)** I reached **(c)** did I reached **(d)** No improvement

11.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) doesn't like**
Third-person singular in the present: she **doesn't like**.

Q2 **Answer: (d) went**
"Last week" is a finished time: **went**.

Q3 **Answer: (d) to meeting**
"Look forward to" + gerund: **to meeting**.

Q4 **Answer: (c) No improvement**
An action in progress interrupted by another: past continuous is correct. **No improvement**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) senior to**
Latin comparatives take "to": **senior to**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) reply**

"Revert back" is redundant, and in standard English "revert" means "return to a previous state"; the clear form is **reply** by Monday.

Q7 **Answer: (b) Because**

The concise form is **Because**.

Q8 **Answer: (b) has done**

"Each" is singular: **has done**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) at**

The fixed expression is good **at**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) who had broken the printer**

An indirect question takes no "that" and no question mark: asked **who had broken the printer**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) to tea**

"Prefer … to": prefers coffee **to tea**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) had left**

Third conditional: **If he had left** early.

Q13 **Answer: (b) sings but also dances**

Parallel verbs after "not only … but also": **sings but also dances**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) that of Chennai**

Compare climate with climate: **that of Chennai**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) It being a holiday**

The participle needs a subject (the office was not a holiday): **It being a holiday**, the office was closed.

Q16 **Answer: (a) No improvement**

Continuing action since a point of time: present perfect continuous is correct. **No improvement**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) improve quality and increase**

Parallel infinitives after "aims to": to reduce costs, **improve quality and increase** sales.

Q18 **Answer: (d) than**

"No sooner" pairs with **than**.

Q19 **Answer: (c) While I was walking along the road, a car**

Remove the dangling modifier: **While I was walking along the road, a car** almost hit me.

Q20 **Answer: (c) has increased**

"The number of" takes a singular verb: **has increased**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) No improvement**

"So ... that" is the correct pattern. **No improvement**.

Q22 **Answer: (b) is expected**

"Along with" does not change the subject: the CEO **is expected**.

Q23 **Answer: (a) spent only**

Place "only" before what it limits (ten minutes): I **spent only** ten minutes.

Q24 **Answer: (b) the best**

"Consider" takes no "as": considered him **the best** candidate.

Q25 **Answer: (a) had I reached**

A negative adverb at the start causes inversion: Hardly **had I reached** home.

Test options for grammar first, then clarity of meaning, then conciseness. Split the options at each difference and eliminate in groups. Watch for idioms (prefer ... to, consider without as), parallel structure, logical comparisons and dangling modifiers. Choose "No improvement" when the original passes every test.

MODULE 12 · INTERMEDIATE

Fill in the blanks

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Intermediate**

Fill-in-the-blank questions test grammar and vocabulary in context. This module covers grammar-based blanks (articles, prepositions, tenses, conjunctions), vocabulary blanks with similar-looking options, double and triple blanks, the clue words that reveal the answer (contrast, support, cause and effect), and word-swap and word-usage questions, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

12.1 Grammar-based blanks
12.2 Vocabulary-based blanks
12.3 Clues in the sentence
12.4 Word-swap and word-usage questions
12.5 Practice questions
12.6 Solutions

12.1 Grammar-based blanks

12.1.1 Articles, prepositions, tenses, conjunctions

When all the options are the same kind of word (four prepositions, four tense forms), the question tests a grammar rule. Look at the words immediately around the blank: the subject, a time marker (since, yesterday, by next year), a fixed expression (interested ___), or a second clause.

Option set	Look for
a / an / the / no article	the sound of the next word; first or second mention; unique things
in / on / at / for / since	fixed expressions; time point or period
tense forms	time markers and the tense of the other clause
although / because / unless / so	the logical link between the two clauses

12.2 Vocabulary-based blanks

12.2.1 Single blanks with similar-looking options

Look-alike pair	Meanings
affect / effect	affect = influence (verb); effect = result (noun)
complement / compliment	complement = complete; compliment = praise
principal / principle	principal = main / head; principle = basic rule
stationary / stationery	stationary = not moving; stationery = writing materials

Look-alike pair	Meanings
eminent / imminent	eminent = famous; imminent = about to happen
elicit / illicit	elicit = draw out; illicit = illegal
adverse / averse	adverse = harmful; averse = unwilling
council / counsel	council = group; counsel = advice / lawyer

12.2.2 Double blanks

Solve the blank you are surer of first and eliminate every option whose word for that blank is wrong. Then check the survivors with the second blank. Both words must fit; one good word is not enough.

12.2.3 Triple blanks

Triple blanks (in CAT and GRE text completion) work the same way: find the blank with the strongest clue, decide it, then move to the next. Re-read the whole sentence with all three words before answering.

12.3 Clues in the sentence

12.3.1 Contrast words: but, although, however

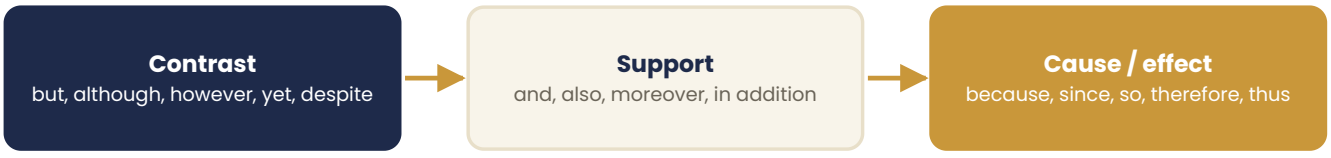
A contrast word means the blank is the **opposite** of an idea elsewhere in the sentence: *Although he was _____, he refused to give up* → exhausted / discouraged.

12.3.2 Support words: and, moreover, because

A support word means the blank **continues** the same idea: *She is kind and _____* → generous (positive like "kind").

12.3.3 Cause-and-effect words: therefore, so

Cause-and-effect words mean the blank is a **result** or a **reason**: *The road was flooded, so the buses were _____* → cancelled / diverted.



SIGNAL WORDS TELL YOU THE DIRECTION OF THE BLANK

SHORTCUT TRICK
Cover the options and predict a word from the clue. Then pick the option closest to your prediction. This prevents attractive but wrong words from pulling you in.

12.4 Word-swap and word-usage questions

Word swap: two words in a sentence have been exchanged; find them. **Word usage:** a word is used in several sentences and you find the sentence where it is used wrongly or inappropriately.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Word usage: "fair"

(a) The judge was **fair** to both sides. (b) We went to the book **fair**. (c) She has **fair** skin. (d) He **faired** well in the exam. × — the verb is "fared", so (d) is the wrong usage.

12.5 Practice questions

12.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Fill in the blank: She is interested _____ learning Spanish.

(a) on (b) at (c) in (d) for

Q2 Fill in the blank: He has lived in Delhi _____ 2015.

(a) for (b) from (c) by (d) since

Q3 Fill in the blank: _____ it was raining, we went for a walk.

(a) Because (b) Unless (c) So (d) Although

Q4 Fill in the blank: The new rules will _____ all employees.

(a) effect (b) infect (c) affect (d) afflict

Q5 Fill in the blank: Please buy some _____ for the office: pens, paper and envelopes.

(a) stationery (b) stationary (c) stationer (d) station

Q6 Fill in the blank: By the time we arrived, the film _____.

(a) started (b) has started (c) starts (d) had started

Q7 Fill in the blank: The students were _____ because the exam was postponed.

(a) worried (b) relieved (c) angry (d) punished

Q8 Fill in the blank: She is not only intelligent _____ hard-working.

(a) and also (b) but also (c) as well as (d) but

12.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Fill in the blank: Despite his _____, he remained humble.

(a) failure (b) poverty (c) illness (d) success

Q10 Fill in the blank: The storm was so severe that all flights were _____.

(a) cancelled (b) delayed briefly
(c) boarded (d) announced

Q11 Fill in the blank: The _____ of the school addressed the students.

(a) principle (b) principality (c) principal (d) prince

Q12 Fill in the blank: Her speech was brief _____ powerful.

(a) so (b) because (c) therefore (d) yet

Q13 Fill in the blanks: The scientist was _____ by the results, which _____ her theory.

(a) delighted … disproved (b) delighted … confirmed
(c) disappointed … confirmed (d) puzzled … supported

Q14 Fill in the blank: The police tried to _____ information from the witness.

(a) elicit (b) illicit (c) solicit (d) explicit

Q15 Fill in the blank: He is _____ to taking risks; he always plays safe.

(a) adverse **(b)** inverse **(c)** averse **(d)** diverse

Q16 Fill in the blanks: Although the task seemed _____ at first, it turned out to be quite _____.

(a) difficult … easy **(b)** easy … simple
(c) difficult … hard **(d)** boring … dull

12.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Fill in the blanks: The company's profits _____ sharply last year, _____ the management to cut costs.

(a) rose … forcing **(b)** fell … forcing
(c) fell … preventing **(d)** rose … allowing

Q18 Fill in the blank: The manager's _____ remarks hurt the team's morale.

(a) encouraging **(b)** complimentary **(c)** neutral **(d)** disparaging

Q19 Fill in the blanks: Far from being _____, the new policy was _____ by almost everyone.

(a) popular … welcomed **(b)** unpopular … rejected
(c) unpopular … welcomed **(d)** controversial … opposed

Q20 Fill in the blank: The witness gave a _____ account: every detail was consistent and clear.

(a) confused **(b)** biased **(c)** coherent **(d)** brief

Q21 Fill in the blanks: Her _____ nature made her popular, but her _____ often annoyed her colleagues.

(a) gloomy … punctuality **(b)** cheerful … honesty
(c) rude … lateness **(d)** cheerful … unpunctuality

Q22 In which sentence is the word "fare" used incorrectly?

(a) The bus fare has increased. **(b)** He fared the wall with paint.
(c) How did you fare in the interview? **(d)** The restaurant serves simple fare.

Q23 Identify the two words that should be swapped: "The doctor prescribed the patient for the medicine."

(a) patient and medicine **(b)** doctor and patient
(c) prescribed and medicine **(d)** the and for

Q24 Fill in the blanks: The negotiations were _____; neither side was willing to _____.

(a) successful … compromise **(b)** deadlocked … compromise
(c) deadlocked … argue **(d)** brief … listen

Q25 Fill in the blanks: Though the evidence was _____, the jury found it _____ and convicted him.

(a) circumstantial … convincing **(b)** direct … unconvincing
(c) circumstantial … weak **(d)** strong … doubtful

12.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) in**

Fixed preposition: interested **in**.

Q2 **Answer: (d) since**

2015 is a point in time: **since**.

Q3 **Answer: (d) Although**

Rain and going for a walk contrast: **Although**.

Q4 **Answer: (c) affect**

A verb meaning "influence" is needed: **affect**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) stationery**

Writing materials: **stationery**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) had started**

The earlier of two past actions: **had started**.

Q7 **Answer: (b) relieved**

Postponement gives more time; with "because" the feeling is caused by it: **relieved**.

Q8 **Answer: (b) but also**

"Not only" pairs with **but also**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) success**

"Despite" signals contrast with "humble": someone could become proud after **success**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) cancelled**

"So severe that" signals a strong result: **cancelled**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) principal**

The head of a school is the **principal**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) yet**

Brief and powerful are a mild contrast: **yet**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) delighted … confirmed**

Results confirming her theory would delight her: **delighted … confirmed**. The other pairs are inconsistent.

Q14 **Answer: (a) elicit**

"Draw out" information: **elicit**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) averse**

Unwilling: **averse** to.

Q16 **Answer: (a) difficult … easy**

"Although" demands contrast between the two blanks: **difficult … easy**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) fell … forcing**

Cost cutting follows falling profits: **fell … forcing**.

Q18 **Answer: (d) disparaging**

Remarks that hurt morale are critical: **disparaging**.

Q19 **Answer: (c) unpopular … welcomed**

"Far from being X" means the opposite of X is true: **unpopular … welcomed**.

Q20 **Answer: (c) coherent**

Consistent and clear: **coherent**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) cheerful … unpunctuality**

"But" marks a contrast between a positive trait and an annoying one: **cheerful … unpunctuality**.

Q22 **Answer: (b) He fared the wall with paint.**

"Fare" means a ticket price, to perform, or food; it does not mean "to paint". **He fared the wall with paint** is wrong.

Q23 **Answer: (a) patient and medicine**

Correct: "The doctor prescribed the medicine for the patient." Swap **patient and medicine**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) deadlocked … compromise**

If neither side yields, talks are stuck: **deadlocked … compromise**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) circumstantial … convincing**

"Though" sets up contrast: indirect (circumstantial) evidence that was nevertheless **convincing**, leading to conviction.

Same-type options test a rule: read the words around the blank. For vocabulary, predict the word from the signal words (contrast, support, cause and effect) before reading the options. In double blanks, decide the surer blank first and eliminate. Watch for look-alikes: affect/effect, principal/principle, stationary/stationery, elicit/illicit, adverse/averse.

MODULE 13 · INTERMEDIATE

Cloze test

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Intermediate**

A cloze test is a passage with several blanks; each answer must fit both its sentence and the whole passage. This module covers the read-first method, filling easy blanks first, checking fit at both levels, grammar-based, vocabulary-based and mixed cloze passages, and the common trap of words that fit the sentence but not the passage, followed by three cloze passages with 25 solved blanks.

IN THIS MODULE

13.1 Approach
13.2 Types
13.3 Common traps
13.4 Practice questions
13.5 Solutions

13.1 Approach

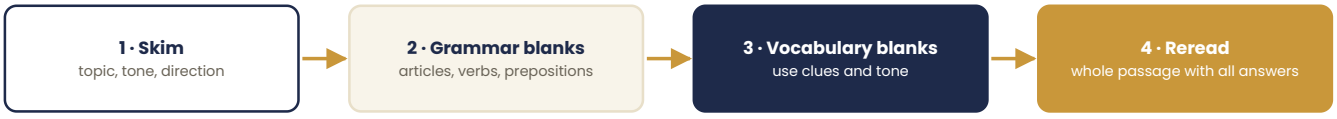
13.1.1 Read the whole passage first for its theme and tone

Skim the passage once without filling anything. Ask: what is the topic, what is the writer's attitude (positive, critical, neutral), and how does the argument move? Blanks near the end often depend on ideas from the beginning.

13.1.2 Fill easy blanks first

Grammar blanks (articles, prepositions, verb forms) are usually quick. Filling them first gives you more of the passage to work with for the harder vocabulary blanks.

13.1.3 Check each answer fits the sentence and the passage



THE CLOZE METHOD

13.2 Types

13.2.1 Grammar-based cloze

Options are different forms of a word (go, went, gone, going) or different function words (in, on, at; which, who, whose). Apply the grammar rule.

13.2.2 Vocabulary-based cloze

Options are words of similar meaning with different shades, strength or connotation. Choose by the passage's tone and logic.

13.2.3 Mixed cloze

Most tests mix both kinds. Treat each blank on its own terms: rule first, then meaning.

13.3 Common traps

13.3.1 Words that fit the sentence but not the passage

WORKED EXAMPLE

A trap

Passage: "Sales had fallen for three quarters. The new strategy, however, proved _____: profits doubled within a year." Option "disastrous" fits the first sentence's mood but contradicts "profits doubled". The answer is **successful**; "however" signals the turn.

WATCH OUT

Watch for connectors (however, therefore, moreover) between sentences: they tell you whether the blank continues or reverses the previous idea.

13.4 Practice questions

13.4.1 Basic level

Q1 *Passage 1. Read and answer Q1 to Q8.*
Regular exercise is one of the most effective ways (1) _____ improve health. It strengthens the heart, (2) _____ stress and helps people sleep better. Doctors recommend at least thirty minutes of activity (3) _____ day. However, many people find it difficult to (4) _____ a routine. A common reason is lack of (5) _____; long working hours leave little energy for the gym. Experts suggest that short walks, (6) _____ than long sessions, can be a good start. What matters most is (7) _____: a little exercise every day is better (8) _____ a lot once a month.

Blank (1)

(a) for **(b)** of **(c)** to **(d)** in

Q2 Passage 1, blank (2)

(a) increases **(b)** produces **(c)** reducing **(d)** reduces

Q3 Passage 1, blank (3)

(a) the **(b)** an **(c)** each of **(d)** a

Q4 Passage 1, blank (4)

(a) break **(b)** refuse **(c)** maintain **(d)** forget

Q5 Passage 1, blank (5)

(a) time **(b)** money **(c)** interest **(d)** space

Q6 Passage 1, blank (6)

(a) more **(b)** better **(c)** other **(d)** rather

Q7 Passage 1, blank (7)

(a) intensity **(b)** consistency **(c)** equipment **(d)** speed

Q8 Passage 1, blank (8)

(a) then **(b)** than **(c)** to **(d)** from

13.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 *Passage 2. Read and answer Q9 to Q16.*
The rise of online shopping has (9) _____ changed the way people buy goods. Customers can now compare prices (10) _____ seconds and have products delivered to their doors. For small shopkeepers, (11) _____, this convenience has been a serious threat. Many have seen their sales (12) _____, and some have closed altogether. Yet a few have (13) _____ by opening online stores of their own. They have discovered that personal service, which large websites cannot easily (14) _____, still attracts loyal customers. The lesson is clear: those who (15) _____ to change survive, while those who resist it are often (16) _____.

Blank (9)

(a) slightly **(b)** rarely **(c)** hardly **(d)** dramatically

Q10 Passage 2, blank (10)

(a) in (b) on (c) at (d) for

Q11 Passage 2, blank (11)

(a) therefore (b) moreover (c) however (d) similarly

Q12 Passage 2, blank (12)

(a) rise (b) stabilise (c) double (d) decline

Q13 Passage 2, blank (13)

(a) surrendered (b) adapted (c) complained (d) retired

Q14 Passage 2, blank (14)

(a) offer (b) refuse (c) destroy (d) ignore

Q15 Passage 2, blank (15)

(a) object (b) surrender (c) adapt (d) react

Q16 Passage 2, blank (16)

(a) left behind (b) rewarded (c) promoted (d) protected

13.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 *Passage 3. Read and answer Q17 to Q25.*

Artificial intelligence is often described as either a miracle or a menace, but the truth is more (17) _____. AI systems can diagnose certain diseases, translate languages and (18) _____ huge amounts of data in moments. These abilities are (19) _____ transforming industries from banking to agriculture. At the same time, critics warn that AI may (20) _____ existing biases if it is trained on unfair data, and that it could (21) _____ millions of jobs. Such concerns are not (22) _____; they deserve careful attention from governments and companies alike. The challenge, then, is not to (23) _____ AI but to guide it, so that its (24) _____ are shared widely and its risks are (25) _____ kept in check.

Blank (17)

(a) simple (b) complex (c) exciting (d) frightening

Q18 Passage 3, blank (18)

(a) ignore (b) delete (c) create (d) analyse

Q19 Passage 3, blank (19)

(a) never (b) yet (c) already (d) seldom

Q20 Passage 3, blank (20)

(a) remove (b) question (c) reinforce (d) reveal

Q21 Passage 3, blank (21)

(a) create (b) protect (c) improve (d) replace

Q22 Passage 3, blank (22)

(a) valid (b) baseless (c) serious (d) new

Q23 Passage 3, blank (23)

(a) reject (b) guide (c) study (d) improve

Q24 Passage 3, blank (24)

(a) risks (b) benefits (c) costs (d) errors

Q25 Passage 3, blank (25)

(a) firmly (b) loosely (c) rarely (d) barely

13.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) to**

"Ways **to** improve" (infinitive of purpose).

Q2 **Answer: (d) reduces**

Parallel present verbs (strengthens, ___ , helps) and a positive effect: **reduces** stress.

Q3 **Answer: (d) a**

"Thirty minutes **a** day" means per day.

Q4 **Answer: (c) maintain**

Difficulty with a routine means keeping it going: **maintain**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) time**

The next clause explains: long working hours leave little energy: lack of **time**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) rather**

"Short walks, **rather** than long sessions" is the fixed comparison.

Q7 **Answer: (b) consistency**

"A little every day is better than a lot once a month" is about **consistency**.

Q8 **Answer: (b) than**

Comparative "better **than**".

Q9 **Answer: (d) dramatically**

The passage describes a major shift: **dramatically**.

Q10 **Answer: (a) in**

"**In** seconds" = within a few seconds.

Q11 **Answer: (c) however**

The convenience for customers contrasts with the threat to shopkeepers: **however**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) decline**

Some even closed, so sales went down: **decline**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) adapted**

"Yet a few" did something positive by opening online stores: **adapted**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) offer**

Personal service that large websites cannot easily **offer**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) adapt**

"Adapt **to** change" fits the lesson and the preposition "to".

Q16 **Answer: (a) left behind**

Those who resist change fail: **left behind**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) complex**

Neither miracle nor menace: the truth is **complex**.

Q18 **Answer: (d) analyse**

A capability listed with diagnosing and translating: **analyse** data.

Q19 **Answer: (c) already**

Present continuous "are … transforming" with a positive sense: **already**.

Q20 **Answer: (c) reinforce**

Trained on unfair data, AI may make biases stronger: **reinforce**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) replace**

A warning about jobs: AI could **replace** them.

Q22 **Answer: (b) baseless**

"Not ___; they deserve careful attention" → not **baseless**. "Not valid" would contradict the second half.

Q23 **Answer: (a) reject**

"Not to ___ AI but to guide it": the contrast word is **reject**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) benefits**

Contrasted with "its risks": its **benefits** are shared widely.

Q25 **Answer: (a) firmly**

Risks should be kept in check strongly: **firmly**.

Skim the whole passage first for topic, tone and direction. Fill grammar blanks first, then vocabulary blanks using connectors and tone. Every answer must fit both its sentence and the passage; reread the completed passage before finishing.

MODULE 14 · INTERMEDIATE

Para jumbles (sentence rearrangement)

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Intermediate**

Para jumbles give the sentences of a paragraph in random order and ask for the logical sequence. This module covers finding the opening sentence, mandatory pairs, connectors, pronouns and articles as links, time and cause–effect order, the closing sentence, four- to six-sentence jumbles, fixed first and last sentences, TITA questions and using the options to save time, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

14.1 Approach
14.2 Types
14.3 Using options to save time
14.4 Practice questions
14.5 Solutions

14.1 Approach

14.1.1 Finding the opening sentence

The opening sentence introduces the topic and can be understood on its own. It usually has no pronoun pointing backwards (he, it, this, they), no connector (however, therefore, also) and often uses "a" rather than "the" for something mentioned for the first time.

14.1.2 Finding mandatory pairs

A **mandatory pair** is two sentences that must appear together: a term and its explanation, a claim and its example, a question and its answer, or a noun and the pronoun that refers to it. Finding one or two pairs usually leaves only one possible option.

14.1.3 Using connectors, pronouns and articles as links

Link	Tells you
he, she, it, they, this, these, such	the noun they refer to comes earlier
the (for something specific)	it was introduced before with "a"
however, but, yet	contrast with the previous sentence
also, moreover, furthermore	adds to the previous point
for example, for instance	follows a general statement
therefore, thus, as a result	a consequence of what came before

14.1.4 Time sequence and cause–effect order

Dates, words like *first, then, later, finally*, and cause before effect give a natural order. A historical paragraph usually runs from earlier to later events.

14.1.5 Finding the closing sentence

The closing sentence often summarises, draws a conclusion (thus, therefore, in short) or looks ahead. It rarely introduces a new idea that needs explaining.



THE PARA JUMBLE METHOD

14.2 Types

14.2.1 Four-, five- and six-sentence jumbles

Placement tests usually use four or five sentences labelled P, Q, R, S (T). Longer jumbles use the same method; just find more pairs.

14.2.2 Fixed first and last sentences

Some questions give sentence 1 and sentence 6 and jumble the four in between. Use sentence 1 to find which sentence follows it, and sentence 6 to find which comes just before it.

14.2.3 TITA (type the answer) para jumbles

In CAT, you type the order with no options to help. One sentence may be an odd one out. Build the chain pair by pair, then check that the whole paragraph reads smoothly.

14.3 Using options to save time

Once you know the opening sentence, cross out all options that begin differently. Then test one mandatory pair against the survivors. Usually only one remains within a minute.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Worked example

P: However, it was expensive and slow. Q: The first telephone exchange opened in 1878. R: Today, calls are cheap and instant. S: It allowed people to connect only through a human operator.

Opening: Q (introduces the topic with a date). S follows Q ("It" = the exchange). P adds a contrast about S. R ends with the present. Order: **QSPR**.

14.4 Practice questions

14.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: He opened the door slowly.
Q: Ravi heard a knock late at night.
R: There was nobody outside.
S: Surprised, he looked around.

(a) PQRS **(b)** QRPS **(c)** QPRS **(d)** SQPR

Q2 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: Then add sugar and stir well.
Q: First, boil a cup of water.
R: Finally, pour in the milk and serve.
S: Next, add a spoon of tea leaves.

(a) QPSR **(b)** SQPR **(c)** QSRP **(d)** QSPR

Q3 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: These trees produce oxygen and absorb carbon dioxide.
Q: Forests cover about a third of the earth's land.
R: Therefore, cutting them down harms the climate.
S: They are home to millions of species of trees.

(a) QPSR **(b)** SQPR **(c)** QPRS **(d)** QSPR

Q4 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: As a result, she was promoted within a year.
Q: Meera joined the company as a trainee.
R: She worked hard and learnt quickly.
S: Her manager noticed her dedication.

(a) QSRP **(b)** RQSP **(c)** QRSP **(d)** QRPS

Q5 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: It was built by Shah Jahan in memory of his wife.
Q: Every year, millions of tourists visit it.
R: The Taj Mahal is in Agra.
S: Construction took about twenty years.

(a) RPSQ **(b)** RSPQ **(c)** PRSQ **(d)** RPQS

Q6 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: However, the bus never came.
Q: We waited at the stop for an hour.
R: We had planned to take the morning bus.
S: In the end, we took a taxi.

(a) QRPS **(b)** RPQS **(c)** QPRS **(d)** RQPS

Q7 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: For example, a phone can now be unlocked by a face.
Q: Technology has made daily life more convenient.

R: Payments too can be made with a single tap.
S: Even groceries can be ordered from home.

(a) QRPS **(b)** QPRS **(c)** PQRS **(d)** QSPR

Q8 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: The match was stopped for an hour.
Q: Heavy rain began in the second innings.
R: When play resumed, the overs were reduced.
S: The home team won by four wickets.

(a) PQRS **(b)** QPRS **(c)** QRPS **(d)** RQPS

14.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: Such systems learn patterns from large amounts of data.
Q: Machine learning is a branch of artificial intelligence.
R: Once trained, they can make predictions about new data.
S: This is why banks use them to detect fraud.

(a) QRPS **(b)** PQRS **(c)** QPSR **(d)** QPRS

Q10 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: This was mainly because of cheap imports.
Q: Local factories found it hard to compete.
R: Many of them shut down within a few years.
S: The textile industry in the town once employed thousands.

(a) QSPR **(b)** SPQR **(c)** SQPR **(d)** SQRP

Q11 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: But these early computers filled entire rooms.
Q: The first electronic computers were built in the 1940s.
R: Today, a smartphone is far more powerful.
S: Over the decades, they became smaller and faster.

(a) QSPR **(b)** PQSR **(c)** QPSR **(d)** QPRS

Q12 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: She decided to start a small online bakery.
Q: Anita had always loved baking.
R: Within a year, orders were coming from across the city.
S: At first, she sold cakes only to friends.

(a) QSPR **(b)** PQSR **(c)** QPRS **(d)** QPSR

Q13 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: It reduces travel time and pollution.
Q: Many cities are now building metro railways.
R: Yet the cost of construction is very high.
S: Governments must therefore plan funding carefully.

(a) QRPS **(b)** QPRS **(c)** PQRS **(d)** QPSR

Q14 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: The professor asked the class a simple question.

Q: Then, slowly, a girl at the back raised her hand.
R: For a long moment, nobody answered.
S: Her answer was exactly right.

(a) PRQS **(b)** PQRS **(c)** RPQS **(d)** PRSQ

Q15 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: They help the body fight infections.
Q: Vaccines contain weakened or inactive germs.
R: As a result, diseases like polio have almost disappeared.
S: The immune system learns to recognise these germs.

(a) QPSR **(b)** SQPR **(c)** QSPR **(d)** QSRP

Q16 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: The idea was simple: let people share rides.
Q: In 2009, two friends could not find a taxi in Paris.
R: Within a decade, the company operated in hundreds of cities.
S: That experience gave them the idea for an app.

(a) QSPR **(b)** QPSR **(c)** SQPR **(d)** QSRP

14.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: Some even make up illnesses to stay at home.
Q: Many students feel anxious before examinations.
R: Teachers can help by teaching better study habits.
S: This anxiety can affect their sleep and appetite.

(a) QPSR **(b)** QSPR **(c)** SQPR **(d)** QSRP

Q18 Rearrange the sentences P, Q, R, S between 1 and 6 to form a logical paragraph.
1: The government launched a new scheme in 2016.
P: The scheme aims to provide clean cooking fuel to poor families.
Q: Before it, many women cooked on wood fires.
R: This exposed them to harmful smoke for hours every day.
S: Since its launch, millions of gas connections have been given.
6: Health experts believe the scheme has saved many lives.

(a) QRPS **(b)** QPRS **(c)** PRQS **(d)** PQRS

Q19 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: In ancient times, words were carved on stone or written on palm leaves.
Q: This made books rare and expensive.
R: Later, before printing was invented, every book had to be copied by hand.
S: Printing changed this, making knowledge available to many.

(a) RPQS **(b)** RQPS **(c)** PRQS **(d)** PQRS

Q20 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: The team studied the complaints and found a common problem.
Q: Customer complaints about late deliveries rose sharply last year.
R: They redesigned the delivery routes.
S: Complaints have since fallen by half.

(a) PQRS (b) QRPS (c) QPRS (d) QPSR

Q21 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: But it also has a darker side.
Q: Social media connects people across the world.
R: Studies link heavy use to anxiety and loneliness.
S: Users should therefore set limits on their screen time.

(a) QRPS (b) PQRS (c) QPSR (d) QPRS

Q22 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: The second, in contrast, values speed above all.
Q: There are two broad approaches to managing projects.
R: The first emphasises detailed planning before any work begins.
S: Most modern teams combine elements of both.

(a) QPRS (b) QRPS (c) RQPS (d) QRSP

Q23 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: These findings surprised the researchers.
Q: They expected the group using the app to perform better.
R: Instead, both groups showed the same improvement.
S: A study compared students who used a learning app with those who did not.

(a) SQRP (b) SRQP (c) QSRP (d) SQPR

Q24 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: Ironically, the very success of the antibiotics caused the problem.
Q: Antibiotics transformed medicine in the twentieth century.
R: Overuse allowed bacteria to evolve resistance.
S: Infections that were once easy to treat are becoming dangerous again.

(a) QRPS (b) QPRS (c) PQRS (d) QPSR

Q25 Rearrange the sentences to form a logical paragraph.
P: This means that a car built today may still be running in 2040.
Q: Electric cars produce no exhaust fumes.
R: Yet cars last fifteen years or more.
S: Many countries plan to stop selling petrol cars by 2035.

(a) QSRP (b) SQRP (c) QRSP (d) QSPR

14.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) QPRS**
Q introduces Ravi and the knock; P (he opened the door) follows; R reveals nobody; S his reaction. **QPRS**.

Q2 **Answer: (d) QSPR**
Sequence words: First (Q), Next (S), Then (P), Finally (R). **QSPR**.

Q3 **Answer: (d) QSPR**

Q opens with forests; S (They = forests) home to trees; P (These trees) their function; R (Therefore) the conclusion. **QSPR**.

Q4 **Answer: (c) QRSP**

Q introduces Meera; R her effort; S the manager noticed; P the result. **QRSP**.

Q5 **Answer: (a) RPSQ**

R introduces the Taj Mahal; P (It) who built it; S how long; Q visitors today. **RPSQ**.

Q6 **Answer: (d) RQPS**

R the plan; Q waiting; P (However) the problem; S the solution. **RQPS**.

Q7 **Answer: (b) QPRS**

Q is the general claim; P (For example) follows it; R ("too") adds a second example; S ("Even") the most striking. **QPRS**.

Q8 **Answer: (b) QPRS**

Cause (rain) → stoppage → resumption with fewer overs → result. **QPRS**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) QPRS**

Q defines the term; P (Such systems) how they learn; R (Once trained) what they then do; S (This is why) application. **QPRS**.

Q10 **Answer: (c) SQPR**

S opens (the industry once employed thousands); Q factories struggled; P (This) the reason; R the result. **SQPR**.

Q11 **Answer: (c) QPSR**

Chronological: 1940s (Q) → But they were huge (P) → over the decades (S) → today (R). **QPSR**.

Q12 **Answer: (d) QPSR**

Q background; P decision; S (At first) early stage; R (Within a year) growth. **QPSR**.

Q13 **Answer: (b) QPRS**

Q topic; P (It = metro) benefits; R (Yet) drawback; S (therefore) conclusion. **QPRS**.

Q14 **Answer: (a) PRQS**

Question (P) → silence (R) → then a girl raised her hand (Q) → her answer (S). **PRQS**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) QSPR**

Q what vaccines contain; S the immune system learns; P (They) help fight infection; R result. **QSPR**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) QSPR**

Q the incident; S (That experience) the idea; P what the idea was; R growth. **QSPR**.

Q17 **Answer: (b) QSPR**

Q topic; S (This anxiety) effects; P (Some even) extreme case; R solution. **QSPR**.

Q18 **Answer: (d) PQRS**

Sentence 1 introduces the scheme, so P (its aim) follows. Q (Before it) gives the background, R (This exposed them) its harm, and S the results, leading to the experts' view in 6. **PQRS**.

Q19 **Answer: (c) PRQS**

Time order: ancient times (P) → later, copying by hand (R) → This made books rare (Q) → printing changed this (S). **PRQS**.

Q20 **Answer: (c) QPRS**

Q problem; P investigation; R (They) action; S result. **QPRS**.

Q21 **Answer: (d) QPRS**

Q claim; P (But) contrast; R evidence for the dark side; S (therefore) advice. **QPRS**.

Q22 **Answer: (b) QRPS**

Q introduces "two approaches"; R the first; P the second; S synthesis. **QRPS**.

Q23 **Answer: (a) SQRP**

S introduces the study; Q (They = researchers) expectation; R (Instead) result; P (These findings) reaction. **SQRP**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) QPRS**

Q background; P (Ironically … the problem) introduces the problem; R explains the mechanism; S the consequence. **QPRS**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) QSRP**

Q the advantage; S policy based on it; R (Yet) a complication; P (This means) its implication. **QSRP**.

Find the opening sentence (stands alone, no backward pronoun or connector), then mandatory pairs (pronoun and its noun, claim and example, cause and effect). Use connectors, articles and time order to link the rest, and end with a conclusion. Eliminate options as soon as you know the opening sentence.

MODULE 15 · INTERMEDIATE

Odd sentence out and paragraph completion

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Intermediate**

These questions test your grasp of the theme and flow of a paragraph. This module covers finding the sentence that breaks a paragraph's theme or flow, combining that with para-jumble skills, choosing the sentence that best completes a paragraph by matching tone, topic and direction, and finding where a given sentence fits, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

15.1 Odd sentence out
15.2 Paragraph completion
15.3 Sentence insertion
15.4 Practice questions
15.5 Solutions

15.1 Odd sentence out

15.1.1 Finding the sentence that breaks the theme or flow

Four or five sentences are given; all but one belong to one coherent paragraph. The odd sentence may be on a **different topic**, on the same topic but from a **different angle** (a general fact among specific steps), or simply **impossible to link** to the others.

Odd sentence type	How to spot it
different topic	it shares a word with the others but not their subject
different scope	too general or too specific compared with the rest
different time or tone	a personal opinion among neutral facts, or the past among present-day statements
no link	it has no pronoun, connector or idea that connects it to any other sentence

WATCH OUT
The odd sentence often uses the same key word as the paragraph to look as if it belongs. Judge by the idea, not the word.

15.1.2 Combining with para-jumble skills

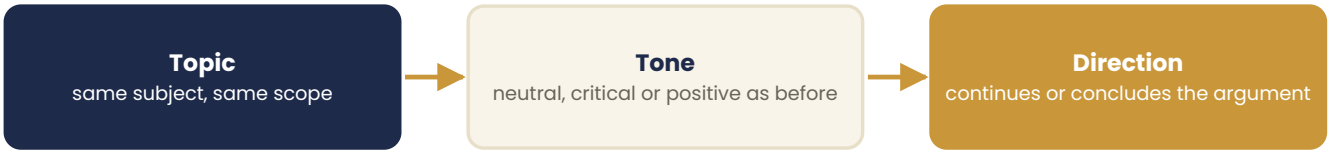
Try to build the paragraph as a para jumble. The sentences that link into a chain form the paragraph; the one left out is the odd sentence.

15.2 Paragraph completion

15.2.1 Choosing the sentence that best completes a paragraph

Usually the missing sentence is the last one. It should follow from the final sentence given and fit the paragraph's overall point.

15.2.2 Matching tone, topic and logical direction



THREE TESTS FOR A COMPLETING SENTENCE

Reject options that introduce a new topic, that are more extreme than the paragraph ("always", "never", "the only"), that contradict an earlier sentence, or that merely repeat the last sentence.

15.3 Sentence insertion

15.3.1 Finding where a sentence fits in a paragraph

Look at the sentence to be inserted for links: a pronoun (it, this, they) needs a noun before it; a connector (however, for example) tells you what must come before; a new term may need an explanation after it. Test the sentence in each gap and check that the sentence after it still follows smoothly.

15.4 Practice questions

15.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Bees collect nectar from flowers.
(b) The stock market fell sharply today.
(c) They turn it into honey in the hive.
(d) Honey can last for thousands of years.

Q2 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) To make tea, boil water.
(b) Add tea leaves and let them brew.
(c) Tea is grown widely in Assam.
(d) Strain the tea and add milk.

Q3 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Buses in the city are painted red.
(b) Ravi woke up late.
(c) He missed the bus.
(d) He reached the office an hour late.

Q4 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Plastic waste is choking our rivers. Fish swallow small pieces and die. Birds get trapped in plastic bags. _____"

(a) Plastic was invented in the nineteenth century.
(b) Fish are a good source of protein.
(c) Rivers are used for transport.
(d) Reducing plastic use is therefore urgent.

Q5 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Walking is a simple form of exercise. It needs no equipment and can be done anywhere. _____"

(a) Running shoes are expensive.
(b) Many people drive to work.
(c) Cycling is popular in Europe.
(d) It is also gentle on the joints.

Q6 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) The library opens at nine.
(b) Members can borrow up to five books.
(c) Books must be returned within two weeks.
(d) Reading improves vocabulary.

Q7 Where does the sentence "This made travel much faster." fit best? (1) For centuries, people travelled on foot or horseback. (2) Then the railway was invented. (3) ___ (4) Towns along the railway lines grew quickly.

(a) after sentence (1)
(b) before sentence (1)
(c) after sentence (2)
(d) after sentence (4)

Q8 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Our company's sales fell for three quarters. The new manager changed the pricing and improved customer service. _____"

(a) Within a year, sales had recovered.
(b) The old manager had retired.
(c) Customer service is important in every business.
(d) Pricing strategies vary across industries.

15.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Electric cars produce no exhaust fumes.
(b) The first car was built in Germany.
(c) They are cheaper to run than petrol cars.
(d) Charging stations are increasing in number.

Q10 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Yoga mats are made from rubber or PVC.
(b) Yoga improves flexibility.
(c) It also reduces stress.
(d) Many people practise it every morning.

Q11 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Many students believe that cramming the night before an exam works. Research shows otherwise. _____"

(a) Exams are held every year in March.
(b) Some students prefer to study in groups.
(c) Cramming is popular among students.
(d) Information learnt over several days is remembered far better.

Q12 Where does the sentence "However, the plan was too expensive." fit best? (1) The city wanted to build a new bridge. (2) ___ (3) Engineers suggested repairing the old one instead. (4) The repairs were finished in six months.

(a) after sentence (3)
(b) after sentence (1)
(c) after sentence (4)
(d) before sentence (1)

Q13 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Online learning offers flexibility.
(b) Students can study at their own pace.
(c) The internet was created for military research.
(d) Recorded lectures can be watched again.

Q14 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Coral reefs cover less than one per cent of the ocean floor. Yet they support about a quarter of all marine species. _____"

(a) Corals are found in warm, shallow waters.
(b) Their loss would therefore be a disaster for ocean life.
(c) Many tourists enjoy diving.
(d) The ocean covers most of the earth.

Q15 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) The meeting began at ten.
(b) The manager presented the quarterly results.
(c) Several questions were raised about costs.
(d) Coffee is the world's most traded commodity after oil.

Q16 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Many employees now work from home. This saves them time and travel costs. _____ Companies are therefore looking for ways to keep teams connected."

(a) Working from home is popular.
(b) Travel costs have risen.
(c) Companies are making record profits.
(d) However, some feel isolated from their colleagues.

15.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Antibiotics kill bacteria.
(b) Vitamins are found in fresh fruit.
(c) They do not work against viruses.
(d) Colds and flu are caused by viruses.

Q18 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Mumbai is India's financial capital.
(b) The novel follows a young woman who moves to Mumbai.
(c) She struggles to find work and a place to live.
(d) Slowly, she builds a new life and finds friendship.

Q19 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Some argue that tougher punishments reduce crime. Studies, however, suggest that the certainty of being caught matters more than the severity of the punishment. _____"

(a) Better policing may therefore deter crime more than longer sentences.
(b) Crime rates vary from city to city.
(c) Punishments should be made even tougher.
(d) Prisons are expensive to run.

Q20 Where does the sentence "For example, a simple app can remind patients to take their medicine." fit best? (1) Technology is changing healthcare. (2) ___ (3) Such tools improve treatment results. (4) Doctors are increasingly recommending them.

(a) after sentence (3)
(b) after sentence (4)
(c) after sentence (1)
(d) before sentence (1)

Q21 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) Inflation reduces the value of money.
(b) When prices rise, the same salary buys less.
(c) Many people enjoy shopping during festivals.
(d) Central banks raise interest rates to control inflation.

Q22 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "The printing press made books cheaper. More people learnt to read. Ideas spread faster than ever before. _____"

(a) Books today are printed digitally.
(b) Reading is a pleasant hobby.
(c) The printing press was heavy.
(d) In this way, a single invention transformed society.

Q23 Which sentence does not belong to the paragraph?

(a) A good résumé should be short.
(b) Most interviews last about thirty minutes.

(c) It should highlight achievements, not just duties.

(d) Spelling mistakes can ruin a first impression.

Q24 Which sentence best completes the paragraph? "Cities are getting hotter. Concrete and asphalt absorb heat during the day and release it at night. Trees, on the other hand, provide shade and cool the air. _____"

(a) Concrete is a strong building material.

(b) Planting more trees is one of the cheapest ways to cool a city.

(c) Many cities have tall buildings.

(d) Night temperatures are always low.

Q25 Where does the sentence "They then vote on whether to accept it." fit best? (1) A bill is first introduced in Parliament. (2) Members debate it in detail. (3) ___ (4) If it passes both houses, it goes to the President for assent.

(a) after sentence (2)

(b) after sentence (1)

(c) after sentence (4)

(d) before sentence (1)

15.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (b) The stock market fell sharply today.**

The other three sentences are about bees and honey; the odd sentence is on a different topic.

Q2 **Answer: (c) Tea is grown widely in Assam.**

The other three sentences are steps in a process; the odd sentence is a general fact, not a step.

Q3 **Answer: (a) Buses in the city are painted red.**

The other three sentences form a story of Ravi's morning; the odd sentence breaks it.

Q4 **Answer: (d) Reducing plastic use is therefore urgent.**

The paragraph lists harms; the logical conclusion is a call to act: **Reducing plastic use is therefore urgent.**

Q5 **Answer: (d) It is also gentle on the joints.**

The paragraph lists advantages of walking; **It is also gentle on the joints** continues the list.

Q6 **Answer: (d) Reading improves vocabulary.**

The other three sentences are library rules; the odd sentence is a general claim about reading.

Q7 **Answer: (c) after sentence (2)**

"This" refers to the invention of the railway, so the sentence goes **after sentence (2)**.

Q8 **Answer: (a) Within a year, sales had recovered.**

The paragraph sets up a problem and an action; it should end with the result: **Within a year, sales had recovered.**

Q9 **Answer: (b) The first car was built in Germany.**

The other three sentences discuss electric cars today; the odd sentence is car history.

Q10 **Answer: (a) Yoga mats are made from rubber or PVC.**

The paragraph is about the practice and benefits of yoga; the odd sentence is about the material of mats.

Q11 **Answer: (d) Information learnt over several days is remembered far better.**

"Research shows otherwise" needs the finding: **Information learnt over several days is remembered far better.** The option saying cramming is popular merely repeats the first sentence.

Q12 **Answer: (b) after sentence (1)**

"However" contrasts with the plan in (1), and explains why engineers suggested repairs in (3): **after sentence (1)**.

Q13 **Answer: (c) The internet was created for military research.**

The other three sentences describe advantages of online learning; the odd sentence is internet history.

Q14 **Answer: (b) Their loss would therefore be a disaster for ocean life.**

The paragraph stresses the reefs' importance; the conclusion follows: **Their loss would therefore be a disaster for ocean life.**

Q15 **Answer: (d) Coffee is the world's most traded commodity after oil.**

The other three sentences describe the meeting; the odd sentence is unrelated (and also factually doubtful).

Q16 **Answer: (d) However, some feel isolated from their colleagues.**

The blank must explain why companies want to keep teams connected: **However, some feel isolated from their colleagues.**

Q17 **Answer: (b) Vitamins are found in fresh fruit.**

The other three sentences build the point that antibiotics do not help with colds; the odd sentence is off-topic.

Q18 **Answer: (a) Mumbai is India's financial capital.**

The other three sentences summarise the novel's plot; the odd sentence is a general fact about the city, a different scope.

Q19 **Answer: (a) Better policing may therefore deter crime more than longer sentences.**

The conclusion should follow from "certainty matters more than severity": **Better policing may therefore deter crime more than longer sentences.** The option calling for tougher punishments contradicts the evidence.

Q20 **Answer: (c) after sentence (1)**

"For example" follows the general claim in (1), and "Such tools" in (3) refers back to the app: **after sentence (1)**.

Q21 **Answer: (c) Many people enjoy shopping during festivals.**

The other three sentences explain inflation; the odd sentence is unrelated.

Q22 **Answer: (d) In this way, a single invention transformed society.**

The paragraph traces a chain of effects; the best ending summarises them: **In this way, a single invention transformed society.**

Q23 **Answer: (b) Most interviews last about thirty minutes.**

The other three sentences are advice on writing a résumé; the odd sentence is about interviews.

Q24 **Answer: (b) Planting more trees is one of the cheapest ways to cool a city.**

The contrast between concrete and trees leads to a practical conclusion: **Planting more trees is one of the cheapest ways to cool a city.**

Q25 **Answer: (a) after sentence (2)**

"They" = the members who debated, and voting comes before passing: **after sentence (2)**.

Odd sentence out: the odd one differs in topic, scope, time or tone, or cannot be linked; build the chain and see what is left. Completion: match the topic, tone and direction, and prefer a conclusion that follows from the last sentence. Insertion: follow pronouns and connectors to the gap.

MODULE 16 · INTERMEDIATE

Reading comprehension basics

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Intermediate**

Reading comprehension is the largest part of most verbal sections. This module covers active reading, skimming and scanning, balancing speed and understanding, passage structure (topic, main idea, supporting details and paragraph roles), the basic question types (main idea and title, specific detail, vocabulary in context, true/false/not given) and a reliable RC strategy, followed by four passages with 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

16.1 Reading skills
16.2 Passage structure
16.3 Basic question types
16.4 RC strategy
16.5 Practice questions
16.6 Solutions

16.1 Reading skills

16.1.1 Active reading: asking questions while reading

Passive reading lets the words pass by; active reading asks questions: *What is this paragraph about? Why does the author mention this example? Does the author agree?* Active readers remember more and answer faster.

16.1.2 Skimming for the main idea

Skimming means reading quickly for the gist: the first and last sentences of each paragraph, and words such as *however, therefore, the main reason*. Use it to get a map of the passage.

16.1.3 Scanning for specific details

Scanning means searching for a particular name, number or keyword without reading everything. Use it to locate the lines that answer a detail question, then read those lines carefully.

16.1.4 Reading speed vs understanding

Speed without understanding wastes time, because you must reread. Aim for steady, thoughtful reading: most test passages can be read carefully in two to three minutes. Speed grows with daily practice, not by skipping words.

16.2 Passage structure

16.2.1 Topic, main idea and supporting details

Term	Meaning	Example
Topic	what the passage is about (a few words)	remote work
Main idea	the author's central point about the topic (a sentence)	Remote work has benefits and costs, so many firms choose hybrid models.
Supporting details	facts, examples and reasons that back the main idea	saves travel time; new staff learn slowly

16.2.2 Paragraph roles



TYPICAL ROLES OF PARAGRAPHS

16.3 Basic question types

16.3.1 Main idea and title

The right answer covers the whole passage, not just one paragraph, and is neither too broad nor too narrow. A good title is short, specific to the topic and matches the author's attitude.

16.3.2 Specific detail

The answer is stated in the passage, often in different words. Scan for the keyword, read the sentence before and after, and match the meaning, not just the words.

16.3.3 Vocabulary in context

The question asks what a word means **as used in the passage**. Replace the word with each option and reread the sentence; the familiar dictionary meaning is often the trap.

16.3.4 True / false / not given

Answer	Means
True	the passage states it or it follows directly
False	the passage states the opposite
Not given	the passage says nothing either way; do not use outside knowledge

WATCH OUT
The commonest RC error is choosing an answer that is true in real life but not stated in the passage. Every answer must be supported by the text.

16.4 RC strategy

16.4.1 Questions first or passage first

For short passages, read the passage first, then the questions. For long passages under time pressure, glance at the question stems first (not the options) so you know what to look for, then read the passage.

16.4.2 Making brief notes

Write two or three words per paragraph in the margin (or in your head): "problem", "example: Delhi", "author disagrees". This map lets you find answers quickly.

16.4.3 Finding evidence in the passage for every answer

SHORTCUT TRICK
Before marking an answer, put your finger on the line that proves it. If you cannot find one, it is probably a trap.

16.5 Practice questions

16.5.1 Basic level

Q1 *Passage 1 (Q1–Q6).*
The honeybee is one of the most important insects for human food supply. As bees move from flower to flower collecting nectar, they carry pollen, which allows plants to produce fruits and seeds. Scientists estimate that about one-third of the food we eat depends on pollination by insects, mainly bees. In recent years, however, bee populations in many countries have fallen sharply. The causes include the use of certain pesticides, the loss of wild flowers, and diseases spread by parasites. Some farmers now rent hives to pollinate their crops, but this is expensive. Experts say that planting more flowers and reducing harmful pesticides are the most effective ways to protect bees.

What is the main idea of the passage?

(a) Bees produce honey that is good for health.
(b) Pesticides are the only cause of the decline of bees.
(c) Bees are vital for food production but are declining, and steps can be taken to protect them.
(d) Farmers should rent hives for all crops.

Q2 Passage 1: According to the passage, about how much of our food depends on insect pollination?

(a) one-third **(b)** one-half **(c)** one-quarter **(d)** two-thirds

Q3 Passage 1: Which of the following is NOT mentioned as a cause of the fall in bee numbers?

(a) pesticides **(b)** climate change
(c) loss of wild flowers **(d)** diseases spread by parasites

Q4 Passage 1: The word "sharply" in the passage most nearly means

(a) cleverly **(b)** painfully **(c)** clearly **(d)** steeply

Q5 Passage 1: Why do some farmers rent hives?

(a) to produce honey for sale **(b)** to study bee diseases
(c) to pollinate their crops **(d)** to reduce pesticide use

Q6 Passage 1: Which title suits the passage best?

(a) The Sweetness of Honey **(b)** How Pesticides Are Made
(c) Saving the Pollinators **(d)** Farming in the Modern Age

Q7 *Passage 2 (Q7–Q12).*
When the first public library opened in the town in 1950, it had only a few hundred books and one room. Today it occupies a three-storey building and lends e-books as well as printed ones. Yet the librarian, Mrs. Fernandes, says the library's most valuable service is not its books. "Many people come here simply for a quiet place to study," she explains. "Students who share small homes with large families find it impossible to concentrate at home." The library has therefore extended its opening hours during the examination season. It also runs free reading classes for adults who never had the chance to go to school. For Mrs. Fernandes, a library is less a store of books than a meeting place for the whole community.

According to Mrs. Fernandes, what is the library's most valuable service?

(a) lending e-books **(b)** its collection of printed books
(c) its large building **(d)** providing a quiet place to study

Q8 Passage 2: Why did the library extend its opening hours?

(a) because it had more books
(b) to help students during the examination season
(c) to run adult reading classes
(d) because the building was larger

16.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Passage 2: True, False or Not given? "The library first opened with one room."

(a) True **(b)** False **(c)** Not given **(d)** Partly true

Q10 Passage 2: True, False or Not given? "The library charges a small fee for adult reading classes."

(a) True **(b)** False **(c)** Not given **(d)** Partly true

Q11 Passage 2: The word "concentrate" in the passage means

(a) focus attention **(b)** gather together
(c) make stronger **(d)** reduce in size

Q12 Passage 2: Which statement best expresses Mrs. Fernandes's view of a library?

(a) It is mainly a store of books.
(b) It is only for students.
(c) It is mainly a meeting place for the community.
(d) It should replace schools.

Q13 *Passage 3 (Q13–Q18).*
Sleep is often treated as wasted time, something to be cut short when work piles up. Research suggests this is a costly mistake. During sleep, the brain sorts and stores the information gathered during the day; students who sleep well after studying remember more than those who stay up late revising. Lack of sleep also slows reaction times, making drivers who have slept less than five hours almost as dangerous as drunk drivers. Over the long term, regular short sleep has been linked to heart disease and weakened immunity. Most adults need seven to nine hours a night, yet surveys show that a third of working adults get less than six. The problem, then, is not that we do not know the value of sleep, but that we do not act on what we know.

What is the main point of the passage?

(a) Students should study late at night.
(b) Drunk driving is more dangerous than tired driving.
(c) Most adults sleep more than nine hours.
(d) People know sleep matters but do not get enough of it.

Q14 Passage 3: According to the passage, what happens in the brain during sleep?

(a) It stops working completely.
(b) It forgets unimportant facts only.

(c) It produces new brain cells.

(d) It sorts and stores the day's information.

Q15 Passage 3: Drivers who have slept less than five hours are compared to

(a) new drivers **(b)** professional drivers

(c) drunk drivers **(d)** elderly drivers

Q16 Passage 3: True, False or Not given? "A third of working adults sleep less than six hours."

(a) True **(b)** False **(c)** Not given **(d)** Partly true

16.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Passage 3: True, False or Not given? "Taking a short nap in the afternoon improves memory."

(a) True **(b)** False **(c)** Partly true **(d)** Not given

Q18 Passage 3: The author's attitude towards cutting sleep for work is

(a) approving **(b)** critical **(c)** indifferent **(d)** amused

Q19 *Passage 4 (Q19–Q25).*

For decades, cities were designed around the car. Wide roads, large parking lots and fast flyovers were seen as signs of progress. But as traffic grew, these roads filled up almost as quickly as they were built, a pattern planners call "induced demand". Some cities have begun to take a different approach. Instead of adding lanes, they have improved buses, built safe cycle tracks and widened footpaths. Critics argued that shopkeepers would lose customers if car access were reduced. In several cities, the opposite happened: pedestrians and cyclists, who move slowly and stop often, turned out to spend more at local shops over a month than drivers did. The lesson is not that cars should be banned, but that streets work best when they serve people rather than vehicles.

What does "induced demand" refer to in the passage?

(a) people demanding more buses

(b) new roads filling up with more traffic soon after they are built

(c) shopkeepers asking for parking

(d) cities banning cars

Q20 Passage 4: What did critics fear would happen if car access were reduced?

(a) Traffic would increase. **(b)** Cycle tracks would be unsafe.

(c) Buses would become crowded. **(d)** Shopkeepers would lose customers.

Q21 Passage 4: According to the passage, why did pedestrians and cyclists spend more at local shops?

(a) They move slowly and stop often. **(b)** They have more money.

(c) Shops gave them discounts. **(d)** They cannot travel far.

Q22 Passage 4: The word "opposite" in "the opposite happened" refers to

(a) cars being banned

(b) roads becoming wider

(c) shops gaining rather than losing customers

(d) traffic increasing

Q23 Passage 4: Which of the following would the author most likely support?

(a) building a new flyover in the city centre
(b) banning all private cars
(c) converting cycle tracks into parking
(d) widening footpaths in a busy market street

Q24 Passage 4: True, False or Not given? "The author believes cars should be banned from cities."

(a) True (b) False (c) Not given (d) Partly true

Q25 Passage 4: Which is the best title for the passage?

(a) Streets for People, Not Just Cars
(b) The History of the Automobile
(c) Why Shopkeepers Fear Change
(d) How to Build a Flyover

16.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) Bees are vital for food production but are declining, and steps can be taken to protect them.**

The passage covers the importance of bees, their decline, its causes and solutions: the correct option **covers the whole passage**. The others are too narrow or not stated.

Q2 **Answer: (a) one-third**

"About **one-third** of the food we eat depends on pollination by insects."

Q3 **Answer: (b) climate change**

The passage lists pesticides, loss of wild flowers and parasites. **Climate change** is not mentioned.

Q4 **Answer: (d) steeply**

Populations "have fallen sharply": by a large amount, **steeply**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) to pollinate their crops**

"Some farmers now rent hives **to pollinate their crops**."

Q6 **Answer: (c) Saving the Pollinators**

The passage is about bees as pollinators and how to protect them: **Saving the Pollinators**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) providing a quiet place to study**

She says its most valuable service is "not its books"; people come "for **a quiet place to study**".

Q8 **Answer: (b) to help students during the examination season**

Extended hours are "during the examination season", linked to students needing a quiet place: **to help students**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) True**

"It had only a few hundred books and **one room**": True.

Q10 **Answer: (b) False**

The passage says the classes are **free**, so the statement is False.

Q11 **Answer: (a) focus attention**

Students cannot "concentrate at home": they cannot **focus their attention**.

Q12 **Answer: (c) It is mainly a meeting place for the community.**

Final sentence: "less a store of books than **a meeting place for the whole community**".

Q13 **Answer: (d) People know sleep matters but do not get enough of it.**

The passage lists the benefits of sleep and ends: "we do not act on what we know": **people know but do not get enough**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) It sorts and stores the day's information.**

"During sleep, the brain **sorts and stores** the information gathered during the day."

Q15 **Answer: (c) drunk drivers**

They are "almost as dangerous as **drunk drivers**".

Q16 **Answer: (a) True**

"Surveys show that a third of working adults get less than six": **True**.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Not given**

The passage says nothing about afternoon naps: **Not given**.

Q18 **Answer: (b) critical**

The author calls it "a costly mistake": **critical**.

Q19 **Answer: (b) new roads filling up with more traffic soon after they are built**

The roads "filled up almost as quickly as they were built, a pattern planners call induced demand": **new roads attract more traffic**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) Shopkeepers would lose customers.**

"Critics argued that **shopkeepers would lose customers**."

Q21 **Answer: (a) They move slowly and stop often.**

They "**move slowly and stop often**", so over a month they spent more.

Q22 **Answer: (c) shops gaining rather than losing customers**

Critics expected shops to lose customers; the opposite was **shops gaining customers** (spending rose).

Q23 **Answer: (d) widening footpaths in a busy market street**

The author favours streets that "serve people": **widening footpaths**. The author explicitly says cars should not be banned.

Q24 **Answer: (b) False**

"The lesson is not that cars should be banned": **False**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) Streets for People, Not Just Cars**

The passage argues for designing streets around people: **Streets for People, Not Just Cars**.

Read actively, skim for the map and scan for details. The main idea covers the whole passage; details are stated in other words; vocabulary questions depend on context; "not given" means the passage is silent. Find a supporting line for every answer and never rely on outside knowledge.

MODULE 17 · INTERMEDIATE

Verbal analogies, word relationships and classification

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Intermediate**

Language-based reasoning questions test how well you understand the relationships between words. This module covers the main analogy relationships (synonym, antonym, part–whole, cause–effect, function, degree, category and more), building a bridge sentence, odd word out by meaning, usage or grammar, word association and arranging words in logical order, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

17.1 Verbal analogies
17.2 Word classification
17.3 Word association
17.4 Word order
17.5 Practice questions
17.6 Solutions

17.1 Verbal analogies

17.1.1 Relationship types

Relationship	Example pair	Bridge sentence
Synonym	Happy : Joyful	Happy means the same as joyful.
Antonym	Hot : Cold	Hot is the opposite of cold.
Part – whole	Petal : Flower	A petal is part of a flower.
Category (type of)	Rose : Flower	A rose is a kind of flower.
Cause – effect	Fire : Smoke	Fire causes smoke.
Function / tool – user	Scissors : Cut	Scissors are used to cut.
Worker – tool	Carpenter : Saw	A carpenter works with a saw.
Worker – product	Author : Book	An author writes a book.
Degree / intensity	Warm : Hot	Hot is a stronger degree of warm.
Place	Doctor : Hospital	A doctor works in a hospital.
Young one	Dog : Puppy	A young dog is a puppy.
Group	Lion : Pride	A group of lions is a pride.
Lack of	Coward : Courage	A coward lacks courage.

17.1.2 Building a "bridge sentence"

Make a short, specific sentence that links the first pair, then apply exactly that sentence to the options. If more than one option fits, make the sentence more precise.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Refining the bridge

Pen : Writer :: ?

Bridge 1: "A writer uses a pen." Options: Brush : Painter, Knife : Chef. Both fit. Bridge 2: "A writer uses a pen to **create** his work." Brush : Painter fits better (a chef's knife prepares, a brush creates the work itself). Precision decides.

SHORTCUT TRICK

Always state the relationship in the same direction as the question pair. "Puppy : Dog" (young one first) is not the same as "Dog : Puppy".

17.2 Word classification

17.2.1 Odd word out by meaning, usage or grammar

Find the common property shared by all but one word. Check, in order: meaning (category), connotation (positive vs negative), part of speech, and form (for example, all are past participles).

Group	Odd one	Reason
Mango, Apple, Potato, Banana	Potato	vegetable; others are fruits
Happy, Glad, Cheerful, Gloomy	Gloomy	negative; others positive
Run, Quickly, Jump, Swim	Quickly	adverb; others verbs
Written, Spoken, Taken, Went	Went	past tense; others past participles

17.3 Word association

17.3.1 Related word groups

Association questions ask which word is most closely related to a given set: *doctor, nurse, ward* → hospital; *bat, pitch, wicket* → cricket. Think of the setting, activity or category that contains all the given words.

17.4 Word order

17.4.1 Logical order of words

Arrange words by size (smallest to largest), by stage in a process (seed → plant → flower → fruit), by time (morning → noon → evening), or by the order of a hierarchy (village → district → state → country).



A PROCESS ORDER

17.5 Practice questions

17.5.1 Basic level

Q1 Book : Author :: Painting : ?

(a) Canvas (b) Gallery (c) Painter (d) Brush

Q2 Hot : Cold :: Up : ?

(a) Down (b) Above (c) High (d) Top

Q3 Petal : Flower :: Page : ?

(a) Paper (b) Book (c) Word (d) Library

Q4 Dog : Puppy :: Cat : ?

(a) Cub (b) Calf (c) Kid (d) Kitten

Q5 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Apple (b) Mango (c) Carrot (d) Grape

Q6 Doctor : Hospital :: Teacher : ?

(a) Student (b) Book (c) School (d) Lesson

Q7 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Cheerful (b) Joyful (c) Merry (d) Gloomy

Q8 Arrange in a logical order: 1. Adult 2. Infant 3. Teenager 4. Child

(a) 4, 2, 3, 1 (b) 2, 4, 3, 1 (c) 2, 3, 4, 1 (d) 1, 3, 4, 2

17.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Fire : Smoke :: Rain : ?

(a) Flood (b) Cloud (c) Umbrella (d) Water

Q10 Carpenter : Saw :: Surgeon : ?

(a) Hospital (b) Scalpel (c) Patient (d) Operation

Q11 Warm : Hot :: Cool : ?

(a) Cold (b) Warm (c) Mild (d) Ice

Q12 Lion : Pride :: Fish : ?

(a) Herd (b) Flock (c) School (d) Pack

Q13 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Run (b) Jump (c) Swim (d) Quickly

Q14 Coward : Courage :: Miser : ?

(a) Money (b) Wealth (c) Greed (d) Generosity

Q15 Which word is most closely associated with: wicket, over, pitch?

(a) Football (b) Tennis (c) Cricket (d) Hockey

Q16 Arrange in a logical order: 1. District 2. Village 3. State 4. Country

(a) 2, 1, 3, 4 (b) 1, 2, 3, 4 (c) 2, 3, 1, 4 (d) 4, 3, 1, 2

17.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 Scissors : Cut :: Needle : ?

(a) Thread (b) Cloth (c) Sharp (d) Sew

Q18 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Written (b) Went (c) Spoken (d) Taken

Q19 Ignorance : Knowledge :: Poverty : ?

(a) Hunger (b) Wealth (c) Money (d) Poor

Q20 Choose the pair that has the same relationship as Thermometer : Temperature.

(a) Speedometer : Car (b) Clock : Wall
(c) Scale : Weight-lifter (d) Barometer : Pressure

Q21 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Glance (b) Stare (c) Gaze (d) Peer

Q22 Choose the pair that has the same relationship as Drought : Famine.

(a) Rain : Cloud (b) Food : Hunger
(c) Earthquake : Destruction (d) Water : River

Q23 Arrange in a logical order: 1. Harvest 2. Sow 3. Plough 4. Irrigate

(a) 2, 3, 4, 1 (b) 3, 4, 2, 1 (c) 1, 3, 2, 4 (d) 3, 2, 4, 1

Q24 Choose the pair that has the same relationship as Garrulous : Talk.

(a) Silent : Speak (b) Gluttonous : Eat
(c) Generous : Take (d) Lazy : Work

Q25 Choose the odd one out.

(a) Hesitant (b) Resolute (c) Determined (d) Steadfast

17.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) Painter**

An author creates a book; a **painter** creates a painting (worker – product).

Q2 **Answer: (a) Down**

Antonyms: hot – cold, up – **down**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) Book**

A petal is part of a flower; a page is part of a **book**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) Kitten**

Young one: a young cat is a **kitten**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) Carrot**

Apple, mango and grape are fruits; **carrot** is a vegetable.

Q6 **Answer: (c) School**

A doctor works in a hospital; a teacher works in a **school** (place of work).

Q7 **Answer: (d) Gloomy**

Cheerful, joyful and merry are positive; **gloomy** is negative.

Q8 **Answer: (b) 2, 4, 3, 1**

Stages of life: infant, child, teenager, adult: **2, 4, 3, 1**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) Flood**

Cause – effect: fire can cause smoke; heavy rain can cause a **flood**. (Clouds cause rain, which reverses the direction.)

Q10 **Answer: (b) Scalpel**

Worker – tool: a surgeon works with a **scalpel**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) Cold**

Degree: hot is a stronger warm; **cold** is a stronger cool.

Q12 **Answer: (c) School**

Group names: a pride of lions, a **school** of fish.

Q13 **Answer: (d) Quickly**

Run, jump and swim are verbs; **quickly** is an adverb.

Q14 **Answer: (d) Generosity**

Lack of: a coward lacks courage; a miser lacks **generosity**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) Cricket**

All three belong to **cricket**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) 2, 1, 3, 4**

From smallest to largest unit: village, district, state, country: **2, 1, 3, 4**.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Sew**

Function: scissors are used to cut; a needle is used to **sew**.

Q18 **Answer: (b) Went**

Written, spoken and taken are past participles; **went** is a simple past form.

Q19 **Answer: (b) Wealth**

Absence and its opposite: ignorance is the lack of knowledge; poverty is the lack of **wealth**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) Barometer : Pressure**

A thermometer measures temperature; a barometer measures **pressure**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) Glance**

Stare, gaze and peer all mean looking for a long time or closely; **glance** is a quick look.

Q22 **Answer: (c) Earthquake : Destruction**

Cause – effect: drought leads to famine; an earthquake leads to **destruction**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) 3, 2, 4, 1**

Farming process: plough, sow, irrigate, harvest: **3, 2, 4, 1**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) Gluttonous : Eat**

Garrulous means talking too much; gluttonous means **eating too much** (excess of the action).

Q25 **Answer: (a) Hesitant**

Resolute, determined and steadfast mean firm in purpose; **hesitant** means uncertain.

Name the exact relationship with a bridge sentence and keep its direction. For classification, test category, connotation, part of speech and form. For association, find the setting or category that contains all the words. For order, use size, process, time or hierarchy.

MODULE 18 · INTERMEDIATE

Voice and narration

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Intermediate**

Active–passive voice and direct–indirect speech are tested directly in many exams. This module covers changing voice in every tense, modals in the passive, imperative and interrogative sentences, sentences with two objects and when to use the passive in professional writing; then changes of pronoun, tense, time and place words in reported speech, statements, questions, commands and exclamations, and universal truths, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

18.1 Active and passive voice
18.2 Direct and indirect speech
18.3 Practice questions
18.4 Solutions

18.1 Active and passive voice

The chef	cooked	the meal.	→	The meal	was cooked	by the chef.
subject (doer)	verb	object		new subject	be + past participle	by + doer

ACTIVE TO PASSIVE: THE OBJECT BECOMES THE SUBJECT

18.1.1 Changing voice in all tenses

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Present continuous	She is writing a letter.	A letter is being written by her.
Present perfect	She has written a letter.	A letter has been written by her.
Simple past	She wrote a letter.	A letter was written by her.
Past continuous	She was writing a letter.	A letter was being written by her.
Past perfect	She had written a letter.	A letter had been written by her.
Simple future	She will write a letter.	A letter will be written by her.
Future perfect	She will have written a letter.	A letter will have been written by her.

Perfect continuous tenses and the future continuous are normally not changed into the passive.

18.1.2 Modals in the passive

Modal + **be** + past participle: "You must submit the form" → "The form must be submitted (by you)". "They can solve it" → "It can be solved".

18.1.3 Imperative and interrogative sentences

Active	Passive
Close the door.	Let the door be closed. / The door should be closed.
Please help me.	You are requested to help me.
Did he write the report?	Was the report written by him?
Who broke the glass?	By whom was the glass broken?
Why did they cancel the trip?	Why was the trip cancelled by them?

18.1.4 Sentences with two objects

With verbs like *give, send, show, teach, offer*, either object can become the subject. The person (indirect object) is more common: "The manager gave Riya a bonus" → "**Riya was given** a bonus by the manager" or "**A bonus was given** to Riya by the manager".

18.1.5 When to use passive voice in professional writing

Use the passive when the doer is unknown or unimportant ("The server was restarted at 2 am"), or to be tactful ("Mistakes were made"). Prefer the active when the doer matters and for clear, direct writing.

18.2 Direct and indirect speech

18.2.1 Changes in pronouns, tenses, time and place words

When the reporting verb is in the past (said, told, asked), shift each tense one step back and change pronouns and time/place words to suit the reporter.

Direct	Indirect	Direct	Indirect
simple present	simple past	now	then
present continuous	past continuous	today	that day
present perfect	past perfect	tomorrow	the next day
simple past	past perfect	yesterday	the previous day
will	would	here	there
can / may	could / might	this / these	that / those
must	had to (or must)	ago	before

18.2.2 Statements, questions, commands and exclamations

Type	Direct	Indirect
Statement	He said, "I am tired."	He said that he was tired.
Yes/no question	She said to me, "Are you ready?"	She asked me if (whether) I was ready.
Wh- question	He said, "Where do you live?"	He asked where I lived.
Command	The teacher said, "Sit down."	The teacher told (ordered) us to sit down.
Request	She said, "Please help me."	She requested me to help her.
Negative command	He said, "Don't shout."	He told me not to shout.
Exclamation	He said, "What a beautiful view!"	He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful view.

WATCH OUT
Reported questions use statement word order and no question mark: "He asked where I lived", not "He asked where did I live?".

18.2.3 Universal truths and exceptions

The tense does not change when the reported statement is a universal truth, a habitual fact or when the reporting verb is in the present or future: *The teacher said that the sun **rises** in the east. She says that she **is** busy.*

18.3 Practice questions

18.3.1 Basic level

Q1 Change to passive: "The boy kicked the ball."

(a) The ball is kicked by the boy.
(b) The ball has been kicked by the boy.
(c) The ball was kicked by the boy.
(d) The boy was kicked by the ball.

Q2 Change to passive: "She writes poems."

(a) Poems are written by her.
(b) Poems were written by her.
(c) Poems is written by her.
(d) Poems are being written by her.

Q3 Change to passive: "They are building a bridge."

(a) A bridge was being built by them.
(b) A bridge is being built by them.
(c) A bridge is built by them.
(d) A bridge has been built by them.

Q4 Change to indirect speech: He said, "I am busy."

(a) He said that I was busy.
(b) He said that he is busy.
(c) He told that he was busy.
(d) He said that he was busy.

Q5 Change to passive: "You must finish the work."

(a) The work must finished by you.
(b) The work must have finished by you.
(c) The work must be finished by you.
(d) The work must being finished by you.

Q6 Change to indirect speech: She said, "I will come tomorrow."

(a) She said that she will come tomorrow.
(b) She said that she would come tomorrow.
(c) She said that she would come the next day.
(d) She said that I would come the next day.

Q7 Change to passive: "Close the window."

(a) The window was closed.
(b) Let close the window.
(c) The window is closing.
(d) Let the window be closed.

Q8 Change to indirect speech: The teacher said, "The earth revolves around the sun."

(a) The teacher said that the earth revolved around the sun.
(b) The teacher said that the earth revolves around the sun.
(c) The teacher said that the earth had revolved around the sun.
(d) The teacher told that the earth revolves around the sun.

18.3.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Change to passive: "Who wrote this letter?"

(a) By whom was this letter written?
(b) Who was this letter written?
(c) By whom this letter was written?
(d) Whom wrote this letter?

Q10 Change to passive: "He has completed the project."

(a) The project had been completed by him.
(b) The project has been completed by him.
(c) The project has completed by him.
(d) The project was completed by him.

Q11 Change to indirect speech: He said to me, "Are you coming?"

(a) He asked me if I was coming.
(b) He asked me if I am coming.
(c) He asked me was I coming.
(d) He told me if I was coming.

Q12 Change to indirect speech: She said to me, "Where do you live?"

(a) She asked me where did I live.
(b) She asked me where I live.
(c) She asked me where I lived.
(d) She asked me that where I lived.

Q13 Change to passive: "The manager gave Riya a bonus."

(a) Riya is given a bonus by the manager.
(b) A bonus is given to Riya by the manager.
(c) Riya was gave a bonus by the manager.
(d) Riya was given a bonus by the manager.

Q14 Change to indirect speech: The officer said, "Don't park here."

(a) The officer told us do not park there.
(b) The officer said us not to park here.
(c) The officer told us not to park here.
(d) The officer told us not to park there.

Q15 Change to indirect speech: He said, "I saw her yesterday."

(a) He said that he saw her yesterday.
(b) He said that he has seen her the previous day.
(c) He said that he had seen her the previous day.
(d) He said that he had seen her yesterday.

Q16 Change to active: "The thief was caught by the police."

(a) The police caught the thief.
(b) The police catches the thief.
(c) The police have caught the thief.
(d) The thief caught the police.

18.3.3 Advanced level

Q17 Change to passive: "They will have finished the task by noon."

(a) The task will be finished by them by noon.
(b) The task will have finished by them by noon.
(c) The task would have been finished by them by noon.
(d) The task will have been finished by them by noon.

Q18 Change to indirect speech: She said, "Please lend me your pen."

(a) She requested me to lend me your pen.
(b) She requested me to lend her my pen.
(c) She told me lend her my pen.
(d) She requested that I lend her your pen.

Q19 Change to passive: "Why did they postpone the meeting?"

(a) Why the meeting was postponed by them?
(b) Why was the meeting postponed by them?

(c) Why did the meeting postponed by them? (d) Why was the meeting postpone by them?

Q20 Change to indirect speech: He said, "What a lovely garden!"

(a) He exclaimed what a lovely garden it is.
(b) He said what a lovely garden!
(c) He asked that it was a lovely garden.
(d) He exclaimed that it was a very lovely garden.

Q21 Change to passive: "People speak English all over the world."

(a) English is spoken all over the world.
(b) English is spoken by people all over the world by them.
(c) English was spoken all over the world.
(d) English speaks all over the world.

Q22 Change to indirect speech: He said, "I have been working here for five years."

(a) He said that he has been working here for five years.
(b) He said that he had been working here for five years.
(c) He said that he had been working there for five years.
(d) He said that he was working there for five years.

Q23 Change to passive: "Someone has stolen my bicycle."

(a) My bicycle has been stolen by someone else.
(b) My bicycle was being stolen.
(c) My bicycle had stolen.
(d) My bicycle has been stolen.

Q24 Change to indirect speech: She says, "I am tired."

(a) She says that she was tired. (b) She says that she is tired.
(c) She said that she was tired. (d) She says that I am tired.

Q25 Change to indirect speech: The coach said to the players, "Let us practise harder."

(a) The coach proposed to the players that they should practise harder.
(b) The coach told the players let us practise harder.
(c) The coach ordered the players to practise harder by him.
(d) The coach asked the players if they practised harder.

18.4 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) The ball was kicked by the boy.**
Simple past active → **was** + past participle.

Q2 **Answer: (a) Poems are written by her.**
Simple present with plural subject "poems": **are written**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) A bridge is being built by them.**

Present continuous → **is being** + past participle.

Q4 **Answer: (d) He said that he was busy.**

Present → past, I → he: **He said that he was busy.**

Q5 **Answer: (c) The work must be finished by you.**

Modal + **be** + past participle.

Q6 **Answer: (c) She said that she would come the next day.**

will → would; tomorrow → **the next day**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) Let the window be closed.**

Imperative → **Let** + object + be + past participle.

Q8 **Answer: (b) The teacher said that the earth revolves around the sun.**

Universal truth: the tense does **not** change.

Q9 **Answer: (a) By whom was this letter written?**

"Who" → **By whom** + was + subject + past participle.

Q10 **Answer: (b) The project has been completed by him.**

Present perfect → **has been** + past participle.

Q11 **Answer: (a) He asked me if I was coming.**

Yes/no question → **asked … if**, statement order, tense back.

Q12 **Answer: (c) She asked me where I lived.**

Wh- question → asked + wh-word + statement order: **where I lived**.

Q13 **Answer: (d) Riya was given a bonus by the manager.**

Simple past; the indirect object becomes subject: **Riya was given a bonus**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) The officer told us not to park there.**

Negative command → **told … not to**; here → there.

Q15 **Answer: (c) He said that he had seen her the previous day.**

Simple past → past perfect; yesterday → **the previous day**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) The police caught the thief.**

Was + past participle → simple past active: **The police caught the thief.**

Q17 **Answer: (d) The task will have been finished by them by noon.**

Future perfect → **will have been** + past participle.

Q18 **Answer: (b) She requested me to lend her my pen.**

Request → **requested … to**; me → her, your → my.

Q19 **Answer: (b) Why was the meeting postponed by them?**

Wh- question keeps question order: **Why was the meeting postponed**?

Q20 **Answer: (d) He exclaimed that it was a very lovely garden.**

Exclamation → **exclaimed that** + statement with "very".

Q21 **Answer: (a) English is spoken all over the world.**

With a general doer ("people"), the by-phrase is dropped: **English is spoken all over the world.**

Q22 **Answer: (c) He said that he had been working there for five years.**

Present perfect continuous → past perfect continuous; here → **there**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) My bicycle has been stolen.**

An unknown doer is dropped: **My bicycle has been stolen.**

Q24 **Answer: (b) She says that she is tired.**

The reporting verb is present ("says"), so the tense does **not** change.

Q25 **Answer: (a) The coach proposed to the players that they should practise harder.**

"Let us" (suggestion) → **proposed / suggested that they should**.

Passive = be (in the tense of the active verb) + past participle; the object becomes the subject; drop "by" for unknown or general doers; modal + be + past participle. In reported speech, move tenses one step back after a past reporting verb, change pronouns and time/place words, use statement order in questions, "told … to / not to" for commands, and keep the present for universal truths.

LEVEL 3

Advanced level

Solve advanced reading comprehension and verbal critical reasoning, summarise text, master confusing words, write timed emails and essays, and clear spoken-English assessments

8 MODULES · 12 DAYS MINIMUM

Module 19 · Advanced reading comprehension	**2 days**
Module 20 · Verbal critical reasoning	**1 day**
Module 21 · Para summary and main idea	**1 day**
Module 22 · Text completion and sentence equivalence	**1 day**
Module 23 · Confusing words, spelling and word usage	**1 day**
Module 24 · Written English tests: email and essay writing	**2 days**
Module 25 · Spoken English assessments: Versant and SVAR	**2 days**
Module 26 · Exam strategy, mock tests and company-specific preparation	**2 days**

MODULE 19 · ADVANCED

Advanced reading comprehension

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Advanced**

This module covers the inference-based reading questions used in tougher placement tests and CAT-style exams: inference versus statement, avoiding extreme and out-of-scope options, the author's tone, purpose and agreement, the function of sentences and paragraphs, passage organisation, application and analogy questions, passage genres, and strategies for long, dense text, followed by three demanding passages with 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

19.1 Inference questions
19.2 Author-based questions
19.3 Structure questions
19.4 Application and analogy questions
19.5 Passage genres
19.6 Long passages and dense academic text
19.7 Practice questions
19.8 Solutions

19.1 Inference questions

19.1.1 What can be inferred vs what is stated

An **inference** is something that must be true if the passage is true, though it is not written in so many words. It is one small, safe step beyond the text, never a leap.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Inference

Text: "Since the new metro line opened, the number of cars entering the city centre has fallen by a fifth."
Valid inference: some people who used to drive now use the metro (or travel less).
Not valid: "Traffic jams have disappeared" (too extreme) or "The metro is profitable" (out of scope).

19.1.2 Avoiding extreme and out-of-scope options

Trap	Signs	Example
Extreme	always, never, all, only, completely, must	"All drivers have switched to the metro."
Out of scope	introduces an idea the passage does not discuss	"Metro fares should be reduced."
Distortion	uses the passage's words but changes the meaning	"Cars caused the metro to be built."
Opposite	reverses what the passage says	"Car use has risen."

SHORTCUT TRICK
Prefer cautious wording in inference answers: "some", "may", "can", "is likely". Correct inferences are usually modest.

19.2 Author-based questions

19.2.1 Author's tone and attitude

Tone word	Meaning
objective / neutral	presents facts without taking sides
critical	points out faults
sarcastic / ironic	says the opposite of what is meant, to mock
optimistic / pessimistic	expects good / bad outcomes
cautious / measured	careful, avoids strong claims
laudatory / appreciative	praises
indignant	angry at something unjust
ambivalent	mixed feelings

Look at adjectives and adverbs the author chooses (*alarming, welcome, so-called, admittedly*): they reveal the attitude.

19.2.2 Author's purpose

Ask why the passage was written: to **inform** (explain), to **argue** (persuade), to **compare**, to **criticise**, to **describe** or to **propose a solution**. The purpose verb must fit the whole passage.

19.2.3 Author's agreement or disagreement

Separate the author's own view from views the author reports ("critics claim", "some believe"). Signals such as "however", "yet", "this overlooks" show where the author steps in.

19.3 Structure questions

19.3.1 Function of a paragraph or sentence

Ask what a sentence **does**, not what it says: introduces a claim, gives an example, raises an objection, answers an objection, draws a conclusion.

19.3.2 Organisation of the passage



ONE COMMON ORGANISATION: PROBLEM → SOLUTION

19.4 Application and analogy questions

These ask which new situation is most similar to one described in the passage, or how the author would react to a new case. Identify the underlying principle first, then find the option with the same principle, not the same topic.

19.5 Passage genres

19.5.1 Business, economics, technology, science, philosophy, social issues

Genre	What to watch
Business / economics	cause and effect, trade-offs, data trends
Technology / science	definitions, processes, limits of a finding
Philosophy	precise definitions, the exact claim, counter-arguments
Social issues	author's stance versus reported views, tone

19.6 Long passages and dense academic text

Read the first paragraph carefully, then the first sentence of each later paragraph; note each paragraph's role in two words. Slow down for words of contrast and conclusion. You do not need to understand every technical term to answer the questions: many are explained by context or not asked about.

WATCH OUT
In dense passages, the trap answer often repeats a striking phrase from the text but attaches it to the wrong idea. Check that the option matches the meaning, not just the words.

19.7 Practice questions

19.7.1 Basic level

Q1 *Passage 1 (Q1–Q8).*
Economists have long assumed that people make choices rationally, weighing costs and benefits to maximise their own welfare. Behavioural economics challenges this picture. Its researchers have shown, for example, that people value a loss more heavily than a gain of the same size, and that they are swayed by how a choice is framed: a medical treatment described as having a "90 per cent survival rate" is preferred to one with a "10 per cent death rate", although the two are identical. Such findings do not mean that people are foolish. Rather, they suggest that the mind relies on shortcuts that usually work well but can mislead in predictable ways. Governments have begun to use these insights, for instance by making pension saving the default option so that employees must actively choose to opt out. Critics worry that such "nudges" may be used to manipulate citizens. Supporters reply that every choice is presented in some way, so the question is not whether to influence people but how to do so transparently and in their interest.

What is the primary purpose of the passage?

(a) to prove that people are irrational and foolish
(b) to argue that governments should never influence citizens
(c) to explain how behavioural economics challenges a traditional assumption and how its insights are used
(d) to describe the history of pension schemes

Q2 Passage 1: The example of the medical treatment is used to illustrate

(a) the effect of framing on choices
(b) the danger of medical treatments
(c) that people prefer gains to losses of different sizes
(d) that statistics are often false

Q3 Passage 1: It can be inferred from the passage that making pension saving the default

(a) forces all employees to save
(b) increases the number of employees who save for a pension
(c) is opposed by all economists
(d) reduces employees' freedom completely

Q4 Passage 1: According to the passage, behavioural economists suggest that mental shortcuts

(a) always lead to wrong decisions
(b) are used only by uneducated people
(c) can be eliminated through training
(d) usually work well but can mislead in predictable ways

Q5 Passage 1: The supporters of "nudges" argue that

(a) people should be manipulated for their own good
(b) choices should never be framed
(c) influence is unavoidable, so it should be transparent and in people's interest

(d) nudges are always harmless

Q6 Passage 1: The author's attitude towards behavioural economics is best described as

(a) hostile
(b) sarcastic
(c) balanced and appreciative
(d) indifferent

Q7 Passage 1: Which of the following situations best illustrates "loss aversion" as described in the passage?

(a) A shopper buys the cheapest product available.
(b) A student studies harder for a difficult exam.
(c) A customer compares prices in two shops.
(d) An investor refuses to sell a falling share because selling would "make the loss real".

Q8 Passage 1: The word "swayed" in the passage most nearly means

(a) moved from side to side
(b) influenced
(c) confused
(d) persuaded against their will

19.7.2 Intermediate level

Q9 *Passage 2 (Q9–Q16).*
It is fashionable to declare that the age of the printed book is over. E-readers, we are told, are lighter, cheaper and capable of storing thousands of titles. All of this is true, and yet sales of printed books have proved remarkably stubborn. Part of the explanation is practical: a printed book needs no battery and never crashes. But the deeper reason may be that a book is not merely a container for text. Readers remember where on a page a passage appeared; they flip back and forth; they lend, inscribe and display their books. Studies suggest that people reading long, complex texts on paper understand them slightly better than those reading on screens, perhaps because the physical book gives the mind a map. None of this means that screens have no place: for quick reference and travel they are unbeatable. The likelier future is not the triumph of one format but a division of labour between them.

The author's main argument is that

(a) printed books and e-readers will each keep a role suited to their strengths
(b) printed books will soon disappear
(c) e-readers are better than books in every way
(d) reading on screens damages the brain

Q10 Passage 2: The phrase "remarkably stubborn" suggests that sales of printed books have

(a) risen sharply
(b) not fallen as much as many expected
(c) collapsed
(d) been impossible to measure

Q11 Passage 2: Which of the following is presented as a "deeper reason" for the survival of printed books?

(a) A book is a physical object that readers interact with in many ways.
(b) Books need no battery.
(c) Books are cheaper than e-readers.
(d) Publishers refuse to sell e-books.

Q12 Passage 2: The tone of the opening sentence ("It is fashionable to declare…") is

(a) enthusiastic
(b) angry
(c) mildly sceptical
(d) neutral and factual

Q13 Passage 2: According to the passage, studies suggest that reading long texts on paper

(a) is much faster than on screens
(b) causes eye strain
(c) is preferred by all readers
(d) leads to slightly better understanding

Q14 Passage 2: The author would most likely agree that e-readers are

(a) useless for any purpose
(b) certain to replace books
(c) harmful to reading habits
(d) very useful for travel and quick reference

Q15 Passage 2: What is the function of the sentence "None of this means that screens have no place"?

(a) to introduce a new topic
(b) to summarise evidence against books
(c) to prevent the reader from concluding that the author rejects screens
(d) to criticise e-reader makers

Q16 Passage 2: The word "map" in the passage refers to

(a) a mental sense of where things are in the text
(b) a geographical chart printed in books
(c) the table of contents
(d) a reading plan

19.7.3 Advanced level

Q17 *Passage 3 (Q17–Q25).*
The idea that more choice always makes people happier seems self-evident. A supermarket with forty kinds of jam surely serves customers better than one with six. Yet in a well-known experiment, shoppers offered six jams were far more likely to buy one than those offered twenty-four. Psychologists call this "choice overload": when options multiply, the effort of comparing them rises, and so does the fear of choosing wrongly. Even when people do choose, they are often less satisfied, because they can easily imagine that a rejected option would have been better. This does not mean that choice is bad; having no choice at all is plainly worse. The point is that the relationship between choice and well-being is not a straight line but a curve that rises, flattens and may eventually fall. Designers of products and public services might therefore do better to offer a small number of well-chosen options than an endless menu.

Which statement best expresses the main idea of the passage?

(a) People are happier with no choice at all.
(b) Supermarkets should sell only six products.
(c) More choice always makes people happier.
(d) Beyond a point, more choice can reduce people's satisfaction and willingness to choose.

Q18 Passage 3: The jam experiment is mentioned in order to

(a) show that jam is a popular product
(b) provide evidence that challenges a common assumption
(c) prove that shoppers dislike supermarkets
(d) explain how jam is made

Q19 Passage 3: According to the passage, why might people be less satisfied after choosing from many options?

(a) They pay more for their choice.
(b) They can easily imagine that a rejected option was better.
(c) They choose more quickly.
(d) They are given poor-quality products.

Q20 Passage 3: The author describes the relationship between choice and well-being as

(a) a straight line rising steadily
(b) a line falling steadily
(c) completely random
(d) a curve that rises, flattens and may fall

Q21 Passage 3: Which of the following would the author most likely recommend to a government website for choosing health insurance?

(a) Offer a few clearly compared plans with a sensible default.
(b) List every plan available in the country.
(c) Allow only one plan for everyone.
(d) Remove all information about plans.

Q22 Passage 3: The phrase "plainly worse" indicates that the author

(a) is unsure whether no choice is bad
(b) prefers having no choice
(c) considers having no choice obviously undesirable
(d) thinks choice is irrelevant

Q23 Passage 3: Which of the following can be inferred from the passage?

(a) Shoppers never buy jam when given many options.
(b) All psychologists agree that choice is harmful.
(c) Products with fewer options are always cheaper.
(d) Comparing many options takes mental effort that some people prefer to avoid.

Q24 Passage 3: The tone of the passage is best described as

(a) alarmist
(b) analytical and measured
(c) humorous
(d) nostalgic

Q25 Passage 3: How is the passage organised?

(a) A common belief is stated, challenged with evidence, explained, qualified, and followed by a recommendation.
(b) A story is told and its moral explained.
(c) Two products are compared point by point.
(d) A history is traced from past to present.

19.8 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) to explain how behavioural economics challenges a traditional assumption and how its insights are used**

The passage presents the rational model, the behavioural challenge, its use in policy and the debate: **explain a challenge and its applications**. The author says the findings "do not mean that people are foolish".

Q2 **Answer: (a) the effect of framing on choices**

It shows identical options judged differently depending on description: **framing**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) increases the number of employees who save for a pension**

Defaults work because people tend to stay with them; employees can still opt out, so **more save**. "Forces all" is extreme.

Q4 **Answer: (d) usually work well but can mislead in predictable ways**

The passage states this directly: shortcuts that "**usually work well but can mislead in predictable ways**".

Q5 **Answer: (c) influence is unavoidable, so it should be transparent and in people's interest**

"Every choice is presented in some way, so the question is … how to do so **transparently and in their interest**."

Q6 **Answer: (c) balanced and appreciative**

The author explains its findings respectfully and presents both critics and supporters: **balanced and appreciative**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) An investor refuses to sell a falling share because selling would "make the loss real".**

Valuing losses more heavily than equal gains: avoiding the pain of **realising a loss** fits the principle.

Q8 **Answer: (b) influenced**

People are "swayed by how a choice is framed": **influenced**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) printed books and e-readers will each keep a role suited to their strengths**

The conclusion: "not the triumph of one format but **a division of labour** between them".

Q10 **Answer: (b) not fallen as much as many expected**

Despite predictions of their end, sales have **held up**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) A book is a physical object that readers interact with in many ways.**

The practical reason is the battery; the deeper reason is that a book is "not merely a container for text": **a physical object** readers use in many ways.

Q12 **Answer: (c) mildly sceptical**

"It is fashionable to declare" signals that the author doubts the claim: **mildly sceptical**.

Q13 **Answer: (d) leads to slightly better understanding**

Readers on paper "understand them **slightly better**".

Q14 **Answer: (d) very useful for travel and quick reference**

"For quick reference and travel they are **unbeatable**."

Q15 **Answer: (c) to prevent the reader from concluding that the author rejects screens**

It **qualifies** the argument for books so the reader does not think the author dismisses screens.

Q16 **Answer: (a) a mental sense of where things are in the text**

The physical book gives the mind a map: **a mental sense of position** in the text.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Beyond a point, more choice can reduce people's satisfaction and willingness to choose.**

The passage argues the relationship is a curve: **beyond a point** more choice hurts. It explicitly rejects "no choice".

Q18 **Answer: (b) provide evidence that challenges a common assumption**

It follows "Yet": it is **evidence against** the assumption that more choice is better.

Q19 **Answer: (b) They can easily imagine that a rejected option was better.**

Stated: "they can easily imagine that a **rejected option would have been better**".

Q20 **Answer: (d) a curve that rises, flattens and may fall**

Directly stated: "**not a straight line but a curve**".

Q21 **Answer: (a) Offer a few clearly compared plans with a sensible default.**

The author advises "a small number of well-chosen options": **a few clear plans**. One plan is "no choice", which the author calls worse.

Q22 **Answer: (c) considers having no choice obviously undesirable**

"Having no choice at all is **plainly worse**": obviously undesirable.

Q23 **Answer: (d) Comparing many options takes mental effort that some people prefer to avoid.**

The passage says effort rises with options and fewer people buy: people **avoid that effort**. The other options are extreme or out of scope.

Q24 **Answer: (b) analytical and measured**

It weighs evidence carefully and qualifies its claims ("This does not mean..."): **analytical and measured**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) A common belief is stated, challenged with evidence, explained, qualified, and followed by a recommendation.**

Belief → experiment → explanation → qualification → advice: the correct option describes **the whole structure**.

An inference is a small, safe step beyond the text; reject extreme, out-of-scope, distorted and opposite options. Read tone from word choice, purpose from the whole passage, and separate the author's view from reported views. For structure questions ask what a sentence does; for application questions match the principle, not the topic.

MODULE 20 · ADVANCED

Verbal critical reasoning

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Advanced**

Critical reasoning questions present a short argument and ask you to evaluate it. This module covers argument structure (premise, conclusion and assumption), the main question types (strengthen, weaken, assumption, inference, paradox and main point), statement-based questions with a language focus, and classifying sentences as facts, inferences or judgements, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

20.1 Argument structure
20.2 Question types
20.3 Statement-based questions in verbal sections
20.4 Fact, inference and judgement
20.5 Practice questions
20.6 Solutions

20.1 Argument structure

20.1.1 Premise, conclusion, assumption



EVERY ARGUMENT HAS THIS SHAPE

Part	Signal words	Example
Premise	because, since, given that, as shown by	Sales rose 20% after the advertising campaign.
Conclusion	therefore, so, thus, hence, clearly	Therefore, the campaign caused the rise.
Assumption	(unstated)	Nothing else (a festival season, a price cut) caused the rise.

SHORTCUT TRICK

To find the assumption, ask: "What must be true for the conclusion to follow from the premise?" Then test it with the negation: if the opposite would destroy the argument, it is a necessary assumption.

20.2 Question types

20.2.1 Strengthen and weaken

A **strengthener** makes the conclusion more likely (often by supporting the assumption or ruling out another cause); a **weakener** makes it less likely (often by showing another cause or attacking the assumption). The answer need not prove or disprove the conclusion, only change its likelihood.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Weaken

Argument: "Students who use our app score higher; so the app improves scores."

Weakener: "Students who choose the app were already the top scorers before using it." (another explanation: selection).

20.2.2 Assumption

The correct assumption is the unstated premise the argument **needs**. It is usually modest and close to the gap between premise and conclusion.

20.2.3 Inference

Which must be true if the statements are true? Choose the option directly supported by the text, as in reading comprehension. Avoid extreme words.

20.2.4 Paradox

Two facts seem to conflict ("Sales rose but profits fell"). The answer explains how both can be true ("Discounts were deep, so each sale earned less").

20.2.5 Main point

Identify the conclusion of the argument, not a premise and not a background fact.

20.3 Statement-based questions in verbal sections

20.3.1 Statement and assumptions, statement and conclusions

A statement is given with two assumptions (or conclusions). Decide which are implicit (assumptions) or which follow (conclusions). Read the exact words: "only", "all", "best" in the statement change what is assumed.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Statement and assumption

Statement: "Use brand X toothpaste for whiter teeth."

I. People want whiter teeth. (implicit: an advertiser assumes people care about it.)

II. Other toothpastes do not whiten teeth. (not implicit: the statement does not say "only X".)

Answer: only I is implicit.

20.4 Fact, inference and judgement

20.4.1 Classifying sentences

Type	Definition	Example
Fact	can be checked and verified	The company employs 4,000 people.
Inference	a conclusion drawn from facts	Since the office is always full, the company must be growing.
Judgement	an opinion, approval or disapproval	The company's new logo is ugly.

SHORTCUT TRICK

Judgement words: should, must (as advice), good, bad, best, unfair, beautiful. Inference words: so, therefore, must be (as a deduction), probably.

20.5 Practice questions

20.5.1 Basic level

Q1 "All the shops in the market were closed today. Therefore, today must be a public holiday." Which is the assumption?

(a) Shops close every Sunday.
(b) The market is very large.
(c) Shops in the market close only on public holidays.
(d) Public holidays are announced in advance.

Q2 "Our new advertisement was shown in May, and sales in May rose by 15 per cent. The advertisement clearly worked." Which, if true, most weakens the argument?

(a) Sales rise by about 15 per cent every May because of the wedding season.
(b) The advertisement was expensive.
(c) Customers liked the advertisement's music.
(d) Sales also rose in June.

Q3 Classify: "The bridge is 2 kilometres long."

(a) Inference **(b)** Fact **(c)** Judgement **(d)** None of these

Q4 Classify: "This is the most beautiful bridge in the country."

(a) Fact **(b)** Inference **(c)** None of these **(d)** Judgement

Q5 Classify: "Since the roads are wet, it must have rained last night."

(a) Fact **(b)** Judgement **(c)** Inference **(d)** None of these

Q6 "Riya studied for ten hours a day before the exam, so she will surely top the class." What is the conclusion?

(a) Riya studied ten hours a day.
(b) The exam was difficult.
(c) Riya will top the class.
(d) Studying is important.

Q7 Statement: "Please use the stairs; the lift is under repair." Which assumption is implicit? I. People can use the stairs. II. The lift will never be repaired.

(a) Only II is implicit
(b) Both are implicit
(c) Neither is implicit
(d) Only I is implicit

Q8 "Restaurants that display hygiene ratings attract more customers. So all restaurants should display them." Which, if true, most strengthens the argument?

(a) Some restaurants have poor ratings.
(b) Customers say they trust restaurants that are open about hygiene.
(c) Hygiene inspectors visit once a year.
(d) Restaurants are expensive to run.

20.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 "Since the company introduced flexible working hours, absenteeism has fallen by 30 per cent." Which conclusion is best supported?

(a) Flexible hours may have helped reduce absenteeism.
(b) Flexible hours are the only cause of lower absenteeism.
(c) All companies should introduce flexible hours.
(d) Employees now work fewer hours.

Q10 "The city built a new flyover, yet traffic jams on that route became worse within a year." Which best explains this?

(a) The flyover was built using steel.
(b) The faster route attracted many drivers who previously used other roads.
(c) Traffic police were present on the route.
(d) The flyover cost more than expected.

Q11 "Everyone who attended the workshop improved their presentation skills. Arjun improved his presentation skills. Therefore, Arjun attended the workshop." What is wrong with this reasoning?

(a) Others could have improved without attending the workshop.
(b) The workshop may have been too short.
(c) Arjun may not like presentations.
(d) Nothing is wrong with it.

Q12 "A survey of gym members found that 80 per cent exercise regularly. This shows that most people in the city exercise regularly." Which most weakens the argument?

(a) The survey was conducted online.
(b) Exercise is good for health.
(c) Gym members are not representative of the general population.
(d) The gym has a swimming pool.

Q13 Statement: "The government has decided to double the fine for traffic violations." Which conclusion follows? I. The government wants to reduce traffic violations. II. Traffic violations will disappear completely.

(a) Only II follows
(b) Both follow
(c) Neither follows
(d) Only I follows

Q14 "Online sales of the book rose, but the publisher's total revenue from the book fell." Which best explains this?

(a) The book received good reviews.
(b) The author wrote a sequel.
(c) Online shopping is popular.
(d) Online copies were sold at a much lower price than shop copies, and shop sales fell sharply.

Q15 "Children who eat breakfast perform better at school. Therefore, schools should provide free breakfast." Which is an assumption of this argument?

(a) All children dislike breakfast.
(b) Schools have large kitchens.
(c) Providing breakfast will lead some children who skip it to eat it.
(d) Breakfast is the only meal that matters.

Q16 "Most successful entrepreneurs wake up early. So, waking up early will make you a successful

entrepreneur." This argument is flawed because it

(a) confuses a common trait with a cause of success

(b) uses too many statistics

(c) ignores entrepreneurs who sleep late

(d) is based on personal experience

20.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 "Since the new manager joined, the team has met every deadline. Therefore, the new manager is responsible for the improvement." Which, if true, most strengthens this?

(a) The new manager has an MBA.

(b) The team is small.

(c) Deadlines were missed last year.

(d) Nothing else about the team's workload, members or tools changed during this period.

Q18 Classify: "The council should spend more on public parks."

(a) Fact **(b)** Judgement **(c)** Inference **(d)** None of these

Q19 Statement: "To attract the best talent, our firm offers salaries 20 per cent above the market average." Which assumption is implicit? I. Salary is a factor in where talented people choose to work. II. No other firm offers high salaries.

(a) Only II is implicit **(b)** Only I is implicit

(c) Both are implicit **(d)** Neither is implicit

Q20 "Crime in the district fell after street lights were installed. A council member argues that the lights caused the fall." Which, if true, most weakens the argument?

(a) The lights use LED bulbs.

(b) Residents like the new lights.

(c) Installing the lights took six months.

(d) Crime fell by the same amount in neighbouring districts without new lights.

Q21 What is the main point of the argument? "Many people believe that a university degree guarantees a good job. But employers increasingly value skills and experience. Graduates who also complete internships are hired faster. Students should therefore gain practical experience alongside their studies."

(a) Students should gain practical experience alongside their studies.

(b) A degree guarantees a good job.

(c) Employers value skills and experience.

(d) Internships lead to faster hiring.

Q22 "Every member of the committee voted for the proposal. Meera is a member of the committee." Which must be true?

(a) The proposal was accepted unanimously by the company.

(b) Meera wrote the proposal.

(c) Meera voted for the proposal.

(d) The committee has many members.

Q23 "Fewer people are buying newspapers. Yet the number of people reading news has never been higher." Which best reconciles these statements?

(a) Newspapers have become more expensive.

(b) Some newspapers have closed.

(c) People are busier than before.

(d) Most people now read news online rather than in print.

Q24 Statement: "Only students with 75 per cent attendance may sit the final exam." Which conclusion follows? I. Some students may not be allowed to sit the exam. II. All students have 75 per cent attendance.

(a) Only II follows

(b) Only I follows

(c) Both follow

(d) Neither follows

Q25 "Studies show that people who drink green tea live longer. Therefore, green tea extends life." Which, if true, most weakens the argument?

(a) Green tea drinkers in the studies also exercised more and smoked less.

(b) Green tea contains antioxidants.

(c) Green tea is popular in Asia.

(d) Some people dislike green tea.

20.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) Shops in the market close only on public holidays.**

The conclusion follows only if **shops close only on public holidays**; otherwise another reason (a strike) is possible.

Q2 **Answer: (a) Sales rise by about 15 per cent every May because of the wedding season.**

It offers **another cause** for the rise, so the advertisement may not be responsible.

Q3 **Answer: (b) Fact**

It can be measured and checked: **Fact**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) Judgement**

"Most beautiful" is an opinion: **Judgement**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) Inference**

A conclusion drawn from an observed fact: **Inference**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) Riya will top the class.**

The claim the speaker wants accepted: **Riya will top the class**. Ten hours a day is the premise.

Q7 **Answer: (d) Only I is implicit**

The request assumes people **can** use the stairs (I). "Under repair" implies it will be fixed, so II is not assumed.

Q8 **Answer: (b) Customers say they trust restaurants that are open about hygiene.**

It explains why ratings attract customers, supporting the recommendation: **customers trust openness**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) Flexible hours may have helped reduce absenteeism.**

A cautious causal link is supported; "only cause" and "all companies" go too far: **may have helped**.

Q10 **Answer: (b) The faster route attracted many drivers who previously used other roads.**

This resolves the paradox: **more drivers were attracted** (induced demand).

Q11 **Answer: (a) Others could have improved without attending the workshop.**

The argument reverses the condition: attending → improvement does not mean improvement → attending. **Other people could improve in other ways.**

Q12 **Answer: (c) Gym members are not representative of the general population.**

The sample is biased: **gym members are not representative** of all citizens.

Q13 **Answer: (d) Only I follows**

Raising fines aims to deter: I follows. "Disappear completely" is extreme: **only I**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) Online copies were sold at a much lower price than shop copies, and shop sales fell sharply.**

Lower online prices and falling shop sales **explain both facts**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) Providing breakfast will lead some children who skip it to eat it.**

The recommendation helps only if free breakfast **changes behaviour** for children who skip it.

Q16 **Answer: (a) confuses a common trait with a cause of success**

Correlation is not causation: it **treats a shared trait as a cause**.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Nothing else about the team's workload, members or tools changed during this period.**

It **rules out alternative causes**, strengthening the link.

Q18 **Answer: (b) Judgement**

"Should" expresses an opinion about what ought to be done: **Judgement**.

Q19 **Answer: (b) Only I is implicit**

High pay attracts talent only if salary matters: I. "Above average" does not assume no one else pays well: **only I**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) Crime fell by the same amount in neighbouring districts without new lights.**

If crime fell equally elsewhere, **something else** probably caused the fall.

Q21 **Answer: (a) Students should gain practical experience alongside their studies.**

The final recommendation, introduced by "therefore", is the conclusion: **students should gain practical experience**.

Q22 **Answer: (c) Meera voted for the proposal.**

Direct deduction: all members voted for it and Meera is a member, so **Meera voted for it**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) Most people now read news online rather than in print.**

Reading moved **online**, explaining both facts.

Q24 **Answer: (b) Only I follows**

The rule implies some may fall short: I follows; II is not stated: **only I**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) Green tea drinkers in the studies also exercised more and smoked less.**

Other healthy habits could explain the longer lives: **confounding factors**.

Find the premise, the conclusion and the gap between them (the assumption). Weakeners offer another cause or attack the assumption; strengtheners rule out other causes. Watch for correlation treated as causation, unrepresentative samples and reversed conditions. Facts can be checked, inferences are drawn from facts, judgements express opinions.

MODULE 21 · ADVANCED

Para summary and main idea

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Advanced**

Summary questions test your ability to identify the essence of a paragraph. This module covers separating main points from examples and details, eliminating summary options that are too narrow, too broad or distorted, writing one- or two-sentence summaries, and précis writing, followed by 25 solved questions.

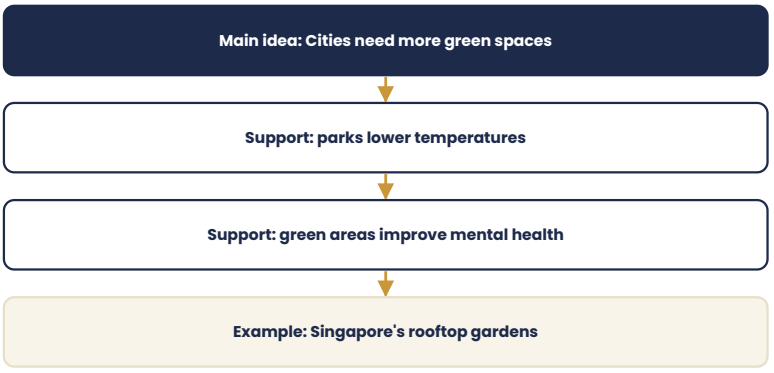
IN THIS MODULE

21.1 Finding the main idea
21.2 Para summary questions
21.3 Writing summaries
21.4 Practice questions
21.5 Solutions

21.1 Finding the main idea

21.1.1 Separating main points from examples and details

Each paragraph has one central point. Examples, statistics, quotations and anecdotes support it but are not the point itself. Strip them away and ask: "What is the author telling me about the topic?"



MAIN IDEA ABOVE, SUPPORT AND EXAMPLES BELOW

21.2 Para summary questions

21.2.1 Eliminating options that are too narrow, too broad or distorted

Wrong option type	What it does
Too narrow	covers only one example or detail
Too broad	makes a general claim beyond the paragraph

Wrong option type	What it does
Distorted	uses the paragraph's words but changes the meaning or the author's view
Extreme	turns "may" into "will" or "some" into "all"
Out of scope	adds an idea the paragraph does not discuss

SHORTCUT TRICK
The best summary covers the main idea and the key qualification ("but", "only if", "in most cases") in the paragraph. Missing the qualification is the most common trap.

21.3 Writing summaries

21.3.1 Summarising a passage in one or two sentences

Write the topic, the author's main claim about it and, if needed, the reason or qualification. Use your own words; leave out examples and figures.

WORKED EXAMPLE
One-sentence summary
Paragraph about remote work (Module 1). Summary: "Because remote work offers flexibility but weakens learning and collaboration, many firms have adopted a hybrid model."

21.3.2 Précis writing

A précis is a summary about one-third the length of the original, keeping its main ideas and order, in clear formal prose, without the writer's own comments. Steps: read twice; underline key points; write a draft without looking at the original; cut it to length; give it a title.

Do	Do not
keep the original order of ideas	add your own opinion
use your own words	copy whole sentences
write in the third person and past tense for reported views	include examples, figures or quotations
give a short title	exceed the word limit

21.4 Practice questions

21.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Regular reading improves vocabulary, concentration and general knowledge. It also reduces stress. Even twenty minutes a day can make a difference."

(a) Reading reduces stress.
(b) People should read for twenty minutes.
(c) Reading a little every day brings several mental benefits.
(d) Vocabulary is the most important skill.

Q2 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Plastic bags take hundreds of years to decompose. They pollute rivers and harm animals. Many countries have therefore banned or taxed them."

(a) Because plastic bags cause lasting pollution, many countries restrict them.
(b) Plastic bags harm animals.
(c) All countries have banned plastic bags.
(d) Rivers are polluted.

Q3 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Smartphones help us stay connected, but excessive use can disturb sleep and reduce face-to-face interaction. Moderation is key."

(a) Smartphones should be banned.
(b) Smartphones are useful but should be used in moderation.
(c) Smartphones disturb sleep.
(d) Smartphones keep us connected.

Q4 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Early humans lived as hunter-gatherers. The development of farming allowed them to settle in one place, which led to villages and eventually cities."

(a) Early humans were hunters.
(b) Cities are older than villages.
(c) Farming is difficult.
(d) Farming enabled settled life, leading to villages and cities.

Q5 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Exercise is often recommended for physical health. Recent studies show it also improves mood and memory, making it valuable for mental health as well."

(a) Exercise improves memory.
(b) Studies are often recent.
(c) Exercise benefits mental as well as physical health.
(d) Physical health is more important than mental health.

Q6 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Water covers most of the earth, yet only a small fraction is fresh water that people can use. As

populations grow, this limited supply is under increasing pressure."

(a) Water covers most of the earth.

(b) Populations are growing.

(c) Usable fresh water is scarce and growing populations strain it.

(d) There is plenty of water for everyone.

Q7 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Some think that talent alone leads to success. However, studies of top performers show that years of deliberate practice matter more than natural ability."

(a) Talent alone leads to success.

(b) Top performers are naturally gifted.

(c) Practice is boring.

(d) Deliberate practice contributes more to success than talent.

Q8 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Volunteering helps communities, but it also benefits volunteers. They gain skills, make friends and often report feeling happier."

(a) Volunteers make friends.

(b) Volunteering benefits both communities and volunteers themselves.

(c) Communities depend entirely on volunteers.

(d) Volunteering is a job.

21.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Electric vehicles produce no tailpipe emissions. However, if the electricity that charges them comes from coal, their overall environmental benefit is reduced. Their value therefore depends partly on how electricity is generated."

(a) The environmental benefit of electric vehicles depends on the source of their electricity.

(b) Electric vehicles produce no emissions.

(c) Coal should be banned.

(d) Electric vehicles are bad for the environment.

Q10 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Many companies once discouraged employees from using social media at work. Now some encourage it, finding that staff who share company news online act as informal ambassadors and attract customers."

(a) Social media wastes time at work.

(b) Some companies now see employees' social media use as a way to promote the business.

(c) All companies ban social media.

(d) Customers dislike social media.

Q11 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"A balanced diet does not require expensive foods. Lentils, seasonal vegetables and grains provide most of the nutrients a person needs at low cost."

(a) Healthy eating can be affordable.

(b) Lentils are cheap.

(c) Expensive foods are unhealthy.

(d) Grains contain all nutrients.

Q12 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Automation has replaced many routine jobs. At the same time, it has created demand for new roles in programming, maintenance and data analysis. The challenge is to train workers for these new jobs."

(a) Automation destroys all jobs.

(b) Programming is a well-paid job.

(c) Automation removes some jobs but creates others, so retraining workers is essential.

(d) Routine jobs are boring.

Q13 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Ancient monuments attract tourists and bring income to local communities. Yet large numbers of visitors can damage fragile structures. Careful management is needed to balance access and preservation."

(a) Tourists damage monuments.

(b) Monuments should be closed to the public.

(c) Tourism brings income.

(d) Tourism at monuments brings benefits but must be managed to protect them.

Q14 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Multitasking feels productive, but research shows that switching between tasks wastes time and increases errors. Focusing on one task at a time usually produces better results."

(a) Multitasking feels productive.

(b) Research is always correct.

(c) Errors are unavoidable.

(d) Doing one task at a time is usually more effective than multitasking.

Q15 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Libraries were once places only for borrowing books. Today many offer internet access, community events and courses, adapting to the changing needs of their users."

(a) Libraries lend books.

(b) Libraries are closing down.

(c) Libraries have expanded their services to meet changing needs.

(d) Internet access is free.

Q16 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Learning a second language improves job prospects. Less obviously, it also strengthens memory and problem-solving, and may delay mental decline in old age."

(a) Learning a second language offers both career and cognitive benefits.

(b) A second language improves job prospects.

(c) Old people should learn languages.

(d) Memory is important.

21.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Supporters of a four-day work week argue that it improves productivity and well-being. Trials in some firms have shown promising results. However, critics point out that it may not suit industries

such as healthcare, where services are needed every day. Its success may therefore depend on the sector."

(a) A four-day work week improves productivity everywhere.

(b) Healthcare workers need more rest.

(c) Critics oppose all changes to working hours.

(d) A four-day work week shows promise but may suit some sectors better than others.

Q18 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"The invention of the printing press is often credited with spreading literacy. But literacy rose slowly, because books remained expensive and schooling was limited. The press made mass literacy possible; social changes made it happen."

(a) The printing press immediately spread literacy.

(b) The printing press enabled mass literacy, but social changes were needed to achieve it.

(c) Books were expensive.

(d) Schooling caused the invention of the printing press.

Q19 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Many believe that a higher price signals higher quality. Marketers exploit this by pricing some products high to create an image of luxury, even when production costs are similar to cheaper rivals."

(a) Expensive products are always better.

(b) Marketers use high prices to suggest quality, exploiting a common belief.

(c) Production costs are similar for all products.

(d) Luxury goods are popular.

Q20 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Urban gardens are often praised for supplying fresh vegetables. Their greater value, however, may lie in bringing neighbours together and giving city children a chance to learn where food comes from."

(a) Urban gardens supply fresh vegetables.

(b) Children should work in gardens.

(c) Cities need more vegetables.

(d) The social and educational value of urban gardens may exceed their food value.

Q21 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Standardised tests are criticised for measuring only a narrow range of abilities. Defenders reply that they provide a common, objective yardstick across schools. The real question may be how test results are used, not whether tests exist."

(a) The debate over standardised tests should focus on how results are used.

(b) Standardised tests should be abolished.

(c) Tests measure all abilities.

(d) Schools are all the same.

Q22 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Fast fashion makes clothing cheap and trendy. Yet its low prices hide high costs: polluted rivers, waste in landfills and poor conditions for garment workers."

(a) Fast fashion is trendy.

(b) Garment workers are well paid.

(c) The low prices of fast fashion conceal serious environmental and social costs.

(d) Clothing should be expensive.

Q23 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Online reviews help shoppers make decisions, but some are fake, written by sellers or paid reviewers. Shoppers should look for detailed, balanced reviews and be wary of extreme praise."

(a) All online reviews are fake.

(b) Sellers write all reviews.

(c) Shoppers should ignore reviews.

(d) Online reviews are useful but shoppers should judge them carefully because some are fake.

Q24 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Space exploration is sometimes dismissed as a costly luxury. Yet technologies developed for space, from satellite weather forecasting to water purification, have brought practical benefits on earth."

(a) Space exploration is a costly luxury.

(b) Space exploration has produced practical benefits that justify more than its image as a luxury suggests.

(c) Water purification was invented in space.

(d) Weather forecasts are always accurate.

Q25 Choose the option that best summarises the paragraph.
"Cities that rely on a single industry are vulnerable: when that industry declines, unemployment rises sharply. Diversifying the local economy spreads risk and makes such cities more resilient."

(a) Cities become more resilient when their economies are diversified.

(b) Single industries always decline.

(c) Unemployment is rising everywhere.

(d) Cities should have one main industry.

21.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) Reading a little every day brings several mental benefits.**
The paragraph lists several benefits of brief daily reading: **the correct summary** covers them all. The others are too narrow or distorted.

Q2 **Answer: (a) Because plastic bags cause lasting pollution, many countries restrict them.**
Cause (lasting pollution) and response (restrictions): **the correct summary**. "All countries" is extreme.

Q3 **Answer: (b) Smartphones are useful but should be used in moderation.**
It balances benefit and harm and recommends moderation: **useful but in moderation**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) Farming enabled settled life, leading to villages and cities.**
The paragraph traces a chain from farming to cities: **farming enabled settled life**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) Exercise benefits mental as well as physical health.**

The key point is the extension to mental health: **mental as well as physical**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) Usable fresh water is scarce and growing populations strain it.**

Scarcity plus rising demand: **the correct summary**. The option claiming plenty of water contradicts the paragraph.

Q7 **Answer: (d) Deliberate practice contributes more to success than talent.**

The paragraph rejects the talent view in favour of practice: **practice matters more**. The talent-based options state the view being rejected.

Q8 **Answer: (b) Volunteering benefits both communities and volunteers themselves.**

The point is the two-way benefit: **both communities and volunteers**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) The environmental benefit of electric vehicles depends on the source of their electricity.**

The conclusion qualifies the benefit: **it depends on the electricity source**. Saying electric vehicles are bad for the environment distorts the paragraph.

Q10 **Answer: (b) Some companies now see employees' social media use as a way to promote the business.**

The shift in attitude and its reason: **a promotional benefit**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) Healthy eating can be affordable.**

The central claim: **a balanced diet can be cheap**. Saying expensive foods are unhealthy distorts it.

Q12 **Answer: (c) Automation removes some jobs but creates others, so retraining workers is essential.**

Both effects plus the challenge: **the correct summary**.

Q13 **Answer: (d) Tourism at monuments brings benefits but must be managed to protect them.**

Benefit, harm and the need for balance: **the correct summary**. Closing monuments goes beyond the paragraph.

Q14 **Answer: (d) Doing one task at a time is usually more effective than multitasking.**

The paragraph's recommendation: **focus on one task**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) Libraries have expanded their services to meet changing needs.**

The theme is adaptation: **expanded services**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) Learning a second language offers both career and cognitive benefits.**

Two kinds of benefit: **career and cognitive**.

Q17 **Answer: (d) A four-day work week shows promise but may suit some sectors better than others.**

Promising results plus the sector qualification: **the correct summary**. The healthcare option is too narrow; the others distort.

Q18 **Answer: (b) The printing press enabled mass literacy, but social changes were needed to achieve it.**

The final sentence states the balance: **enabled vs achieved**. The option saying the press immediately spread literacy is the view being corrected.

Q19 **Answer: (b) Marketers use high prices to suggest quality, exploiting a common belief.**

The point is the exploitation of a belief: **the correct summary**. The option about similar production costs overgeneralises a detail.

Q20 **Answer: (d) The social and educational value of urban gardens may exceed their food value.**

"Their greater value … may lie in": **social and educational value** exceeds food value.

Q21 **Answer: (a) The debate over standardised tests should focus on how results are used.**

The author's conclusion shifts the debate: **how results are used**.

Q22 **Answer: (c) The low prices of fast fashion conceal serious environmental and social costs.**

Cheap prices vs hidden costs: **the correct summary**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) Online reviews are useful but shoppers should judge them carefully because some are fake.**

Usefulness, the problem and the advice: **the correct summary**. The others are extreme.

Q24 **Answer: (b) Space exploration has produced practical benefits that justify more than its image as a luxury suggests.**

The author counters the "luxury" view with benefits: **the correct summary**. The water-purification option distorts an example.

Q25 **Answer: (a) Cities become more resilient when their economies are diversified.**

Problem and solution: **diversification builds resilience**.

Strip away examples and data to find the main point and its key qualification. Reject summaries that are too narrow, too broad, distorted, extreme or out of scope. In your own summaries keep the topic, the claim and the qualification, in your own words and in the original order.

MODULE 22 · ADVANCED

Text completion and sentence equivalence

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Advanced**

These advanced vocabulary-in-context questions are used in GRE-style tests and some top company tests. This module covers one-, two- and three-blank text completion, predicting the word before reading the options, sentence equivalence (choosing two words that give the same meaning), and a high-level word list with usage, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

22.1 Text completion
22.2 Sentence equivalence
22.3 Advanced vocabulary
22.4 Practice questions
22.5 Solutions

22.1 Text completion

22.1.1 One-, two- and three-blank sentences

Text completion sentences are longer and more complex than ordinary fill-in-the-blanks, and the options are harder words. The logic is the same: find the clue, the signal words and the direction of each blank.

22.1.2 Predicting the word before reading options



PREDICTION METHOD

WORKED EXAMPLE

Prediction

"Although the critic is usually _____, she praised the film enthusiastically." Signal: although (contrast) with "praised enthusiastically" → predict "harsh". Options: lenient, **caustic**, verbose, timid. "Caustic" (bitterly critical) matches.

22.2 Sentence equivalence

22.2.1 Choosing two words that give the same meaning

You choose **two** options that both fit the blank and produce sentences with the same meaning. The two correct words are usually near-synonyms. Beware of a synonym pair that does not fit the sentence: both

conditions must hold.

> **SHORTCUT TRICK**
> First predict the meaning, then find the pair of options closest to it. A word without a synonym among the options is almost never correct.

22.3 Advanced vocabulary

22.3.1 High-level word list with usage

Word	Meaning	Usage
ameliorate	make better	Measures to ameliorate poverty were introduced.
assiduous	diligent, hard-working	An assiduous researcher checked every source.
capricious	changing mood suddenly	The capricious weather ruined the picnic.
cogent	clear and convincing	She made a cogent case for reform.
ebullient	cheerful, full of energy	The ebullient host greeted every guest.
enervate	weaken, drain energy	The heat enervated the players.
equivocal	ambiguous, unclear	His equivocal reply satisfied no one.
exacerbate	make worse	Panic buying exacerbated the shortage.
laconic	using few words	His laconic reply was simply "No".
mitigate	lessen the severity of	Trees mitigate the effects of heat.
obdurate	stubbornly refusing to change	The obdurate official ignored all appeals.
pragmatic	practical, realistic	A pragmatic solution was found.
prosaic	dull, ordinary	The speech was prosaic and uninspiring.
reticent	reserved, not revealing much	He was reticent about his past.
sanguine	optimistic	She remained sanguine despite the setback.
spurious	false, not genuine	The report rested on spurious data.
tenacious	persistent, determined	A tenacious lawyer won the case.
ubiquitous	found everywhere	Smartphones are now ubiquitous.
vindicate	clear of blame; prove right	New evidence vindicated the accused.
zealous	very enthusiastic	A zealous volunteer worked all night.

22.4 Practice questions

22.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Fill in the blank: Although the novel was long, its _____ style made it easy to read.

(a) convoluted (b) obscure (c) lucid (d) turgid

Q2 Fill in the blank: The scientist's _____ approach meant she checked every result three times.

(a) meticulous (b) careless (c) hasty (d) casual

Q3 Fill in the blank: The medicine did not cure the disease but did _____ its symptoms.

(a) exacerbate (b) alleviate (c) cause (d) reveal

Q4 Fill in the blank: Smartphones have become so _____ that it is hard to find anyone without one.

(a) rare (b) expensive (c) obsolete (d) ubiquitous

Q5 Fill in the blank: His _____ reply, a single word, gave no hint of his feelings.

(a) verbose (b) emotional (c) laconic (d) lengthy

Q6 Fill in the blank: Despite repeated failures, the _____ inventor kept trying.

(a) indolent (b) timid (c) tenacious (d) fickle

Q7 Sentence equivalence: choose the two words that complete the sentence with the same meaning. "The manager was _____ about the project's chances, expecting it to succeed despite the problems."

(a) sanguine and pessimistic (b) gloomy and optimistic
(c) doubtful and wary (d) sanguine and optimistic

Q8 Fill in the blank: The witness's _____ answers made the jury doubt her honesty.

(a) candid (b) evasive (c) precise (d) frank

22.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Fill in the blanks: The new policy was meant to _____ the housing shortage, but it only _____ it.

(a) ease … worsened (b) worsen … eased
(c) ease … solved (d) ignore … ended

Q10 Sentence equivalence: "The professor's lectures were so _____ that many students fell asleep."

(a) tedious and fascinating (b) tedious and monotonous
(c) riveting and gripping (d) brief and concise

Q11 Fill in the blank: Far from being _____, the CEO was known for her simple lifestyle.

(a) extravagant (b) frugal (c) modest (d) humble

Q12 Fill in the blank: The report was based on _____ data; none of its figures could be verified.

(a) reliable (b) accurate (c) spurious (d) authentic

Q13 Fill in the blanks: The once _____ town became _____ after the factory closed and people moved away.

(a) quiet … deserted
(b) bustling … crowded
(c) deserted … lively
(d) bustling … deserted

Q14 Sentence equivalence: "His _____ refusal to listen to advice cost the company dearly."

(a) obstinate and flexible
(b) willing and eager
(c) polite and courteous
(d) obstinate and obdurate

Q15 Fill in the blank: The evidence _____ the scientist, proving that her controversial theory had been right all along.

(a) discredited (b) confused (c) vindicated (d) ignored

Q16 Fill in the blank: The author's _____ remarks hinted at criticism without stating it directly.

(a) oblique (b) blunt (c) explicit (d) direct

22.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Fill in the blanks: Critics called the plan _____, arguing that it ignored practical realities; its supporters insisted it was _____ and could be implemented easily.

(a) pragmatic … idealistic
(b) realistic … practical
(c) cautious … careful
(d) idealistic … pragmatic

Q18 Sentence equivalence: "The minister's _____ statement could be read as either support or opposition."

(a) equivocal and clear
(b) equivocal and ambiguous
(c) decisive and firm
(d) ambiguous and explicit

Q19 Fill in the blank: Panic buying only _____ the shortage, emptying shelves even faster.

(a) mitigated (b) exacerbated (c) resolved (d) reduced

Q20 Fill in the blanks: Although the speaker was usually _____, today she was _____, answering every question in just a few words.

(a) reticent … talkative
(b) quiet … laconic
(c) verbose … garrulous
(d) talkative … reticent

Q21 Sentence equivalence: "The heat was so _____ that even the athletes could barely move."

(a) enervating and draining
(b) enervating and invigorating
(c) refreshing and pleasant
(d) mild and gentle

Q22 Fill in the blanks: The _____ of the evidence was so great that even the _____ members of the jury were convinced.

(a) lack … sceptical
(b) weight … credulous
(c) weight … sceptical
(d) absence … doubtful

Q23 Fill in the blanks: The company's growth was _____ rather than steady: years of rapid expansion alternated with sudden _____.

(a) consistent … slumps
(b) erratic … growth
(c) gradual … booms
(d) erratic … slumps

Q24 Sentence equivalence: "Her _____ efforts to finish the report impressed even her demanding

manager."

(a) assiduous and careless
(b) assiduous and diligent
(c) lazy and indolent
(d) casual and diligent

Q25 Fill in the blanks: Far from _____ the conflict, the mediator's blunt comments only _____ the tension between the two sides.

(a) resolving … heightened
(b) worsening … reduced
(c) resolving … eased
(d) causing … ended

22.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) lucid**
"Although … long" contrasts with "easy to read": the style must be clear: **lucid**.

Q2 **Answer: (a) meticulous**
Checking every result three times: **meticulous**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) alleviate**
"Did not cure … but did" a positive lesser effect: **alleviate**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) ubiquitous**
Found everywhere: **ubiquitous**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) laconic**
A single word: **laconic**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) tenacious**
"Despite repeated failures … kept trying": **tenacious**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) sanguine and optimistic**
Expecting success: **sanguine and optimistic** are near-synonyms that both fit.

Q8 **Answer: (b) evasive**
Answers that create doubt about honesty avoid the point: **evasive**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) ease … worsened**
"Meant to … but only" shows contrast: **ease … worsened**.

Q10 **Answer: (b) tedious and monotonous**
Lectures that put students to sleep: **tedious and monotonous**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) extravagant**

"Far from being X" contrasts with a simple lifestyle: **extravagant**.

Q12 **Answer: (c) spurious**

Unverifiable figures: **spurious** (false, not genuine).

Q13 **Answer: (d) bustling … deserted**

"Once" + a change after people left: **bustling … deserted**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) obstinate and obdurate**

Refusing advice stubbornly: **obstinate and obdurate**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) vindicated**

Proved right: **vindicated**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) oblique**

Hinting without stating: **oblique** (indirect).

Q17 **Answer: (d) idealistic … pragmatic**

Critics say it ignores reality (idealistic); supporters say it is practical (pragmatic): **idealistic … pragmatic**.

Q18 **Answer: (b) equivocal and ambiguous**

Readable two ways: **equivocal and ambiguous**.

Q19 **Answer: (b) exacerbated**

Emptying shelves faster made it worse: **exacerbated**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) talkative … reticent**

"Although usually … today" signals a contrast; few words today: **talkative … reticent**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) enervating and draining**

Heat that leaves athletes barely moving: **enervating and draining**.

Q22 **Answer: (c) weight … sceptical**

Strong evidence ("so great") convinced even the doubters: **weight … sceptical**. "Credulous" jurors would need no convincing.

Q23 **Answer: (d) erratic … slumps**

"Rather than steady" and alternating periods: **erratic … slumps**.

Q24 **Answer: (b) assiduous and diligent**

Impressive hard work: **assiduous and diligent**.

Q25 **Answer: (a) resolving … heightened**

"Far from X, … only Y" means Y is the opposite effect: **resolving … heightened**.

Cover the options, find the clue and the signal word, predict your own word, then match. In multi-blank questions decide the surer blank first. In sentence equivalence, choose the two near-synonyms that both fit the sentence. Learn advanced words with a usage sentence each.

MODULE 23 · ADVANCED

Confusing words, spelling and word usage

Minimum duration **1 day** | Level **Advanced**

Many test questions target words that look or sound alike. This module covers the commonly confused pairs, homophones and homonyms, the main spelling rules, commonly misspelled words, correctly-spelt-word questions, the same word used in different senses, incorrect usage, and common Indian English expressions with their standard professional alternatives, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

23.1 Commonly confused words
23.2 Homophones and homonyms
23.3 Spelling
23.4 Word usage
23.5 Indian English vs standard English
23.6 Practice questions
23.7 Solutions

23.1 Commonly confused words

23.1.1 The essential pairs

Pair	Difference	Example
affect / effect	verb: influence / noun: result	Stress affects sleep. The effect was clear.
accept / except	receive / excluding	I accept your offer. Everyone except Ravi came.
advice / advise	noun / verb	Good advice. I advise you to rest.
compliment / complement	praise / complete	She paid me a compliment. The colours complement each other.
principal / principle	main, head of school / basic rule	the principal reason; a man of principle
stationary / stationery	not moving / writing materials	a stationary car; office stationery
lose / loose	misplace / not tight	Don't lose your keys. A loose shirt.
then / than	time / comparison	Finish, then leave. Taller than me.
its / it's	possessive / it is	The dog wagged its tail. It's late.
their / there / they're	possessive / place / they are	Their car is there; they're inside.
practice / practise	noun / verb (British)	Football practice. Practise daily.
personal / personnel	private / staff	personal opinion; HR personnel

WATCH OUT
A spell-checker will not catch these errors, because both words are real words. Proofread for them specifically.

23.2 Homophones and homonyms

Homophones sound the same but differ in spelling and meaning: *weather / whether, cite / site / sight, brake / break, fair / fare, peace / piece, steal / steel, wait / weight*. **Homonyms** are spelt and pronounced the same but have different meanings: *bank* (river bank / money bank), *bat* (animal / cricket bat), *right* (correct / direction).

23.3 Spelling

23.3.1 Common spelling rules

Rule	Examples	Exceptions
i before e except after c (when the sound is "ee")	believe, achieve; receive, ceiling	seize, weird, either, neither, protein
drop silent e before a vowel suffix	make → making, hope → hoping	keep e after soft c/g: noticeable, courageous
double the final consonant (short vowel, stressed)	run → running, begin → beginning	visit → visiting (unstressed)
y → i before a suffix (consonant + y)	happy → happiness, carry → carried	keep y before -ing: carrying
-ful has one l	careful, beautiful, hopeful	(but fully: carefully)

23.3.2 Commonly misspelled words

Correct	Correct	Correct	Correct
accommodate	necessary	separate	definitely
embarrass	occurrence	recommend	committee
conscience	conscious	maintenance	privilege
guarantee	millennium	questionnaire	entrepreneur
receive	achieve	acquire	colleague
business	calendar	government	environment

23.3.3 Correctly spelled word questions

SHORTCUT TRICK
Look at doubled letters (accommodate: cc and mm; necessary: one c, double s), at -ance/-ence endings, and at silent letters. When two options differ only in one letter, say the word slowly by syllables: sep-a-rate, def-i-nite-ly.

23.4 Word usage

23.4.1 Same word used in different senses

A word may be a noun, a verb or an adjective with different meanings: *The **book** is new* (noun) / *Please **book** a ticket* (verb). Questions may ask in which sentence a word has a given meaning, or is used wrongly.

23.4.2 Incorrect usage of a word in sentences

× Incorrect	✓ Correct	Rule
He is very much clever.	He is very clever.	"very much" with comparatives or verbs
Myself Ravi from Pune.	I am Ravi from Pune.	reflexive pronoun misuse
I am having two brothers.	I have two brothers.	stative verb
She gave me a good advice.	She gave me good advice.	uncountable noun

23.5 Indian English vs standard English

23.5.1 Common Indianisms and professional alternatives

Indian English	Standard professional alternative
Please do the needful.	Please take the necessary action. / Could you please …?
The meeting is preponed.	The meeting has been brought forward.
Kindly revert back.	Please reply. / I look forward to your reply.
I have a doubt.	I have a question.
Myself Priya.	I am Priya. / My name is Priya.
Pass out from college (graduate)	Graduate from college
Today morning	This morning
Cousin brother / cousin sister	Cousin
Out of station	Out of town / travelling
Discuss about	Discuss

In global workplaces, colleagues and clients may not understand these expressions, so use the standard forms in emails and meetings.

23.6 Practice questions

23.6.1 Basic level

Q1 Choose the correct word: The new policy will _____ all employees.

(a) effect (b) afect (c) affect (d) affection

Q2 Choose the correct word: Everyone _____ Mohan attended the party.

(a) except (b) accept (c) expect (d) excess

Q3 Choose the correct word: My father gave me some useful _____.

(a) advise (b) advice (c) advices (d) adviser

Q4 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) neccessary (b) necesary (c) neccesary (d) necessary

Q5 Choose the correct word: The dog chased _____ tail.

(a) it's (b) its' (c) its (d) it is

Q6 Choose the correct word: She is taller _____ her brother.

(a) then (b) that (c) than (d) thon

Q7 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) seperate (b) separete (c) seprate (d) separate

Q8 Choose the correct word: _____ going to the cinema tonight.

(a) Their (b) They're (c) There (d) Theyr

23.6.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Choose the correct word: The _____ of the school announced a holiday.

(a) principal (b) principle (c) principel (d) princple

Q10 Choose the correct word: Make sure your seat belt is not _____.

(a) lose (b) loose (c) loss (d) lost

Q11 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) accommodation (b) accomodation (c) acommodation (d) accommadation

Q12 Choose the professional alternative to "Please do the needful."

(a) Please do the necessary needful. (b) Do the needful at the earliest.
(c) Please take the necessary action. (d) Kindly revert back with the needful.

Q13 Choose the correct word: The wine and cheese _____ each other perfectly.

(a) compliment (b) complimentary (c) compliance (d) complement

Q14 Choose the correct word: The car was _____ at the traffic light.

(a) stationery (b) stationed (c) stationer (d) stationary

Q15 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) embarass (b) embaress (c) embarrass (d) emberrass

Q16 Choose the correct homophone: I could not decide _____ to go or stay.

(a) whether (b) weather (c) wether (d) whither

23.6.3 Advanced level

Q17 Choose the standard English form of: "The meeting has been preponed to 10 a.m."

(a) The meeting has been postponed to 10 a.m.
(b) The meeting has been pre-poned to 10 a.m.
(c) The meeting has been advanced back to 10 a.m.
(d) The meeting has been brought forward to 10 a.m.

Q18 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) occurence (b) occurrence (c) ocurrence (d) occurrance

Q19 In which sentence is "fair" used incorrectly?

(a) The referee was fair to both teams. (b) He paid the bus fair in cash.
(c) We visited the trade fair. (d) She has fair hair.

Q20 Choose the correct word: All _____ must wear identity cards in the factory.

(a) personal (b) personals (c) persona (d) personnel

Q21 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) conscientious (b) conscientous (c) consciencious (d) concientious

Q22 Choose the standard alternative to "I have a doubt about the assignment."

(a) I am doubting about the assignment.
(b) I have doubts on the assignment.
(c) I have a question about the assignment.
(d) My doubt is regarding about the assignment.

Q23 Choose the correct word: You must _____ every day to become a good pianist.

(a) practice (b) practised (c) practicing (d) practise

Q24 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) millenium (b) millennium (c) milennium (d) millenneum

Q25 In which sentence is "site" used correctly?

(a) The construction site was closed for the holiday.
(b) Please site the source of your quotation.
(c) The sunset was a beautiful site.
(d) He lost his site in an accident.

23.7 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) affect**

Verb meaning "influence": **affect**.

Q2 **Answer: (a) except**

"Excluding": **except**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) advice**

Noun (uncountable): **advice**.

Q4 **Answer: (d) necessary**

Necessary: one c, double s.

Q5 **Answer: (c) its**

Possessive: **its** ("it's" means "it is").

Q6 **Answer: (c) than**

Comparison: **than**.

Q7 **Answer: (d) separate**

Separate: sep-a-rate.

Q8 **Answer: (b) They're**

"They are": **They're**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) principal**

Head of a school: **principal**.

Q10 **Answer: (b) loose**

"Not tight": **loose**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) accommodation**

Accommodation: double c and double m.

Q12 **Answer: (c) Please take the necessary action.**

Standard English: **Please take the necessary action** (or ask specifically for what is needed).

Q13 **Answer: (d) complement**

"Complete each other": **complement**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) stationary**

"Not moving": **stationary**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) embarrass**

Embarrass: double r and double s.

Q16 **Answer: (a) whether**

"If": **whether**.

Q17 **Answer: (d) The meeting has been brought forward to 10 a.m.**

"Prepone" is Indian English; the standard is **brought forward**. "Postponed" means the opposite.

Q18 **Answer: (b) occurrence**

Occurrence: double c, double r, -ence.

Q19 **Answer: (b) He paid the bus fair in cash.**

Money paid for a journey is a **fare**, so "bus fair" is wrong.

Q20 **Answer: (d) personnel**

Staff: **personnel**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) conscientious**

Conscientious (careful and diligent): con-sci-en-tious.

Q22 **Answer: (c) I have a question about the assignment.**

In standard English, "doubt" means uncertainty about truth; for a query use **question**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) practise**

British spelling: verb **practise**, noun "practice".

Q24 **Answer: (b) millennium**

Millennium: double l, double n.

Q25 **Answer: (a) The construction site was closed for the holiday.**

Site means a place; "cite" means quote, "sight" means view or vision.

Learn the confused pairs (affect/effect, accept/except, principal/principle, stationary/stationery, its/it's, than/then, complement/compliment, personal/personnel) and homophones. Watch double letters in spelling (accommodate, embarrass, occurrence, millennium). In professional English replace Indianisms: do the needful, prepone, revert back, I have a doubt.

MODULE 24 · ADVANCED

Written English tests: email and essay writing

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Advanced**

Several companies, including TCS NQT and AMCAT-based recruiters, test written English directly through emails and essays. This module covers email structure, formal tone and politeness, using all the cue words, common email tasks, word limits and timing; essay structure, opinion, argumentative and descriptive essays, two-minute planning and common topics; and writing quality and how automated scoring tools assess it, with model answers and 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

24.1 Email writing
24.2 Essay writing
24.3 Writing quality
24.4 Practice questions
24.5 Solutions

24.1 Email writing

24.1.1 Structure: subject line, greeting, body, closing, signature



THE PARTS OF A PROFESSIONAL EMAIL

24.1.2 Formal tone and politeness

Instead of	Write
I want the report today.	Could you please send the report by today evening? / by the end of the day?
You did not send the file.	I have not yet received the file.
Sorry for the trouble.	I apologise for the inconvenience caused.
Hi buddy,	Dear Ravi,
Pls revert ASAP!!!	I would appreciate an early reply.
Do the needful.	Please let me know if you need anything further.

24.1.3 Using all given cue words or phrases

Test tasks often give cue words or phrases that must appear in your email (for example: "meeting, postpone, client visit, new date, inconvenience"). Use **every** cue, in a natural sentence, roughly in the order given; automated scorers check for them.

24.1.4 Common email tasks

MODEL EMAIL · REQUEST (cue words in bold)

Subject: Request to reschedule project review meeting

Dear Ms. Sharma,

I am writing to request that Thursday's project review meeting be **postponed**. A **client visit** has been scheduled for the same time, and I am required to attend.

Could we move the meeting to Friday at 11 a.m.? I will circulate the updated agenda by Wednesday evening. I apologise for any **inconvenience** this may cause.

Thank you for your understanding.

Regards,
Arjun Mehta
Software Engineer, Payments Team

MODEL EMAIL · COMPLAINT

Subject: Complaint about delayed laptop delivery (Order 48213)

Dear Customer Support Team,

I placed an order for a laptop on 3 March (Order 48213), with delivery promised by 8 March. As of today, 14 March, it has not arrived, and the tracking page has not been updated for five days.

I would be grateful if you could confirm the current status of the order and a firm delivery date. If the laptop cannot be delivered within three days, please arrange a full refund.

I look forward to your prompt reply.

Yours faithfully,
Neha Iyer
+91 98XXX XXXXX

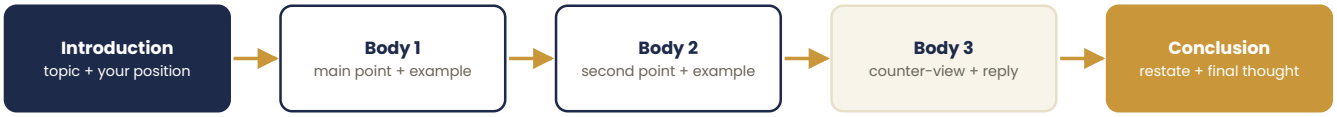
Task	Key content
Request	what, why, by when; polite modal (could, would)
Complaint	facts (dates, order number), effect, the remedy you want; firm but polite
Apology	acknowledge, explain briefly, fix, prevent recurrence
Leave application	dates, reason, handover arrangements
Status update	what is done, what is pending, risks, next steps

24.1.5 Word limits and time management

Typical limits are 50–150 words in 10–15 minutes. Spend 2 minutes planning (cue words, order), 8 minutes writing, and 2–3 minutes checking grammar, cue words and word count. Going far over or under the limit costs marks.

24.2 Essay writing

24.2.1 Introduction, body paragraphs, conclusion



THE FIVE-PARAGRAPH ESSAY

24.2.2 Opinion, argumentative and descriptive essays

Type	Purpose	Key feature
Opinion	give and support your view	"In my view..." with reasons
Argumentative	weigh both sides and reach a conclusion	a fair counter-argument and a reply

Type	Purpose	Key feature
Descriptive	describe a place, person, event or process	vivid, ordered details

24.2.3 Planning in two minutes

Write the topic, decide your position, list two or three points with one example each, and note a counter-argument. These notes become your paragraphs.

24.2.4 Common topics

MODEL ESSAY · ARGUMENTATIVE

Topic: Should social media be regulated? (about 200 words)

Social media has transformed how people communicate, learn and do business. However, its power to spread misinformation and harm young users has led to calls for regulation. In my view, sensible regulation is necessary.

First, false information spreads faster online than corrections do. During health emergencies, rumours have led people to take dangerous remedies. Clear rules requiring platforms to label or remove harmful falsehoods would protect the public.

Second, children are especially vulnerable to addictive design and cyberbullying. Age checks and limits on targeted advertising to minors would reduce these risks.

Critics argue that regulation threatens free speech. This concern is valid, which is why rules should be narrow, transparent and subject to appeal, targeting clearly harmful content rather than unpopular opinions.

In conclusion, social media brings great benefits, but leaving it entirely unregulated puts the public at risk. Balanced regulation can preserve free expression while making online spaces safer.

Other frequent topics: technology and jobs, artificial intelligence, online versus classroom learning, environmental protection, work from home, the role of youth in nation building.

24.3 Writing quality

24.3.1 Grammar, cohesion, vocabulary range and clarity

Criterion	What examiners look for
Grammar	correct tenses, agreement, articles, punctuation
Cohesion	linking words: firstly, moreover, however, as a result, in conclusion
Vocabulary	precise, varied words; no slang or text-speak
Clarity	short, clear sentences; one idea per paragraph
Task response	answers the question; uses all cues; within the word limit

24.3.2 How automated scoring tools assess writing

Automated tools check spelling and grammar, sentence variety, vocabulary range, paragraph structure, relevance to the prompt (keywords and cue words) and length. They cannot be fooled by long, rare words used wrongly: clear, correct, relevant writing scores best.

WATCH OUT

Never memorise a whole essay and force it onto a different topic. Off-topic answers score very low even if the English is good.

24.4 Practice questions

24.4.1 Basic level

Q1 Which subject line is most appropriate for an email asking for two days' leave?

(a) Hi
(b) Urgent!!! Please read
(c) Leave request for 12–13 June
(d) Something I wanted to ask you about

Q2 Which greeting is most appropriate in a formal email to a manager named Anita Rao?

(a) Dear Ms. Rao,
(b) Hey Anita!
(c) Yo,
(d) Dear Sir/Madam Anita,

Q3 Which closing is most suitable for a formal email?

(a) Cheers mate,
(b) Best regards,
(c) Bye!!
(d) Love,

Q4 Choose the most polite way to ask for a document.

(a) Send me the agreement now.
(b) Why haven't you sent the agreement?
(c) I need the agreement, do the needful.
(d) Could you please send me the signed agreement by Friday?

Q5 Which sentence best states the purpose at the start of an email?

(a) Hope you are doing well and your family is fine and the weather is good.
(b) As you may or may not know, many things happen.
(c) I am writing to inform you that the server upgrade has been rescheduled to Saturday.
(d) This is regarding about the thing we discussed.

Q6 In an essay, where should your main position usually be stated?

(a) only in the conclusion
(b) in the middle of the second paragraph
(c) in the introduction
(d) nowhere; let the reader guess

Q7 Which is the best replacement for "Pls revert ASAP!!!" in a formal email?

(a) Revert back fast.
(b) Reply quick pls.
(c) ASAP revert!!!
(d) I would appreciate an early reply.

Q8 Which linking word best introduces a contrasting point in an essay?

(a) Moreover,
(b) However,
(c) Firstly,
(d) For example,

24.4.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Cue words: "order, damaged, replacement, photographs". Which sentence uses all four naturally?

(a) The order arrived damaged, so I have attached photographs and request a replacement.
(b) My order was good and I want photographs.
(c) Damaged replacement order photographs please.
(d) I am attaching photographs of my holiday.

Q10 Which sentence is the best apology in a professional email?

(a) Sorry sorry sorry for the late report.

(b) I apologise for the delay in sending the report; it will reach you by 5 p.m. today.

(c) The report is late, it happens.

(d) It was not my fault the report was late.

Q11 Which is the best order for the body of a complaint email?

(a) facts of the problem → its effect → the remedy requested

(b) remedy → greeting → facts

(c) threat → facts → apology

(d) effect → closing → facts

Q12 Which opening line suits an argumentative essay on "Should homework be banned?"

(a) Homework is homework and everyone knows it.

(b) I hate homework.

(c) Homework divides opinion: some see it as essential practice, others as an unnecessary burden.

(d) In this essay I will write an essay about homework.

Q13 What should a leave application email include?

(a) only the reason

(b) a long personal story

(c) the dates of your previous leaves

(d) the dates, the reason and the handover arrangements

Q14 A task asks for an email of 100–120 words. What is the best approach?

(a) Write 300 words to show your skill.

(b) Write 40 words to save time.

(c) Ignore the limit; content is all that matters.

(d) Plan briefly, write about 110 words, then check grammar, cues and word count.

Q15 Which sentence is most appropriate in a status-update email?

(a) Things are going fine I guess.

(b) Work is happening.

(c) The login module is complete; payment integration is 70 per cent done and on track for Friday.

(d) We are working very very hard on everything.

Q16 Which conclusion is best for an essay arguing that public transport should be improved?

(a) Better public transport would reduce congestion and pollution, making our cities healthier places to live.

(b) That is all I have to say.

(c) Public transport is a type of transport.

(d) In conclusion, cars are blue and red.

24.4.3 Advanced level

Q17 Which is the most appropriate way to mention an attachment?

(a) Attached is attached.

(b) PFA.

(c) I am attaching something, open it.

(d) Please find the revised proposal attached for your review.

Q18 Which sentence avoids an Indianism?

(a) Please do the needful.

(b) Please let me know if you need anything further.

(c) Kindly revert back.

(d) I will update you today evening.

Q19 What is the main purpose of a counter-argument paragraph in an argumentative essay?

(a) to change your position at the end

(b) to show fairness by presenting the other side and replying to it

(c) to fill space

(d) to confuse the reader

Q20 Which feature do automated writing scorers NOT reward?

(a) correct grammar and spelling

(b) relevance to the prompt

(c) clear paragraph structure

(d) long, rare words used incorrectly

Q21 Which sentence best improves cohesion between two paragraphs about the benefits and drawbacks of AI?

(a) Despite these benefits, AI also raises serious concerns.

(b) AI.

(c) Now another paragraph begins.

(d) Also AI exists.

Q22 A complaint email should be

(a) angry and threatening

(b) vague and emotional

(c) firm, factual and polite

(d) very long with many exclamation marks

Q23 Which is the best two-minute essay plan for "Is online learning as effective as classroom learning?"

(a) Start writing immediately without a plan.

(b) List twenty random words.

(c) Write the conclusion first and stop.

(d) Position: partly; points: flexibility, access, but less interaction; example for each; conclusion: blended learning.

Q24 Choose the most formal sentence.

(a) Confirm the meeting time.

(b) I would be grateful if you could confirm the meeting time.

(c) Can u confirm the time?

(d) Gimme the time of the meeting.

Q25 Which signature block is most professional?

(a) Priya Nair | Business Analyst, Finance Systems | +91 98XXX XXXXX

(b) Priya :)
(c) — P
(d) Your friend Priya

24.5 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) Leave request for 12–13 June**
A good subject line is short and specific: **Leave request for 12–13 June**.

Q2 **Answer: (a) Dear Ms. Rao,**
Formal: **Dear Ms. Rao,**.

Q3 **Answer: (b) Best regards,**
Best regards (or Regards, Yours sincerely) suits formal emails.

Q4 **Answer: (d) Could you please send me the signed agreement by Friday?**
A polite modal and a clear deadline: **Could you please send … by Friday?**

Q5 **Answer: (c) I am writing to inform you that the server upgrade has been rescheduled to Saturday.**
The opening should state the purpose directly: **I am writing to inform you that…**

Q6 **Answer: (c) in the introduction**
State your position in the **introduction** and restate it in the conclusion.

Q7 **Answer: (d) I would appreciate an early reply.**
Formal and polite: **I would appreciate an early reply.**

Q8 **Answer: (b) However,**
However introduces contrast; moreover adds, firstly orders, for example illustrates.

Q9 **Answer: (a) The order arrived damaged, so I have attached photographs and request a replacement.**
Only the correct option uses **all four cues** in a natural, meaningful sentence.

Q10 **Answer: (b) I apologise for the delay in sending the report; it will reach you by 5 p.m. today.**
A good apology acknowledges, gives a fix and a time: **the correct option**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) facts of the problem → its effect → the remedy requested**
Present **facts, effect, remedy** in that order.

Q12 **Answer: (c) Homework divides opinion: some see it as essential practice, others as an unnecessary burden.**

It introduces the topic and both sides: a strong argumentative opening.

Q13 **Answer: (d) the dates, the reason and the handover arrangements**

Dates, reason and **handover** plans let the manager decide quickly.

Q14 **Answer: (d) Plan briefly, write about 110 words, then check grammar, cues and word count.**

Stay within the limit and leave time to check: **plan, write, check**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) The login module is complete; payment integration is 70 per cent done and on track for Friday.**

A status update gives **specific progress and next steps**.

Q16 **Answer: (a) Better public transport would reduce congestion and pollution, making our cities healthier places to live.**

A good conclusion restates the position and gives a final thought.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Please find the revised proposal attached for your review.**

Clear and polite: **Please find … attached for your review.** Abbreviations like "PFA" are too informal for many readers.

Q18 **Answer: (b) Please let me know if you need anything further.**

"Do the needful", "revert back" and "today evening" are Indian English; the standard form is **Please let me know if you need anything further.**

Q19 **Answer: (b) to show fairness by presenting the other side and replying to it**

It shows balance and strengthens your case by **answering the other side**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) long, rare words used incorrectly**

Misused rare words lower scores; tools reward correct, relevant, well-structured writing.

Q21 **Answer: (a) Despite these benefits, AI also raises serious concerns.**

A linking sentence that refers back and points forward: **Despite these benefits…**

Q22 **Answer: (c) firm, factual and polite**

Firm, factual and polite complaints get the best results.

Q23 **Answer: (d) Position: partly; points: flexibility, access, but less interaction; example for each; conclusion: blended learning.**

A position, points with examples and a conclusion form a usable plan.

Q24 **Answer: (b) I would be grateful if you could confirm the meeting time.**

Formal register: **I would be grateful if you could…**

Q25 **Answer: (a) Priya Nair | Business Analyst, Finance Systems | +91 98XXX XXXXX**

Name, role and contact form a **professional signature**.

Emails: specific subject, formal greeting, purpose first, one idea per paragraph, a clear action, polite closing and signature; use every cue word and stay within the limit. Essays: plan in two minutes, state your position in the introduction, support each point with an example, answer the counter-view, and conclude. Clear, correct, relevant writing scores best.

MODULE 25 · ADVANCED

Spoken English assessments: Versant and SVAR

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Advanced**

Many service companies use automated spoken-English tests during hiring. This module covers the sections of the Versant English Test and SVAR, preparation for each task (reading aloud, sentence repetition, sentence building, short answers, story retelling, passage reconstruction, listening and free speaking), pronunciation, word stress, fluency, pace and pauses, reducing mother-tongue influence, and technical preparation, followed by 25 solved questions.

IN THIS MODULE

25.1 Test formats
25.2 Section-wise preparation
25.3 Speaking skills
25.4 Technical preparation
25.5 Practice questions
25.6 Solutions

25.1 Test formats

Formats are updated from time to time; check the latest official information before your test. The tables show the typical task types.

25.1.1 Versant English Test sections

Task	What you do	Skill tested
Reading	read sentences aloud	pronunciation, fluency
Repeats	repeat sentences exactly as heard	listening, memory, pronunciation
Sentence builds	rearrange word groups into a sentence	grammar, listening
Conversations / short answers	answer a simple question in a word or phrase	listening, vocabulary
Typing / sentence completion / dictation (some versions)	complete or type sentences	grammar, spelling
Passage reconstruction / story retelling	retell a short passage in your own words	comprehension, fluency
Open questions	speak for about 30–40 seconds on a topic	fluency, organisation

25.1.2 SVAR (AMCAT spoken English) sections

Task	What you do
Read aloud	read sentences clearly
Listen and repeat	repeat sentences
Sentence building / jumbled phrases	form a correct sentence from phrases heard
Short answer questions	answer simple questions
Listening comprehension	answer questions about a passage or conversation
Free speech	speak on a topic for about 45 seconds

25.2 Section-wise preparation

25.2.1 Reading aloud

Read at a natural pace, pause at commas and full stops, and pronounce every word fully, including word endings (-s, -ed). Do not rush: clarity scores higher than speed.

25.2.2 Sentence repetition

Listen to the whole sentence, then repeat it immediately with the same words and rhythm. If you miss a word, keep going rather than stopping; a smooth, nearly complete repetition scores better than a broken one.

25.2.3 Sentence building

You hear three phrases in jumbled order ("to the market / she went / yesterday"). Find the subject and verb first, then attach the rest: "She went to the market yesterday."

25.2.4 Short answer questions

Answer briefly and directly, often in one word: "What do you use to cut paper?" → "Scissors." Do not explain.

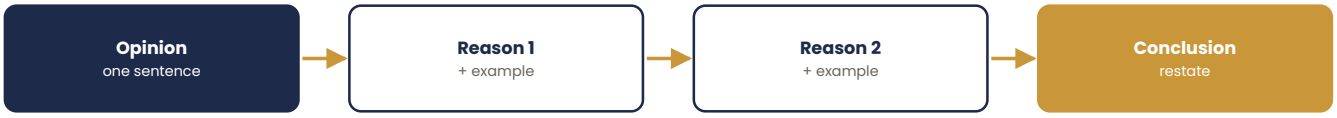
25.2.5 Story retelling and passage reconstruction

Note who, what, where, what went wrong and how it ended. Retell in the same order using simple past tense; include the key details and the ending.

25.2.6 Listening comprehension

Listen for the main idea, numbers, names and the reason for an action. Questions often ask "why" or "what will happen next".

25.2.7 Open questions and free speaking



A 40-SECOND ANSWER STRUCTURE

Example: "Do you prefer working in a team or alone?" → "I prefer working in a team. Firstly, team members bring different ideas; in my college project, a classmate's suggestion saved us a week. Secondly, sharing work reduces stress. So, although I can work alone, I enjoy teamwork more."

25.3 Speaking skills

25.3.1 Pronunciation and word stress

Word	Stress (capitals)	Common error
develop	de-VEL-op	DE-ve-lop
photograph / photographer	PHO-to-graph / pho-TOG-ra-pher	same stress for both
record (noun / verb)	REC-ord / re-CORD	no difference
determine	de-TER-mine	de-ter-MINE
comfortable	COMF-ta-ble	com-FOR-ta-ble
hotel	ho-TEL	HO-tel

25.3.2 Fluency, pace and pauses

Speak at a steady pace of about 130–150 words a minute. Pause at natural phrase boundaries, not in the middle of a phrase. Avoid fillers ("umm", "basically", "like"); a short silent pause is better.

25.3.3 Reducing mother-tongue influence

Common influence	Practice
v / w confusion (vest / west)	v: upper teeth on lower lip; w: rounded lips
adding vowels (iskool, istation)	start directly with the consonant cluster: school, station
s / sh confusion (sip / ship)	practise minimal pairs aloud
dropping final sounds (ask → as)	exaggerate endings when practising
flat intonation	rise for yes/no questions, fall for statements

SHORTCUT TRICK
Record yourself reading a news paragraph every day and listen back. You will hear errors you do not notice while speaking.

25.4 Technical preparation

25.4.1 Headset, microphone and a quiet environment

Use a headset with a microphone held slightly to the side of your mouth to avoid breathing noise. Test it in advance, choose a quiet room, close other applications, and keep water nearby. Speak at normal volume; shouting distorts the recording.

25.5 Practice questions

25.5.1 Basic level

Q1 In a "sentence repetition" task, what should you do if you miss one word?

(a) stop and say "sorry"
(b) start the sentence again from the beginning
(c) continue smoothly with the rest of the sentence
(d) stay silent

Q2 Short answer: "What do we use to tell the time?"

(a) a clock
(b) to tell the time we use many things like phones and so on
(c) time
(d) a calendar

Q3 Arrange the phrases into a sentence: "in the morning / the bus / I catch"

(a) The bus I catch in the morning.
(b) I catch the bus in the morning.
(c) In the morning the bus catch I.
(d) Catch I the bus in the morning.

Q4 Where is the stress in the word "develop"?

(a) DE-ve-lop
(b) de-ve-LOP
(c) equal on all syllables
(d) de-VEL-op

Q5 Which habit most improves reading-aloud scores?

(a) reading as fast as possible
(b) reading in a very low voice
(c) reading at a natural pace with clear word endings
(d) skipping difficult words

Q6 Which is the best microphone position?

(a) directly touching the lips
(b) on the desk far from the mouth
(c) slightly to the side of the mouth, a few centimetres away
(d) inside the shirt

Q7 What is the stress pattern of "record" used as a verb ("Please record the meeting")?

(a) REC-ord
(b) RE-CORD equally
(c) no stress
(d) re-CORD

Q8 Short answer: "If a shop is closed, can you buy things there?"

(a) Yes.
(b) No.
(c) Maybe on Sundays.
(d) Shops are good.

25.5.2 Intermediate level

Q9 Arrange the phrases: "has been delayed / due to rain / the flight"

(a) The flight has been delayed due to rain.
(b) Due to rain has been delayed the flight.
(c) The flight due to rain delayed has been.
(d) Has been delayed the flight due to rain.

Q10 Which pronunciation of "school" reflects mother-tongue influence?

(a) skool **(b)** iskool
(c) sku:l **(d)** school with a clear "sk" start

Q11 Which is the best structure for a 40-second open question answer?

(a) opinion, two reasons with examples, conclusion
(b) a long story with no conclusion
(c) one word
(d) a list of unrelated facts

Q12 Which filler should you avoid in free speaking?

(a) a short silent pause **(b)** "Firstly"
(c) "umm, basically, like" **(d)** "In conclusion"

Q13 In story retelling, which tense is usually used?

(a) simple future **(b)** present perfect continuous
(c) future perfect **(d)** simple past

Q14 Where is the stress in "photographer"?

(a) PHO-to-gra-pher **(b)** pho-to-GRA-pher
(c) pho-to-gra-PHER **(d)** pho-TOG-ra-pher

Q15 What intonation is normal at the end of a yes/no question such as "Are you ready?"

(a) falling **(b)** flat **(c)** rising **(d)** whispered

Q16 Which of these is the best answer to the open question "Describe your favourite hobby"?

(a) My favourite hobby is cycling. It keeps me fit, and on weekend rides I explore new places. That is why I enjoy it so much.
(b) Cycling.
(c) Hobbies are activities that people do.
(d) I do not have time to answer.

25.5.3 Advanced level

Q17 A Versant "story retelling" passage: "Ravi left home early for an interview, but his scooter broke down. He took an auto, reached just in time and got the job." Which retelling is best?

(a) Ravi got a job.
(b) A scooter broke down somewhere.
(c) Ravi took an auto to buy a scooter.
(d) Ravi left early for an interview, but his scooter broke down. He took an auto, arrived just in time and got the job.

Q18 Which pair is a minimal pair for practising the v/w distinction?

(a) vest – best (b) vest – west (c) west – rest (d) vine – fine

Q19 Which pace is most suitable for spoken-English tests?

(a) about 60 words per minute (b) about 130–150 words per minute
(c) about 250 words per minute (d) as fast as possible

Q20 Listening comprehension: "The 9 a.m. train to Chennai has been cancelled due to a signal failure. Passengers may take the 10:30 train at no extra cost." Why was the train cancelled?

(a) bad weather (b) a strike
(c) lack of passengers (d) a signal failure

Q21 Same announcement: What can passengers do?

(a) take the 10:30 train at no extra cost (b) get a full refund only
(c) wait for the next day (d) take a bus

Q22 Where is the stress in "comfortable"?

(a) com-FOR-ta-ble (b) com-for-TA-ble (c) COMF-ta-ble (d) com-for-ta-BLE

Q23 Which sentence would most likely be scored as fluent?

(a) I have, umm, worked on, like, two, basically, projects.
(b) I... have... worked... on... two... projects.
(c) Projects two worked I have.
(d) I have worked on two projects, and both taught me how to manage deadlines.

Q24 What is the best response if you do not understand a short-answer question in an automated test?

(a) ask the computer to repeat it
(b) give your best brief guess and move on
(c) explain that you did not understand at length
(d) remain silent for the whole time

Q25 Which preparation routine is most effective in the week before a Versant test?

(a) daily recorded practice of reading aloud, repeats and 40-second answers, then listening back
(b) reading grammar books silently
(c) memorising long essays
(d) watching films without speaking

25.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) continue smoothly with the rest of the sentence**

Fluency matters: **keep going**; a smooth, nearly complete repeat scores better.

Q2 **Answer: (a) a clock**

Answer briefly and directly: **a clock** (or a watch).

Q3 **Answer: (b) I catch the bus in the morning.**

Subject + verb + object + time: **I catch the bus in the morning.**

Q4 **Answer: (d) de-VEL-op**

Stress falls on the second syllable: **de-VEL-op**.

Q5 **Answer: (c) reading at a natural pace with clear word endings**

Clarity and natural pace: **pronounce every word fully**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) slightly to the side of the mouth, a few centimetres away**

To the side avoids breathing noise while picking up the voice clearly.

Q7 **Answer: (d) re-CORD**

Noun: REC-ord; verb: **re-CORD**.

Q8 **Answer: (b) No.**

A closed shop cannot sell: **No**.

Q9 **Answer: (a) The flight has been delayed due to rain.**

Subject (the flight) + verb + reason: **The flight has been delayed due to rain.**

Q10 **Answer: (b) iskool**

Adding a vowel before "sk" (**iskool**) is a common influence; start directly with the consonants.

Q11 **Answer: (a) opinion, two reasons with examples, conclusion**

Opinion → reasons with examples → conclusion keeps the answer organised.

Q12 **Answer: (c) "umm, basically, like"**

Fillers reduce fluency scores; a short **silent pause** is better. "Firstly" and "In conclusion" are useful signposts.

Q13 **Answer: (d) simple past**

Stories are retold in the **simple past**.

Q14 **Answer: (d) pho-TOG-ra-pher**

Stress moves to the second syllable: **pho-TOG-ra-pher**.

Q15 **Answer: (c) rising**

Yes/no questions usually **rise** at the end.

Q16 **Answer: (a) My favourite hobby is cycling. It keeps me fit, and on weekend rides I explore new places. That is why I enjoy it so much.**

It states the hobby, gives reasons with a detail and concludes, in fluent full sentences.

Q17 **Answer: (d) Ravi left early for an interview, but his scooter broke down. He took an auto, arrived just in time and got the job.**

It keeps the key events in order and the ending; the others omit or distort them.

Q18 **Answer: (b) vest – west**

vest – west differ only in v/w.

Q19 **Answer: (b) about 130–150 words per minute**

A natural, steady pace of **130–150 wpm**.

Q20 **Answer: (d) a signal failure**

Stated reason: **a signal failure**.

Q21 **Answer: (a) take the 10:30 train at no extra cost**

The announcement says they may take **the 10:30 train at no extra cost**.

Q22 **Answer: (c) COMF-ta-ble**

Usually three syllables with stress on the first: **COMF-ta-ble**.

Q23 **Answer: (d) I have worked on two projects, and both taught me how to manage deadlines.**

Smooth phrasing without fillers or broken pauses.

Q24 **Answer: (b) give your best brief guess and move on**

Automated tests do not repeat; a brief best guess is better than silence.

Q25 **Answer: (a) daily recorded practice of reading aloud, repeats and 40-second answers, then listening back**

Spoken tests reward speaking practice: **record, listen, improve**.

Speak clearly at a natural pace, pronounce word endings and stress correctly, and pause only at phrase boundaries. Repeat smoothly, build sentences from the subject and verb, give short answers briefly, retell stories in order in the past tense, and structure open answers as opinion, reasons, examples and conclusion. Test your headset and choose a quiet room.

MODULE 26 · ADVANCED

Exam strategy, mock tests and company-specific preparation

Minimum duration **2 days** | Level **Advanced**

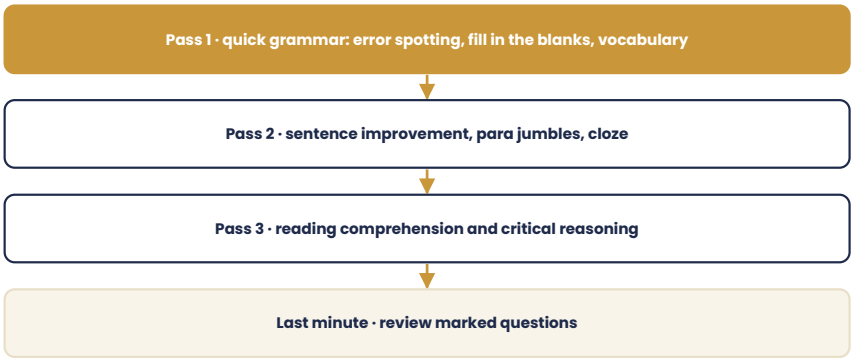
The final module turns verbal skills into consistent test performance. It covers the order of attempting question types, time per passage and per grammar question, when to guess and skip, negative marking, the verbal patterns of TCS NQT, Infosys, Accenture, Wipro, Cognizant, Capgemini, AMCAT, eLitmus and bank exams, weekly mocks with an error log, and a long-term improvement plan, followed by a 25-question mixed verbal mock test, fully solved.

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26.1 Strategy

26.1.1 Order of attempting question types



A THREE-PASS ORDER FOR A VERBAL SECTION

If the test locks sections or forces a fixed order, apply the same idea within each screen: answer quick items first and mark long ones for later where the platform allows.

26.1.2 Time per RC passage and per grammar question

Question type	Target time
Error spotting, synonym, antonym, one-word	20–30 seconds
Fill in the blank, sentence improvement	30–45 seconds
Para jumble, cloze blank	45–75 seconds

Question type	Target time
RC passage (reading)	2–3 minutes for 300–400 words
RC question	30–60 seconds each
Critical reasoning	60–90 seconds

26.1.3 When to guess and when to skip

Skip a question when you cannot name the rule or find evidence after twice the target time. Return if time remains. If there is no negative marking, never leave a question blank.

26.1.4 Handling negative marking

With a penalty of one-third or one-quarter of a mark for a wrong answer, a pure guess among four options is roughly break-even. Eliminating even one option makes guessing worthwhile; eliminating two makes it clearly profitable.

26.2 Company-specific patterns

Patterns change from year to year; always read the latest official notice. The table gives the broad shape of each test.

Test	Verbal content	Priority modules
TCS NQT	verbal ability: grammar, vocabulary, RC, sentence arrangement; email writing in some rounds	10–16, 24
Infosys	harder verbal section: para jumbles, RC, sentence correction, vocabulary	11, 14, 16, 19
Accenture	English ability: grammar, vocabulary, RC	10–13, 16
Wipro	verbal ability and an essay	10–16, 24
Cognizant	English comprehension: RC, grammar, vocabulary	10–12, 16
Capgemini	English communication: grammar, vocabulary, RC	10–13, 16
AMCAT	English comprehension module: vocabulary, grammar, RC	8, 10–12, 16
eLitmus	verbal section: RC-heavy, critical reasoning, grammar	16, 19, 20
Bank and government exams	error spotting, cloze, para jumbles, fillers, RC	10–14, 16

26.2.1 TCS NQT verbal ability and email writing

Expect fast grammar and vocabulary items and short passages. For email tasks, practise using all cue words within the word limit (Module 24).

26.2.2 Infosys verbal ability

The Infosys verbal section is known for difficult para jumbles and longer passages. Practise mandatory pairs and RC inference (Modules 14 and 19).

26.2.3 Accenture, Wipro, Cognizant and Capgemini English sections

These tests mix grammar, vocabulary and comprehension at moderate difficulty. Speed and accuracy on Modules 10–13 and 16 matter most.

26.2.4 AMCAT English and eLitmus verbal

AMCAT is adaptive and scored by module; eLitmus has a negative-marking scheme and favours reading and reasoning. Avoid wild guesses in eLitmus.

26.2.5 Bank and government exam English

Bank and SSC papers are dominated by error spotting, cloze tests, para jumbles and fillers, with one or two passages. Rule-based grammar practice pays off.

26.3 Mock tests and analysis

26.3.1 Weekly sectional and full mocks

Take one timed verbal mock each week. After each, sort every error into a category and note the rule. Retake the questions you got wrong a week later without looking at the solutions.

26.3.2 Error log by question type

Date	Type	My answer → correct	Rule
—	Error spotting	(c) → (b)	"Each of" takes a singular verb
—	RC inference	extreme option → cautious option	Reject "always / all" in inference answers
—	Para jumble	QPRS → QRPS	Pronoun "it" needs its noun before it

26.4 Long-term improvement plan

26.4.1 Daily reading, weekly writing, monthly vocabulary review

Frequency	Activity
Daily	20 minutes of editorial or long-form reading; 10 new words in your deck; one grammar rule revised
Weekly	one timed mock; one email and one essay written and checked; error log updated
Monthly	review the whole vocabulary deck; reread the error log and retest weak areas; one full spoken practice test recorded

26.5 Mixed mock test

26.5.1 Section A level

Q1 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *The number of students / who passed the exam / have increased this year.*

(a) The number of students **(b)** who passed the exam
(c) have increased this year. **(d)** No error

Q2 Choose the synonym of METICULOUS.

(a) careless **(b)** hasty **(c)** careful **(d)** clumsy

Q3 Choose the antonym of SCARCE.

(a) plentiful **(b)** rare **(c)** few **(d)** limited

Q4 Fill in the blank: She has been working here _____ 2021.

(a) for **(b)** since **(c)** from **(d)** by

Q5 One word for: a person who loves books.

(a) bibliographer **(b)** librarian **(c)** philatelist **(d)** bibliophile

Q6 What does "call it a day" mean?

(a) name a day **(b)** start work early
(c) stop working for the day **(d)** take a holiday

Q7 Find the part of the sentence that contains an error. *Neither the manager / nor the employees / was aware of the change.*

(a) Neither the manager **(b)** nor the employees
(c) was aware of the change. **(d)** No error

Q8 Improve the underlined part (or choose "No improvement"): "I look forward <u>to hear</u> from you."

(a) for hearing **(b)** to have heard **(c)** to hearing **(d)** No improvement

26.5.2 Section B level

Q9 Rearrange: P: However, the plan was too costly. Q: The town wanted a new bridge. R: Engineers repaired the old one instead. S: It was finished in six months.

(a) PQRS **(b)** QRPS **(c)** QPSR **(d)** QPRS

Q10 Fill in the blanks: Although the task seemed _____, it turned out to be _____.

(a) easy … simple **(b)** daunting … manageable
(c) daunting … impossible **(d)** simple … trivial

Q11 Book : Author :: Statue : ?

(a) Sculptor **(b)** Stone **(c)** Museum **(d)** Chisel

Q12 Change to passive: "They will announce the results tomorrow."

(a) The results would be announced tomorrow.
(b) The results will be announced tomorrow.

(c) The results will announce tomorrow.

(d) The results are announced tomorrow.

Q13 Change to indirect speech: He said, "I am leaving now."

(a) He said that he was leaving then.

(b) He said that he is leaving now.

(c) He said that I was leaving then.

(d) He said that he was leaving now.

Q14 Choose the correctly spelt word.

(a) reccomend (b) recomend (c) recommend (d) reccommend

Q15 Choose the correct word: The heavy rain will _____ the harvest.

(a) effect (b) afect (c) effectuate (d) affect

Q16 Which sentence does not belong? (choose the odd one)

(a) Cycling improves heart health.

(b) It also strengthens the leg muscles.

(c) Regular cyclists report better mood.

(d) The first bicycle was made of wood.

26.5.3 Section C level

Q17 "Since the new canteen menu was introduced, fewer employees eat outside. Therefore, employees prefer the new menu." Which, if true, most weakens the argument?

(a) The new menu includes salads.

(b) The canteen was painted.

(c) At the same time, the company shortened the lunch break to 20 minutes.

(d) Employees like variety.

Q18 Choose the best summary: "Many people think creativity is a rare gift. Research suggests instead that it grows with practice, curiosity and exposure to varied ideas."

(a) Creativity can be developed rather than being only an inborn gift.

(b) Creativity is a rare gift.

(c) Research is useful.

(d) Only artists are creative.

Q19 *Read the passage and answer Q19 to Q22.*

Cities around the world are experimenting with "car-free days", when central streets are closed to private vehicles for a day. Supporters point to cleaner air, quieter streets and families cycling where traffic usually roars. Shopkeepers were initially worried about losing customers, but many reported busier days as people strolled and stopped more often. Critics argue that a single day changes little and that permanent improvements to public transport matter more. Both sides, however, agree on one thing: a city designed only for cars is not a city designed for people.

What is the main idea of the passage?

(a) Car-free days harm shopkeepers.

(b) All cities have banned cars.

(c) Public transport is useless.

(d) Car-free days show the benefits of designing cities for people, though their impact is debated.

Q20 Passage: What were shopkeepers initially worried about?

(a) higher rents
(b) losing customers
(c) noise from cyclists
(d) traffic jams

Q21 Passage: What do critics argue?

(a) Car-free days should happen every day.
(b) Permanent public-transport improvements matter more than a single day.
(c) Cycling is dangerous.
(d) Air pollution is not a problem.

Q22 Passage: On what do both sides agree?

(a) Car-free days should be banned.
(b) Shops always benefit.
(c) Cars should be removed from all cities.
(d) A city designed only for cars is not designed for people.

Q23 Which is the most appropriate subject line for an email requesting a deadline extension?

(a) Request to extend report deadline to 15 May
(b) Help!!!
(c) Report
(d) Can u give me more time pls

Q24 Choose the standard English alternative to "Kindly revert back at the earliest."

(a) Kindly revert back soon.
(b) Revert back ASAP.
(c) I look forward to your early reply.
(d) Do the needful and revert.

Q25 Where is the stress in "determine"?

(a) DE-ter-mine
(b) de-ter-MINE
(c) equal on all syllables
(d) de-TER-mine

26.6 Solutions

Q1 **Answer: (c) have increased this year.**
"The number of" takes a singular verb: **has increased**.

Q2 **Answer: (c) careful**
Meticulous = very careful about detail.

Q3 **Answer: (a) plentiful**
Scarce = in short supply; opposite: **plentiful**.

Q4 **Answer: (b) since**
A point in time: **since**.

Q5 **Answer: (d) bibliophile**

Biblio (book) + phile (lover): **bibliophile**.

Q6 **Answer: (c) stop working for the day**

To call it a day is to **stop working**.

Q7 **Answer: (c) was aware of the change.**

With "neither … nor", the verb agrees with the nearer subject "employees": **were aware**.

Q8 **Answer: (c) to hearing**

"Look forward to" + gerund: **to hearing**.

Q9 **Answer: (d) QPRS**

Q (plan) → P (However, too costly) → R (repair instead) → S (It = the repair) finished: **QPRS**.

Q10 **Answer: (b) daunting … manageable**

"Although" demands contrast: **daunting … manageable**.

Q11 **Answer: (a) Sculptor**

Worker – product: an author writes a book; a **sculptor** makes a statue.

Q12 **Answer: (b) The results will be announced tomorrow.**

Future: will + **be** + past participle; the general doer is dropped.

Q13 **Answer: (a) He said that he was leaving then.**

Present continuous → past continuous; now → **then**.

Q14 **Answer: (c) recommend**

Recommend: one c, double m.

Q15 **Answer: (d) affect**

Verb meaning "influence": **affect**.

Q16 **Answer: (d) The first bicycle was made of wood.**

The others are about the health benefits of cycling; the bicycle's history is the odd one.

Q17 **Answer: (c) At the same time, the company shortened the lunch break to 20 minutes.**

A shorter break gives **another reason** for eating in.

Q18 **Answer: (a) Creativity can be developed rather than being only an inborn gift.**

The passage corrects the "rare gift" view: **creativity can be developed**.

Q19 **Answer: (d) Car-free days show the benefits of designing cities for people, though their impact is debated.**

It presents benefits, the debate and a shared conclusion: **the correct option**.

Q20 **Answer: (b) losing customers**

"Shopkeepers were initially worried about **losing customers**."

Q21 **Answer: (b) Permanent public-transport improvements matter more than a single day.**

Stated directly in the passage.

Q22 **Answer: (d) A city designed only for cars is not designed for people.**

The final sentence states the agreement.

Q23 **Answer: (a) Request to extend report deadline to 15 May**

Specific and formal: **Request to extend report deadline to 15 May**.

Q24 **Answer: (c) I look forward to your early reply.**

"Revert back" is redundant Indian English; use **I look forward to your early reply**.

Q25 **Answer: (d) de-TER-mine**

Stress on the second syllable: **de-TER-mine**.

Attempt quick grammar and vocabulary items first, then medium items, then RC and critical reasoning; keep to target times; guess only after eliminating options when there is negative marking. Learn your target company's pattern, take weekly mocks, keep an error log, and read, write and revise vocabulary on a fixed schedule.